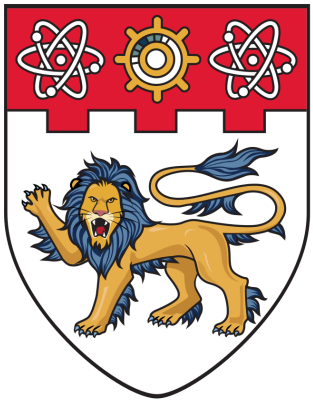


NANYANG TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
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Moving-Horizon-Estimation-Enabled Nonlinear Model Predictive Control for Quadrotors under Abrupt Payload Changes

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SCHOOL OF MECHANICAL AND AEROSPACE ENGINEERING

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A DISSERTATION SUBMITTED IN PARTIAL FULFILMENT OF
THE REQUIREMENTS FOR THE DEGREE OF
MASTER OF SCIENCE IN [PROGRAMME]

2026

Statement of Originality

I hereby certify that the work embodied in this thesis is the result of original research and has not been submitted for a higher degree to any other University or Institution.

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Abstract

Delivery quadrotors change mass and roll and pitch inertia abruptly when they grasp or release a parcel, and a predictive controller that keeps the unloaded model plans with the wrong hover thrust and the wrong rotational response. This dissertation studies how far such a vehicle can adapt to a centred rigid payload from ordinary flight signals, and how it should decide that a commanded release has physically happened.

For a payload grasped on the thrust axis, the inertia increment is the reduced mass times the square of a nominal vertical arm, so the composite mass is the only payload quantity to be identified online. A moving horizon estimator identifies it from odometry and the thrust reconstructed from measured rotor speeds. In its deployed form it keeps only velocity and mass as states and takes the measured attitude as a known input, so that the less reliable rotational model has no path to the mass. One health-gated estimate updates a nonlinear model predictive controller continuously; a separate lifecycle accepts a release only when evidence confirms that the payload has left.

The system is evaluated in PX4/Gazebo software-in-the-loop simulation with acados solvers, using a frozen, block-randomised cohort of 120 flight attempts (118 eligible) at three payload–speed conditions, under nominal release and under a detachment held back for 4 s after the command, together with smaller ablations and a second frozen campaign of 312 flights.

All 118 eligible releases were accepted, 2.3 s to 3.2 s after physical detachment. Under delayed detachment the evidence-gated arms never accepted a release

while the payload was still attached, whereas accepting at the command did so in every flight. Running the same confirmation throughout carry, however, produced 114 false acceptances in 20 of 32 flights at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$; arming it only after the release command removed them without lengthening the delay. Replacing the mass evidence with a force balance from rotor speeds and the inertial unit, enabled by the command or by a watchdog armed on airborne load, produced no false acceptance in 240 flights, detected 24 of 24 loads lost without a command and accepted none of 24 jammed releases; a $10\,\%$ thrust-map error in it, however, either missed every release or disabled the watchdog for the lighter payload. In loaded hover the mass estimate was within $0.5\,\%$ of truth, but in sustained manoeuvre at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ it was biased low and periodically collapsed toward the bare airframe. A residual specific force improved tracking without reducing that bias; against a fixed-parameter controller the interface reduced loaded tracking error, but estimating the mass gave no consistent benefit over the residual alone.

The evidence is from simulation only, and no hardware validity is claimed. Both the estimator and the release detector depend on thrust-map calibration, and neither was compared against a change-detection baseline.

Keywords: quadrotor; nonlinear model predictive control; moving horizon estimation; online mass estimation; payload inertia; release confirmation; software-in-the-loop.

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I would like to thank my supervisor, [Supervisor Name], for guidance throughout this dissertation. I am also grateful to the members of [Laboratory or Research Group] for their technical discussions and support with the simulation and flight-control platform.

Acronyms

Acronym	Meaning
CoM	Centre of Mass
CRLB	Cramér–Rao Lower Bound
CUSUM	Cumulative Sum (change-detection procedure)
EKF	Extended Kalman Filter
ENU	East–North–Up
ESC	Electronic Speed Controller
FLU	Front–Left–Up
FSM	Finite State Machine
INDI	Incremental Nonlinear Dynamic Inversion
IQR	Interquartile Range
LPF	Low-Pass Filter
MAD	Median Absolute Deviation
MHE	Moving Horizon Estimation
MPC	Model Predictive Control
NLP	Nonlinear Programming
NMPC	Nonlinear Model Predictive Control
OCP	Optimal Control Problem
PX4	PX4 autopilot software stack
QP	Quadratic Programming
RK4	Fourth-order Runge–Kutta integration
RMS(E)	Root Mean Square (Error)
ROS	Robot Operating System
RTI	Real-Time Iteration
SITL	Software-in-the-Loop
SQP	Sequential Quadratic Programming
UAV	Unmanned Aerial Vehicle
ZOH	Zero-Order Hold

Symbols

Symbol	Definition
States and inputs	
$\boldsymbol{p}, \boldsymbol{v}$	Position and velocity in the world frame (ENU)
$\boldsymbol{q}$	Hamilton unit quaternion, scalar component first
$\boldsymbol{\omega}$	Body angular velocity (FLU body frame)
$T, \boldsymbol{\tau}$	Collective thrust and body torque
ϕ, θ	Roll and pitch angles (ZYX Euler convention)
Payload parameters	
m_B, m_P, m_T	Bare-airframe, payload and composite mass
$\boldsymbol{r}_p = [0, 0, r_z]$	Payload attachment point in the body frame (centred grasp)
r_z	Vertical arm of the payload below the rotor plane (weak prior)
$\boldsymbol{c}$	Composite centre of mass in the body frame, $\boldsymbol{c} = (m_P/m_T)\boldsymbol{r}_p$
$\boldsymbol{c}_{xy}$	Horizontal CoM offset; not modelled, held at $\mathbf{0}$
μ	Reduced mass, $\mu = m_B m_P / m_T$
J_B, J_T	Bare-airframe and composite inertia tensors
ΔJ	Payload-induced roll/pitch inertia increment, $\Delta J = \mu r_z^2$
κ	Inertia ratio $(J_{xx} + \Delta J)/J_{xx}$
Reconstructed input and actuator model	
$T_{\text{phys}}, \boldsymbol{\tau}_{\text{phys}}$	Wrench reconstructed from rotor speeds
k_f, k_m	Rotor thrust and yaw-reaction coefficients
η	Normalised throttle command
k_d, g	Linear drag coefficient, gravitational acceleration
Estimator and controller	
$N, \Delta t$	Horizon length and sampling interval
W_y, W_w, W_0	MHE measurement, process-noise and arrival weights
β_j	Per-stage weighting factor; λ forgetting factor
Q, R, P	NMPC stage-state, input and terminal weights
$L_{(\cdot)}$	Bryson tolerance scale for the corresponding residual
u_{hover}	Parameter-dependent equilibrium input baseline
$\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$	Residual specific force estimated by the controller ($\mathscr{L}_1$-type)
Lifecycle	
γ	No-payload evidence score, (4.37)
$\sigma(v; a, b)$	Cubic smooth-step indicator, (4.36)
ς	Body-rate command scale

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

Quadrotors are increasingly used for inspection, transport and delivery because they can hover and manoeuvre in confined three-dimensional environments. Their agility, however, is obtained from a light airframe with limited thrust and torque margins. A package pickup can therefore change the vehicle dynamics on the same time scale as the control loop. The total mass changes the thrust-to-acceleration map, and a load hanging below the airframe multiplies the rotational inertia that the attitude loop must move.

Model predictive control is attractive for this problem because it predicts future motion while handling actuator limits and coupled dynamics explicitly [1, 2]. For a quadrotor the relevant equations are nonlinear and the attitude evolves on the unit-quaternion manifold; nonlinear MPC therefore avoids the loss of fidelity caused by repeated linearisation over aggressive motion [3, 4]. Its performance nevertheless depends on the model supplied to the prediction. If the controller continues to use the empty-airframe parameters after grasping a parcel, even a numerically converged optimisation solves the wrong problem.

This dissertation couples moving horizon estimation with nonlinear model predictive control. MHE estimates states and parameters by optimising over a re-

cent window of measurements while enforcing the system dynamics and physical bounds [5]. Within that window the estimator identifies a single payload-dependent scalar, the composite mass, and from it the controller reconstructs every payload-dependent term in its own model.

1.2 Problem Statement

Consider a quadrotor that follows a three-dimensional figure-eight path, grasps a payload from above, transports it and releases it at a selected phase of the trajectory. The controller has no access to the true payload parameters. Only ordinary onboard flight signals are available: odometry, attitude, body rate and rotor-speed telemetry.

Two model errors appear at attachment:

1. the composite mass changes abruptly, shifting the hover thrust and the translational acceleration gain;
2. the payload lever arm increases roll and pitch inertia several-fold, reducing effective inner-loop bandwidth.

At release both changes occur in the opposite direction. The payload is grasped on the thrust axis, so the composite centre of mass moves only vertically and no standing trim moment arises; a residual offset left by imperfect alignment is treated as an unmodelled disturbance (Chapter 3).

The central research question is:

> Can a quadrotor identify its payload online from its ordinary flight signals alone — through grasp, loaded manoeuvre and release —

and feed that estimate to a constrained predictive controller consistently enough to remain a well-tracking controller throughout?

Release adds one decision that the continuous model does not make by itself: when the controller may accept that a delivery has happened. Accepting a release declares the task complete and resets auxiliary estimates learned against the loaded vehicle; it does not change the model's mass or inertia, which follow the estimate continuously. The controller in this work issues the release command itself, but a command is not a detachment — a gripper can be slow to open or can jam. The dissertation therefore studies *estimator-confirmed detachment*: once a release has been commanded, the release is accepted only when the estimate shows that the payload has actually gone. This costs a confirmation delay, and it is evaluated against accepting at the command, under nominal release and under a release whose physical detachment is held back. It is not a detector of load loss in general: a load lost without any command is outside what the evaluated mechanism can establish.

This question has a specific technical obstacle, which Chapter 3 addresses and which shapes the whole design. The inertia increment is several times larger, relative to its bare-airframe value, than the mass increment, so the rotational channel carries a strong payload signature — but it is also the channel this platform models least well. An estimator that lets the mass enter its rotational model will use the mass to absorb rotational model error. The design adopted here identifies the composite mass on the translational channel only, derives the inertia increment from it by rigid-body algebra, and accepts — and measures — the loss of information that this costs in manoeuvre.

1.3 Research Objectives

The dissertation has five objectives:

1. derive a consistent quadrotor model with explicit payload mass and inertia entry points, and reduce a centred rigid payload to one online degree of freedom from which every payload-dependent term follows (Chapter 3);

2. formulate a moving horizon estimator that identifies the composite mass from a wrench reconstructed from measured rotor speeds, on the translational channel, while keeping the mass from absorbing rotational model error (Chapters 3 and 4);

3. formulate a predictive controller whose prediction model, input baseline and inner-loop command scaling are updated continuously from one health-gated estimate (Chapter 4);

4. define a release lifecycle that separates the release command from the physical detachment by gating release acceptance on estimator evidence, and that holds an unconfirmed release as UNRESOLVED rather than assuming it complete (Chapter 4);

5. evaluate the complete interface in software-in-the-loop simulation with a randomised, fully reported cohort and targeted ablations, and characterise where it fails (Chapter 5).

1.4 Scope

The work covers simulation and software-in-the-loop validation of a rigidly attached parcel grasped on the thrust axis. Airframe inertia, rotor geometry and the thrust and yaw-reaction coefficients are treated as calibrated plant quantities. The calibrated airframe mass appears in the rigid-body model, in the derived payload mass $m_P = (m_T - m_B)^+$ and in offline scoring.

The information boundary is stated precisely, because a looser statement would be false. *No task-specific payload mass enters the estimator or the controller, and*

no attach or release notification enters the estimator. The controller uses its own release command only to start the confirmation timeout, to end the attach-time inertia floor, to decide whether an acceptance also resets the residual specific force, and — under the command-armed and force-balance policies — to arm the confirmation count. The command never sets the model's mass or inertia. One mass-valued platform constant does remain in the closed loop — the airframe's 0.30 kg payload envelope, used for an attach-time inertia floor — and it is disclosed as a specification of the airframe rather than as information about the parcel. Chapter 3 states exactly where it appears.

The scope does not include eccentric grasps beyond the gripper's alignment tolerance, deformable or sloshing loads, cable-suspended payload dynamics, wind, motor failure, hardware flight, or a formal closed-loop stability proof for the estimator–controller interconnection. All system-level evidence is from PX4/Gazebo software-in-the-loop simulation. These limits are revisited in Chapter 6.

1.5 Contributions

The contributions are:

1. **A single-degree-of-freedom parameter structure for a centred rigid payload.** For a payload grasped on the thrust axis, the roll and pitch inertia increment is the reduced mass times the square of a nominal vertical arm, so the composite mass is the only payload quantity to be identified online; the inertia follows from it and vanishes with it, with no event needed to remove it (Chapter 3).

2. **A mass estimator driven by a reconstructed physical input that does not integrate the rotational dynamics.** The estimator is fed the thrust reconstructed from measured rotor speeds rather than the controller's intended

input, which would make the mass unobservable by construction. In its deployed form it keeps only the world-frame velocity and the composite mass as states and takes the measured attitude as a known input, so that errors of the poorly modelled rotational channel have no path to the mass; a mass-health check flags an estimate that leaves a physical band instead of hiding it behind a hard bound. Replayed on the 312 recorded campaign flights, it had a smaller loaded mass error than the full-state estimator in every nominal flight. The evaluation campaigns were flown with that earlier full-state form, which separated the channels more weakly by carrying the payload inertia as a parameter lagged by one solve; the lagged treatment halved the loaded mass bias in manoeuvre relative to omitting the inertia (Chapters 3, 4 and Sections 5.7.2, 5.7.3).

3. **A continuous estimate-driven controller interface with a command-armed, estimator-confirmed release lifecycle.** One health-gated frame updates the controller's prediction model, input baseline and inner-loop scaling continuously; release acceptance is a separate decision, taken on estimator evidence once a release has been commanded. In the evaluation it never accepted a release while a delayed payload was still attached, and, unlike an always-on variant of the same rule, it produced no false acceptance during high-speed carry. A variant on independent force-balance evidence, enabled additionally by an airborne-load watchdog, also detected every load lost without a command in the evaluation, at the price of sensitivity to the thrust map (Chapter 4 and Sections 5.5 and 5.6).

4. **A software-in-the-loop evaluation with randomised blocks, complete reporting, ablations and failure cases.** A frozen cohort of 120 flights and a second frozen campaign of 312, every flight reported, together with ablations of the residual specific force and the inertia treatment and an account of the failure modes — in particular the collapse of the mass estimate under sustained manoeuvre and the false acceptances it causes in an always-on lifecycle (Chapter 5).

1.6 Dissertation Organisation

Chapter 2 reviews predictive control, online estimation, inertial-parameter identification and payload-adaptive aerial control, and positions this work against representative approaches. Chapter 3 derives the model and the payload parameter structure, and is where the one-degree-of-freedom reduction and the channel assignment of the mass are developed in full. Chapter 4 presents the coupled architecture, the numerical form of both optimal control problems, the continuous payload interface and the release lifecycle. Chapter 5 describes the implementation and reports the frozen experimental campaign, including the conditions under which the interface fails. Chapter 6 answers the research objectives against that evidence and states what remains open.

Chapter 2

Background and Related Work

2.1 Model Predictive Control

MPC repeatedly solves a finite-horizon optimal control problem, applies the first input and shifts the horizon forward. Its practical value comes from combining prediction, multivariable coordination and explicit constraints within one optimisation [1, 2]. Linear MPC is mature and computationally efficient, but a single linear model is poorly suited to the large attitude changes and thrust-direction coupling of a quadrotor. NMPC retains the nonlinear dynamics and nonlinear tracking errors directly [3].

The price is computation. Multiple shooting, sequential quadratic programming, Gauss–Newton Hessian approximations and real-time iteration schemes are widely used to make NMPC practical [6]. CasADi provides symbolic differentiation and a high-level optimisation interface [7]; acados generates efficient optimal-control solvers around tailored SQP and QP components [8, 9], with HPIPM [10] as the quadratic subproblem solver.

2.2 Quadrotor NMPC

A quadrotor is differentially flat under common assumptions [11], and many successful controllers exploit position and yaw references with a cascaded inner attitude loop [12]. NMPC can instead optimise collective thrust and body torque against the complete nonlinear rigid-body model, and this formulation becomes advantageous as trajectory curvature and operating envelope increase [4, 13].

The controller in this dissertation predicts position, velocity, unit quaternion and body rate. The attitude residual is the vector part of the relative quaternion, which avoids treating the four quaternion components as independent Euclidean coordinates. Input limits represent collective thrust and body-torque authority. This formulation is nominally standard; the distinguishing issue is that the equilibrium input and the plant parameters change at payload attachment and again at release.

2.3 Uncertainty and Adaptation in MPC

Robust MPC protects against bounded uncertainty, while stochastic MPC describes uncertainty probabilistically. Both can preserve margins without identifying the current plant, but conservatism grows when the uncertainty set must cover both an empty and a loaded vehicle. Adaptive MPC instead updates a parameterised model online: certainty-equivalent schemes use the current estimate directly, set-membership schemes maintain a feasible parameter set, and dual-control schemes excite the plant to learn [14, 15].

Learning-based MPC extends this using Gaussian processes, neural networks or learned residual models. Data-driven MPC for quadrotors can compensate complex aerodynamic effects [16, 17], and neural approximations can reduce online computation [18]; broader surveys of learning for control under safety con-

straints are available [19]. Those methods are valuable when the uncertainty is poorly structured. Payload pickup has stronger prior structure: rigid-body mechanics already specifies how mass and attachment geometry enter the equations. The present work therefore estimates a small physical parameter set rather than learning a general residual map.

A distinct and influential alternative is to decline to identify the payload at all, and to absorb its effect as a lumped matched disturbance. The $\mathscr{L}_1$-adaptive augmentation of a quadrotor NMPC [20] is the representative of this family, and incremental nonlinear dynamic inversion [21] is its inner-loop counterpart. Such schemes are robust and require no payload model, but their internal quantity is a force or an acceleration, not a mass and a moment. They therefore cannot answer the question this dissertation poses — whether a payload is still attached — because that question is not represented in their state. The comparison is implemented here (an additive lumped translational and rotational disturbance in the prediction model) but is not among the frozen results.

2.4 State and Parameter Estimation

Recursive filters such as the extended Kalman filter propagate a local Gaussian approximation. They are efficient and central to flight-state estimation, but inequality constraints are not naturally hard constraints and abrupt parameter changes violate the local linearisation assumption. MHE estimates a window of past states and disturbances by solving a constrained optimisation; it can impose bounds such as a physically admissible mass interval and can attribute residuals using the same nonlinear model as the controller [1, 5, 22]. Recent work learns the MHE weights themselves [23], which is the principled version of the stage-weight question that Chapter 4 settles negatively for this problem.

A moving window introduces a trade-off that this work encounters directly. A

longer horizon improves noise rejection, but the constraint that makes an augmented parameter identifiable — that it is constant across the window — becomes less defensible as the window spans more of the trajectory. The implemented estimator uses 20 stages at 0.1 s.

2.5 Inertial-Parameter Identification

That the rigid-body equations are *linear* in a particular set of inertial parameters — mass, first mass moment and the six inertia elements — is a classical result in manipulator identification [24]. The present work identifies only the first of them online. For a payload grasped on the thrust axis the first moment vanishes and the inertia increment reduces to a known function of the mass, so the classical set collapses to one scalar; the argument of Chapter 3 is about which measurement channel should carry that scalar on a vehicle whose rotational model is less trustworthy than its translational one.

Payload-aware estimation for multirotors has previously used force–torque sensing, external observers or explicit mass estimators [25–28], and slung-load and aerial-manipulation work treats the payload as a dynamic subsystem of its own [29–31]. In the works reviewed here, whether a payload is present is either assumed known or not represented as a quantity of its own. This dissertation studies a setting in which the estimator is not told when a payload is attached or released.

2.6 Change Detection and Event-Triggered Estimation

Deciding that a plant has changed, from a residual, is the subject of classical change-detection theory [32], and event-triggered estimation is an established

response to it [33]. The predecessor of the present system used exactly this structure: a persistent step in the reconstructed collective thrust triggered a de-weighting of the pre-event stages of the window.

Chapter 4 reports why that structure was retired for this problem. A collective-thrust residual cannot distinguish a payload change from a trajectory-mode change, a sustained vertical gust, or an aggressive manoeuvre, because all of them move the same scalar. Any decision resting on that signal alone inherits the ambiguity. The deployed design does not detect the change at all: it waits for the estimated mass itself to persist at the bare-airframe value, and accepts both the delay and the dependence on mass accuracy that this implies. A formal comparison against a CUSUM detector on the same signals, under a matched false-alarm constraint, is not performed and is listed among the gaps.

2.7 Positioning and Research Gap

Table 2.1 places representative works from the families above along the dimensions that matter for this dissertation. The summaries are necessarily simplified to the formulation each work emphasises, and a dash means that the aspect is not the subject of that work rather than that the work fails at it.

Within the works reviewed here, three aspects receive comparatively little attention, and they define the scope of this dissertation.

First, **a payload model that does not need an event to switch off.** Payload-adaptive formulations commonly estimate parameters conditioned on attachment, so that some event must tell the model when the payload has gone. A model whose payload-dependent terms are continuous functions of an estimated quantity, and vanish as that quantity returns to the bare airframe, does not need such an event for its dynamics.

Table 2.1: Representative related work compared along the dimensions relevant to payload grasp and release. Entries summarise the formulation emphasised in each cited work; "—" means the aspect is not its subject.

Work	Payload representation	Signals used	Estimated quantities	Attach / release known?	Release confirmation	Controller	Evidence	Principal limitation for this problem
$\mathcal{L}_1$-adaptive NMPC [20]	lumped matched force and torque disturbance	state estimate	disturbance (adaptation law)	not required	—	NMPC with $\mathcal{L}_1$ augmentation	flight experiments	no payload quantity; presence not represented
Adaptive INDI [21]	lumped inner-loop disturbance	angular acceleration, actuator feedback	control effectiveness	not required	—	incremental attitude control	flight experiments	attitude loop only; no payload quantity
NeuroMHE [23]	external disturbance wrench	state measurements	disturbance wrench; learned MHE weights	not required	—	disturbance-compensated tracking	simulation and flight	payload not separated from other disturbances
Online parameter estimation [27, 28]	vehicle mass, centre of mass and inertia	onboard inertial and actuator signals	mass, CoM, inertia (and actuator parameters)	parameters assumed slowly varying	—	not the focus	flight data	no release event; not coupled to a predictive controller
IMU-based inertia estimation [26]	rigid-body inertia	IMU and rotor inputs	inertia	parameters assumed constant	—	not the focus	experiments	inertia only; no grasp or release
External wrench estimation [25]	external wrench	inertial and rotor signals	external force and torque; collisions	not required	contact events from the wrench	reflex reaction	flight experiments	payload not represented as mass and inertia
Aerial grasping [11]	rigid grasped object	external motion capture	object parameters after grasp	grasp commanded and known	—	cascaded tracking control	flight experiments	attachment assumed known
This dissertation	centred rigid point mass on a nominal vertical arm	rotor speeds, odometry	composite mass; inertia derived	not given to the estimator	command-armed, estimator-confirmed detachment; force-balance confirmation with loss watchdog	NMPC over PX4 rate loop	software-in-the-loop only	mass collapses in manoeuvre; thrust-map sensitive; no hardware

Second, **the difference between a release command and a physical detachment.** Systems that grasp and release usually treat the gripper command, or a contact sensor, as the moment the payload leaves, and the mismatch between the two is rarely measured. This dissertation uses the estimate to separate the two once a release has been commanded, and measures both the delay this costs and what happens when the same evidence is consulted before any command.

Third, **an explicit account of the costs.** Confirming a release on the estimate delays it; estimating an absolute mass from an absolute thrust makes the interface sensitive to a calibration constant; and resting every lifecycle decision on one estimate makes the interface only as reliable as that estimate in manoeuvre. Chapter 5 reports these costs rather than asserting them to be small.

The dissertation consequently treats estimation and control as one architecture rather than two algorithms. Estimation is judged by whether its outputs are identifiable and useful for control; control is judged by whether it remains consistent with the quantities being estimated, and by whether it knows when it does not know.

Chapter 3

Modeling and Parameter Structure

A quadrotor that picks up a parcel does not merely become heavier. It also becomes harder to rotate: on the platform of this work, a 0.30 kg parcel hanging about a quarter of a metre below the rotor plane adds fifteen percent to the mass but more than doubles the roll and pitch inertia (Section 3.3.2). These are two distinct changes to the equations of motion, and a controller that compensates only the first loses inner-loop bandwidth in a way that mass adaptation cannot explain.

This chapter derives the model that the estimator and the controller share and makes explicit which of its parameters are identified online. Its structural claim is that, for a payload grasped on the thrust axis, both changes are governed by a *single* online scalar. The composite mass m_T is identified from the translational channel; the roll and pitch inertia increment then follows from m_T by rigid-body algebra and the nominal vertical arm of the gripper. No payload mass is supplied to either optimiser, and no attach or release notification to the estimator. The nominal arm is a geometric prior, and Section 3.4.3 states exactly what that prior is and what it is not.

Section 3.1 defines the system and its assumptions, Section 3.2 its dynamics, and Section 3.3 the coupling between payload mass and inertia. Section 3.4 reduces the payload to one online degree of freedom and explains why the estimator keeps away from the rotational channel. Section 3.5 describes the

measured input and the interface to the autopilot, and Section 3.6 collects the modelling assumptions and their limits. The estimator and controller models built on this chapter are collected in Section 4.2; their numerical form, initialisation and constraints, the residual specific force and the inner-loop scheduling belong to Chapter 4; the experimental evidence for the design choices belongs to Chapter 5.

3.1 System Definition and Modelling Assumptions

Two reference frames are used throughout. The world frame $\mathscr{W}$ is East–North–Up (ENU), so that gravity acts along $-z$. The body frame $\mathscr{B}$ is Front–Left–Up (FLU) with its origin at the geometric centre of the rotor disc — *not* at the centre of mass. The thrust vector passes through the body origin by construction.

The state vector and the control input are

$$x = \left[\boldsymbol{p}; \boldsymbol{v}; \boldsymbol{q}; \boldsymbol{\omega}\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{13}, \qquad u = \left[T; \boldsymbol{\tau}\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{4}, \tag{3.1}$$

where $\boldsymbol{p}$ and $\boldsymbol{v}$ are the position and velocity in $\mathscr{W}$, $\boldsymbol{q}$ is the unit quaternion encoding the attitude of $\mathscr{B}$ relative to $\mathscr{W}$ (Section 3.1.1), $\boldsymbol{\omega}$ is the body rate in $\mathscr{B}$, T is the collective thrust along the body z axis, and $\boldsymbol{\tau}$ is the body torque. We abbreviate $\boldsymbol{e}_3 = [0,0,1]^\top$, and write m_B, m_P and $m_T = m_B + m_P$ for the bare-airframe, payload and composite masses.

Three assumptions define the system.

1. *The bare airframe is balanced about the body origin*, so that its centre of mass and the body origin coincide when no payload is attached. This is an assumption about the vehicle, not a consequence of the frame choice.

2. *The payload is a point mass m_P rigidly attached on the thrust axis*, at the body-frame offset $\boldsymbol{r}_p = [0, 0, r_z]^\top$ with $r_z < 0$: the load hangs below the airframe. The gripper aligns the vehicle over the parcel before attaching; the residual horizontal offset that alignment leaves is treated as an approximation in Section 3.6.

3. *Rotor thrust follows the static quadratic law* of Section 3.5, with calibrated coefficients.

3.1.1 Attitude representation

Attitude is represented by a unit quaternion under the *Hamilton* convention with the scalar part first,

$$\boldsymbol{q} = [q_w, q_x, q_y, q_z]^\top, \qquad \|\boldsymbol{q}\| = 1, \tag{3.2}$$

encoding the rotation from $\mathscr{B}$ to $\mathscr{W}$. The corresponding rotation matrix is

$$R(\boldsymbol{q}) = \begin{bmatrix} q_w^2+q_x^2-q_y^2-q_z^2 & 2(q_xq_y-q_wq_z) & 2(q_xq_z+q_wq_y) \\ 2(q_xq_y+q_wq_z) & q_w^2-q_x^2+q_y^2-q_z^2 & 2(q_yq_z-q_wq_x) \\ 2(q_xq_z-q_wq_y) & 2(q_yq_z+q_wq_x) & q_w^2-q_x^2-q_y^2+q_z^2 \end{bmatrix}. \tag{3.3}$$

Three conventions are fixed here and used throughout: the Hamilton product, the scalar-first component order of (3.2), and $\boldsymbol{\omega}$ resolved in $\mathscr{B}$.

One scalar derived from (3.3) is used repeatedly: the fraction of the collective thrust that acts vertically. With roll ϕ and pitch θ in the ZYX Euler convention $R = R_z(\psi)R_y(\theta)R_x(\phi)$, it is the $(3,3)$ entry of the rotation matrix,

$$\cos\phi\,\cos\theta \;=\; \boldsymbol{e}_3^\top R(\boldsymbol{q})\,\boldsymbol{e}_3 \;=\; 1-2\big(q_x^2+q_y^2\big). \tag{3.4}$$

The implementation evaluates the right-hand side directly from the quaternion.

3.2 Quadrotor Dynamics with a Rigid Payload

3.2.1 Kinematics

Translational kinematics is the definition of velocity,

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{p}} = \boldsymbol{v}. \tag{3.5}$$

With the body rate resolved in $\mathscr{B}$, attitude kinematics is the Hamilton product of the attitude with the pure quaternion of the body rate,

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{q}} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\boldsymbol{q} \otimes [0, \boldsymbol{\omega}] = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\Xi(\boldsymbol{q})\,\boldsymbol{\omega}, \qquad \Xi(\boldsymbol{q}) = \begin{bmatrix} -q_x & -q_y & -q_z \\ q_w & -q_z & q_y \\ q_z & q_w & -q_x \\ -q_y & q_x & q_w \end{bmatrix}. \tag{3.6}$$

The body rate enters on the *right* of the product because it is resolved in the body frame; a world-frame rate would enter on the left. The implementation uses the matrix form, which is linear in $\boldsymbol{\omega}$. One property of Ξ matters for estimation: $\boldsymbol{q}^\top \Xi(\boldsymbol{q}) = \mathbf{0}^\top$ for every quaternion, so $\boldsymbol{q}^\top \dot{\boldsymbol{q}} = 0$ and the kinematics preserve $\|\boldsymbol{q}\|$ exactly. The estimator integrates (3.6) across a whole window before comparing it with measurements, and any drift of the norm would appear as an attitude residual that the optimiser could attribute to the payload parameter.

Neither (3.5) nor (3.6) contains a mass, an inertia, or any other physical parameter. *The payload therefore enters the model only through the dynamics.*

3.2.2 Translational dynamics

Newton's second law in $\mathscr{W}$, with thrust rotated from the body frame and a linear aerodynamic drag term, gives

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{v}} = \frac{1}{m_T}\Big(R(\boldsymbol{q})\,\boldsymbol{e}_3\,T - k_d\,\boldsymbol{v}\Big) - g\,\boldsymbol{e}_3, \tag{3.7}$$

where m_T is the *composite* mass of airframe plus payload, k_d is a fixed drag coefficient, and g is the gravitational acceleration. The mass — and only the mass — enters here, as the scalar gain $1/m_T$ from thrust to acceleration. If the thrust is known independently of the model, the measured motion determines m_T through (3.7) in ordinary near-hover flight, with no dedicated excitation manoeuvre; the qualification "independently of the model" is the subject of Section 3.5.

Projecting (3.7) onto $\boldsymbol{e}_3$ and neglecting the vertical component of the drag term gives the vertical force balance

$$m_T\big(g + a_z\big) \;=\; T\cos\phi\,\cos\theta, \tag{3.8}$$

with $\cos\phi\cos\theta$ from (3.4) and $a_z = \dot{v}_z$. It is used to initialise the estimator (Section 4.3.5).

3.2.3 Rotational dynamics

Let $J_B = \mathrm{diag}(J_{xx}, J_{yy}, J_{zz})$ denote the inertia of the bare airframe about its own centre of mass, and J_T the composite inertia derived in Section 3.3.1. Euler's equation in the body frame is

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{\omega}} = J_T^{-1}\Big(\boldsymbol{\tau} - \boldsymbol{\omega}\times J_T\boldsymbol{\omega}\Big), \tag{3.9}$$

where $\boldsymbol{\omega} \times J_T \boldsymbol{\omega}$ is the gyroscopic coupling. Equation (3.9) holds in this form only when the inertia and the applied moments refer to the same point, and for a free-flying body that point must be the centre of mass. The composite inertia must therefore be taken about the composite centre of mass, which *moves* when a payload is attached (Section 3.3.1). For the centred payload of assumption 2 that centre of mass stays on the thrust axis, so thrust contributes no moment to (3.9).

Taken together, (3.7) and (3.9) give each payload-dependent quantity exactly one point of entry: the composite mass appears only as $1/m_T$ in the translational dynamics, and the inertia increment only inside J_T in the rotational dynamics. This separation is what allows the two effects to be attributed to distinct physical channels, and it is used throughout Section 3.4.

3.3 Payload-Induced Mass and Inertia Coupling

With the payload of assumption 2, define the composite mass and the *reduced mass*

$$m_T = m_B + m_P, \qquad \mu = \frac{m_B m_P}{m_B + m_P} = \frac{m_B m_P}{m_T}. \tag{3.10}$$

3.3.1 Inertia increment and the reduced mass

The inertia increment requires more care than the parallel-axis theorem applied naively, because *the centre of mass itself moves when the payload is attached*. With the airframe centre of mass at the body origin, the composite centre of mass lies on the thrust axis at

$$\boldsymbol{c} = \frac{m_P}{m_T} \boldsymbol{r}_p = \left[0,\, 0,\, \frac{m_P}{m_T} r_z\right]^\top. \tag{3.11}$$

The theorem must be applied about this *new* centre of mass, and both bodies contribute, since the airframe no longer sits at the centre of mass either.

Consider a roll or pitch axis and let $d = |r_z|$ denote the lever arm. From (3.11), the distances of the two bodies from the composite centre of mass are

$$\underbrace{\|\mathbf{0} - \boldsymbol{c}\| = \frac{m_P}{m_T} d,}_{\text{airframe}} \qquad \underbrace{\|\boldsymbol{r}_p - \boldsymbol{c}\| = \Big(1 - \frac{m_P}{m_T}\Big) d = \frac{m_B}{m_T} d\,.}_{\text{payload}} \tag{3.12}$$

The payload's distance is *smaller* than d. Adding the two parallel-axis contributions and simplifying,

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta J &= m_B \Big(\frac{m_P}{m_T} d\Big)^2 + m_P \Big(\frac{m_B}{m_T} d\Big)^2 \\ &= \frac{d^2}{m_T^2}\Big(m_B m_P^2 + m_P m_B^2\Big) = \frac{d^2}{m_T^2} m_B m_P \big(m_P + m_B\big) \\ &= \frac{m_B m_P}{m_T} r_z^2 = \mu\, r_z^2. \end{aligned} \tag{3.13}$$

The factor $(m_B + m_P)$ produced by the sum cancels one power of m_T in the denominator, and the two contributions collapse onto the reduced mass (3.10) — the same quantity that governs the two-body problem, and for the same reason: the inertia of a rigid pair about its centre of mass depends only on the *relative* position of the two bodies.

Equation (3.13) also identifies a natural error. Writing $\Delta J = m_P r_z^2$ — treating the payload as orbiting a fixed body origin, and forgetting both the airframe's own contribution and the displacement of the centre of mass — overestimates the increment by the factor m_T/m_B, which is 14.5 % at the heavier payload of this work.

The same computation carried out for the full tensor gives, for an on-axis point mass,

$$J_T \;=\; J_B + \mu\Big(\|\boldsymbol{r}_p\|^2 I_3 - \boldsymbol{r}_p \boldsymbol{r}_p^{\top}\Big) \;=\; J_B + \operatorname{diag}\big(\mu r_z^2,\, \mu r_z^2,\, 0\big). \tag{3.14}$$

Three consequences are used below. The increment is *isotropic* in roll and pitch, so a single scalar $\Delta J = \mu r_z^2$ describes both. It is *diagonal*: every off-diagonal product of inertia contains a horizontal arm and vanishes. And the yaw increment is exactly zero for a point mass on the yaw axis; the parcel's own rotational inertia about its centre is the only yaw contribution, and Section 3.6 declares its omission.

3.3.2 Magnitudes on the experimental platform

The factor by which the payload slows the roll and pitch response to a given torque is the inertia ratio

$$\kappa = \frac{J_{xx} + \Delta J}{J_{xx}}. \tag{3.15}$$

For the two payloads used in the experiments, attached at the nominal arm $r_z = -0.27\,\mathrm{m}$ on the platform of this work ($m_B = 2.0643\,\mathrm{kg}$, $J_{xx} = 0.0142\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$), equations (3.10), (3.13) and (3.15) give

	μ [kg]	ΔJ [kg m^2]	κ
$m_P = 0.15\,\mathrm{kg}$	0.140	0.0102	1.72
$m_P = 0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$	0.262	0.0191	2.34

(3.16)

A 0.30 kg parcel on a 2.06 kg airframe is a 15 % change of mass but a more than *two-fold* change of roll and pitch inertia. Adapting the mass alone, in the thrust channel, accounts for the first and not the second. The increment is governed by how far *below* the airframe the load hangs, through r_z^2, which is why the gripper geometry, and not only the parcel, sets the difficulty of the task.

3.4 Single-Parameter Estimation Structure

3.4.1 One online degree of freedom

Equations (3.10)–(3.14) express every payload-dependent quantity of the model through two numbers, the payload mass m_P and the vertical arm r_z, and the two are not on an equal footing.

The mass changes from flight to flight and within a flight: it is zero before a grasp, takes the parcel's value after it, and returns to zero at release, possibly in several steps if a load is lost piecewise. It is also *observable*, through the gain $1/m_T$ of (3.7). It is therefore the quantity estimated online, in the form of the composite mass m_T, and the payload mass follows as

$$m_P = (m_T - m_B)^+, \tag{3.17}$$

where $(\cdot)^+$ denotes the positive part, because the mass estimate is permitted to fall slightly below m_B to leave room for calibration error.

The vertical arm, by contrast, is a property of the gripper rather than of the parcel. It is fixed by where the gripper holds the load relative to the rotor plane, and it enters the equations only through the inertia increment, which is weakly excited in delivery flight. It is therefore held at a nominal value rather than estimated. The inertia increment consumed by the model is then a function of the single online scalar,

$$\boxed{\Delta J(m_T) \;=\; \frac{m_B\,(m_T - m_B)^+}{m_T}\, r_z^2} \tag{3.18}$$

which vanishes when the mass estimate returns to the bare-airframe value. No attach or release event is needed to switch the inertia on or off: the algebra does it, continuously, as the estimate moves. The mass is estimated; the inertia

is derived from it and is never an independent decision variable.

3.4.2 Which channel identifies the mass

Equation (3.18) makes the rotational dynamics depend on m_T. Should the *estimator* also be allowed to use that dependence, so that the angular-rate residual contributes information about the mass?

In principle it should: the increment is larger than the airframe inertia itself (Section 3.3.2), so any roll or pitch manoeuvre carries a strong mass signature. In practice the rotational channel of this platform is not modelled well enough to carry an absolute quantity. Three independent errors were found in it: the calibrated airframe inertia differs substantially from the simulator's model description; rotor drag acting through the vertical offset of the rotor plane produces a velocity-dependent body moment that (3.9) does not contain; and the reconstructed torque of an unloaded vehicle carries a small constant bias (Section 3.6). None prevents the vehicle from flying, but an optimiser that is allowed to move m_T inside the rotational model will use the mass to absorb all three. Development flights with that freedom produced large mass overestimates, reported in Section 5.7.2.

The deployed estimator therefore does not integrate the rotational dynamics at all. It keeps the translational dynamics (3.7), supplies the measured attitude as a known input instead of estimating it, and holds the composite mass and the velocity as its only states (Section 4.2.1). The mass then enters the estimator's model only where the model — a thrust, a mass and gravity — is trustworthy, and no inertia, torque or arm enters it.

The evaluation campaigns of Chapter 5 were flown with an earlier, full-state estimator that does integrate (3.6) and (3.9) (Section 4.2.2). It approaches the same separation from the other side, by removing the direct sensitivity of the

rotational dynamics to the mass decision variable,

$$\left.\frac{\partial \dot{\omega}}{\partial m_T}\right|_{\text{estimator}} = 0. \tag{3.19}$$

It does not, however, leave the payload inertia out of its rotational model: an estimator that integrates the bare-airframe inertia sees a heavy, low-hanging load as an unexplained angular response. The increment is instead inserted as a *known parameter* computed from the previous solution $\hat{m}^-$ and held constant within the window,

$$\Delta J^{\text{lag}} = \frac{m_B\left(\hat{m}^- - m_B\right)^+}{\hat{m}^-}\, r_z^2, \qquad \left.\frac{\partial \Delta J^{\text{lag}}}{\partial m_T}\right|_{\text{window}} = 0, \tag{3.20}$$

refreshed between solves at the 10 Hz window rate. In the implementation the positive part in (3.20) is smoothed over a width of 0.02 kg, which near $\hat{m}^- = m_B$ changes the increment by less than the airframe calibration error. Table 3.1 places this *lagged* treatment between the two alternatives, and adds the deployed reduced estimator as a fourth row.

Table 3.1: Treatments of the rotational channel inside the estimator. The controller always uses (3.18) **evaluated at the published estimate; only the estimator's own model differs between rows. The first three rows are treatments within the full-state estimator.**

Treatment	ΔJ inside the estimator	$\partial\dot{\omega}/\partial m_T$	Status
omitted	0	zero	available, off
lagged	(3.18) at the previous solution $\hat{m}^-$	zero	evaluation campaigns
live	(3.18) at the decision variable m_T	non-zero	rejected
not integrated (reduced)	none; attitude measured	—	deployed default

The corresponding implementation settings are listed in Appendix A. The lagged treatment is the full-state default of the experiment entry points; the library default of the full-state estimator remains the omitted treatment. Since 5 November 2026 the entry points select the reduced estimator.

The omitted treatment satisfies (3.19) with the wrong inertia; the live treatment has the right inertia but gives the optimiser the mass as a rotational knob. The lagged treatment keeps both properties: within a solve the increment is a constant, and from one solve to the next it follows the mass. Section 5.7.2 compares the omitted and lagged treatments in closed loop.

Equation (3.19) removes the *direct* sensitivity only, and it should not be read as saying that the rotational channel has no influence on a full-state estimate. Two indirect couplings remain. Within a window, the angular-rate residual shapes the estimated attitude trajectory, and the attitude sets the direction of the thrust in (3.7); an error in the rotational model therefore reaches the mass through the attitude. Between windows, (3.20) feeds the previous mass back into the rotational model, so a biased estimate changes the inertia used in the next window. The lagged treatment does not remove these paths. The reduced estimator removes both: it has no estimated attitude through which an error could pass, and no inertia into which a previous mass could be fed back. Section 5.7.3 compares the two estimators in replay and in closed loop.

3.4.3 What is estimated, what is derived, and what is fixed

Table 3.2 records the identity of every parameter of the model. One scalar is an online degree of freedom; everything else is derived from it by the algebra of Section 3.3, calibrated once for the airframe, or held at a nominal value.

Three entries of the table invite objection.

Why not augment the inertia increment as well? Because it is nearly unobservable in the flight regime of interest, and because the channel through which it would be observed is the one this platform models least well. The increment acts only through $\dot{\omega}$, which a delivery task spent largely in near-hover, low-rate flight excites weakly; a free ΔJ would let the optimiser explain measurement noise and the rotational model errors of Section 3.4.2 with a quantity the data barely constrain. Moreover J_T appears *inverted* in (3.9) and is propagated across the horizon, so an error in it is amplified rather than damped, and inertia elements are two orders of magnitude smaller than the mass, which would worsen the scaling of the estimator's Hessian.

Table 3.2: Model parameters, classified by identity. Only the composite mass is a decision variable of the estimator; the inertia increment is generated from it.

Symbol	Meaning	Dim.	Identity	Value / enters
m_T	composite mass	1	**MHE decision variable**	(3.7)
ΔJ	roll/pitch inertia increment	1	derived, (3.18); absent from the deployed estimator, lagged in the full-state one	(4.9), (3.20)
m_P	payload mass	1	derived, $(m_T - m_B)^+$	(3.18)
r_z	payload vertical arm	1	nominal gripper geometry	$-0.27\,\mathrm{m}$
$\boldsymbol{c}_{xy}$	CoM horizontal offset	2	**not modelled**; held at $\mathbf{0}$	—
m_B	bare-airframe mass	1	calibration	$2.0643\,\mathrm{kg}$
J_B	bare-airframe inertia	3	calibration	$\mathrm{diag}(0.0142, 0.0142, 0.0210)\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$
k_f, k_m	thrust and yaw-reaction coefficients	2	calibration	$8.55 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{N\,s^2}$, $0.016\,\mathrm{m}$
k_d, g	drag coefficient, gravity	2	constants	$0.05\,\mathrm{kg\,s^{-1}}$, $9.81\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}$

Why not estimate a horizontal offset? Because at the operating condition of this work there is none to estimate, and carrying one is costly. The gripper aligns over the parcel before attaching, so the offset is bounded by the alignment tolerance; an estimated offset would be identifiable only through the rotational residual, the channel that Section 3.4.2 keeps away from absolute quantities; and an offset is undefined once the payload has gone, so any parameterisation that carries one must also say what it becomes at release.

Why is a nominal r_z acceptable? Because the arm is a property of the gripper, fixed by its design, and not information about the parcel. It is a geometric prior, and the method does use it: it enters the inertia increment (3.18) of both optimisers, where its error propagates quadratically — a 10 % error in r_z is a 21 % error in ΔJ, which mis-sizes the predicted attitude response and the inner-loop ratio κ. It does not enter the deployed estimator at all. In the full-state estimator it cannot enter the mass estimate through a derivative, because of (3.19), but it can through the indirect paths of Section 3.4.2; the size of

that effect has not been measured. The difference between the nominal and the realised arm is quantified in Section 3.6.

The information boundary. The precise claim of this dissertation is that *no task-specific payload mass enters the estimator or the controller, and no attach or release notification enters the estimator*. It is not the stronger claim that the flight stack contains no payload-related constant. Two such constants remain and are disclosed: the nominal arm r_z above, and the platform's 0.30 kg payload *envelope*, which sets the inertia floor of the attach-time bootstrap (Section 4.6.3). Both are specifications of the airframe and its gripper, in the same category as J_B or the actuator envelope, and neither is the mass of the parcel carried on a particular flight. The controller's own release command is used to start the confirmation timeout, to end the inertia floor and to gate the reset of the residual force (Chapter 4); it does not set the payload mass.

3.5 Measured-Input Reconstruction and Model Interfaces

3.5.1 The physical input

The thrust and torque in (3.7) and (3.9) must be known to the estimator. They are reconstructed from measured rotor speeds ω_i through the quadratic rotor law $F_i = k_f \omega_i^2$ and the linear map from the four rotor thrusts to the wrench. For the X configuration of this platform, with rotor positions (x_i, y_i), $|x_i| = |y_i| = l =$

0.174 m, and spin directions $d_i \in \{\pm 1\}$,

$$\begin{bmatrix} T_{\text{phys}} \\ \tau_{\text{phys}} \end{bmatrix} = \underbrace{\begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 & 1 \\ -l & l & l & -l \\ -l & l & -l & l \\ -k_m & -k_m & k_m & k_m \end{bmatrix}}_{M} \begin{bmatrix} F_1 \\ F_2 \\ F_3 \\ F_4 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad F_i = k_f \omega_i^2, \tag{3.21}$$

whose rows are $T_{\text{phys}} = \sum_i F_i$, $\tau_x = \sum_i y_i F_i$, $\tau_y = -\sum_i x_i F_i$ and $\tau_z = -k_m \sum_i d_i F_i$, with $k_f = 8.55 \times 10^{-6}\,\text{N s}^2$ and yaw-reaction coefficient $k_m = 0.016\,\text{m}$. The first two moment components are lever-arm products; the third is the aerodynamic reaction torque, proportional to rotor thrust and opposed to the rotor's own spin.

This is a wrench, not a state estimate. Equation (3.21) returns the wrench the *actuators generate*. It excludes $J_T \dot{\omega}$ and rotor gyroscopic terms, which is what makes it usable as the known input u^{phys} of the estimator rather than as a second, competing estimate of the state. The deployed estimator uses only its first row, T_{phys}; the full-state estimator uses all four. Rotor speeds are sampled at 250 Hz and averaged over each 10 Hz estimation interval, consistent with a zero-order-hold discretisation of (3.7) and (3.9).

Why the commanded input cannot be used. Let the controller compute its thrust command from an assumed mass $\tilde{m}$, so that in hover $T_{\text{cmd}} = \tilde{m} g$. Feeding T_{cmd} into (3.7) and solving for the mass yields $m_T = T_{\text{cmd}}/g = \tilde{m}$ for *any* $\tilde{m}$: the relation is satisfied identically, the residual carries no information, and the estimate would reproduce whatever the controller already believed. Any inversion error, saturation or motor lag between command and rotor is likewise invisible. Equation (3.21) breaks this circularity because rotor speeds are a physical measurement into which no model state enters, taken downstream of allocation and the motor dynamics. The principle recurs throughout the design: an adaptive loop must be fed by a signal that is not itself a product of the

adaptation. The difference is not academic; the executed yaw torque recorded in flight is about a third of the intended value (Section 5.1).

3.5.2 The interface to the autopilot

The deployed system is a cascade: the predictive controller is the outer loop, and the autopilot's body-rate controller and mixer are the inner loop. Three torque-like quantities exist in it and must not be confused.

1. The *predicted torque* τ is a decision variable of the controller's problem. It shapes the predicted state trajectory through (4.9) and never leaves the solver.

2. The *body-rate setpoint* is what the autopilot receives. After each solve the controller publishes, at 50 Hz, a collective thrust and a body-rate setpoint interpolated along the latest predicted trajectory: the thrust from the predicted input sequence, converted to a normalised throttle by (4.28), and the body rate from the predicted state sequence one stage ahead, starting at its second node. The roll and pitch rate setpoints are then scaled for the payload inertia (Section 4.6). The autopilot's rate loop and mixer turn this setpoint into rotor commands.

3. The *physical torque* τ_{phys} is what the rotors actually produced, reconstructed from measured rotor speeds by (3.21). It is the only torque the full-state estimator sees; the deployed estimator sees no torque at all.

The division is deliberate: the rate loop runs at a bandwidth the 20 Hz solver cannot match, and leaving allocation on the autopilot keeps saturation handling next to the hardware. It is also why the estimator evaluates M in the *forward* direction from measured rotor speeds rather than reading τ off the solver: M applied to what the motors did is a measurement, whereas τ from the solver

is an intention. The ROS layer never evaluates the inverse allocation; its role in sizing the controller's input bounds is discussed with the actuator envelope in Section 4.4.4.

Figure 3.1 traces the complete accounting: what is measured, what is estimated, what is generated by algebra, where each quantity is consumed, and how the loop closes.

3.6 Modelling Assumptions and Limitations

The relations of this chapter fall into two classes, and the distinction matters for how the results should be read.

Relations that hold exactly. For a payload on the thrust axis, the vertical displacement (3.11) of the centre of mass is collinear with the thrust, so the thrust produces no moment about the composite centre of mass; this is a consequence of geometry, not an omitted term. The increment (3.13) is exact for a rigid pair of point masses, and the yaw increment of (3.14) is exactly zero for a point mass on the yaw axis.

The remaining relations are approximations whose validity depends on the operating condition.

The payload is assumed centred. The model sets the horizontal attachment offset to zero. A residual offset r_{xy} left by imperfect alignment produces a constant trim moment $m_P g\, r_{xy}$ and a roll/pitch inertia error μr_{xy}^2. At the 0.03 m attachment tolerance of the gripper and 0.30 kg these are 0.09 N m, or 18 % of the roll authority, and 0.4 % of the increment. The first is supplied by the integral action of the autopilot's rate loop; the second is negligible.

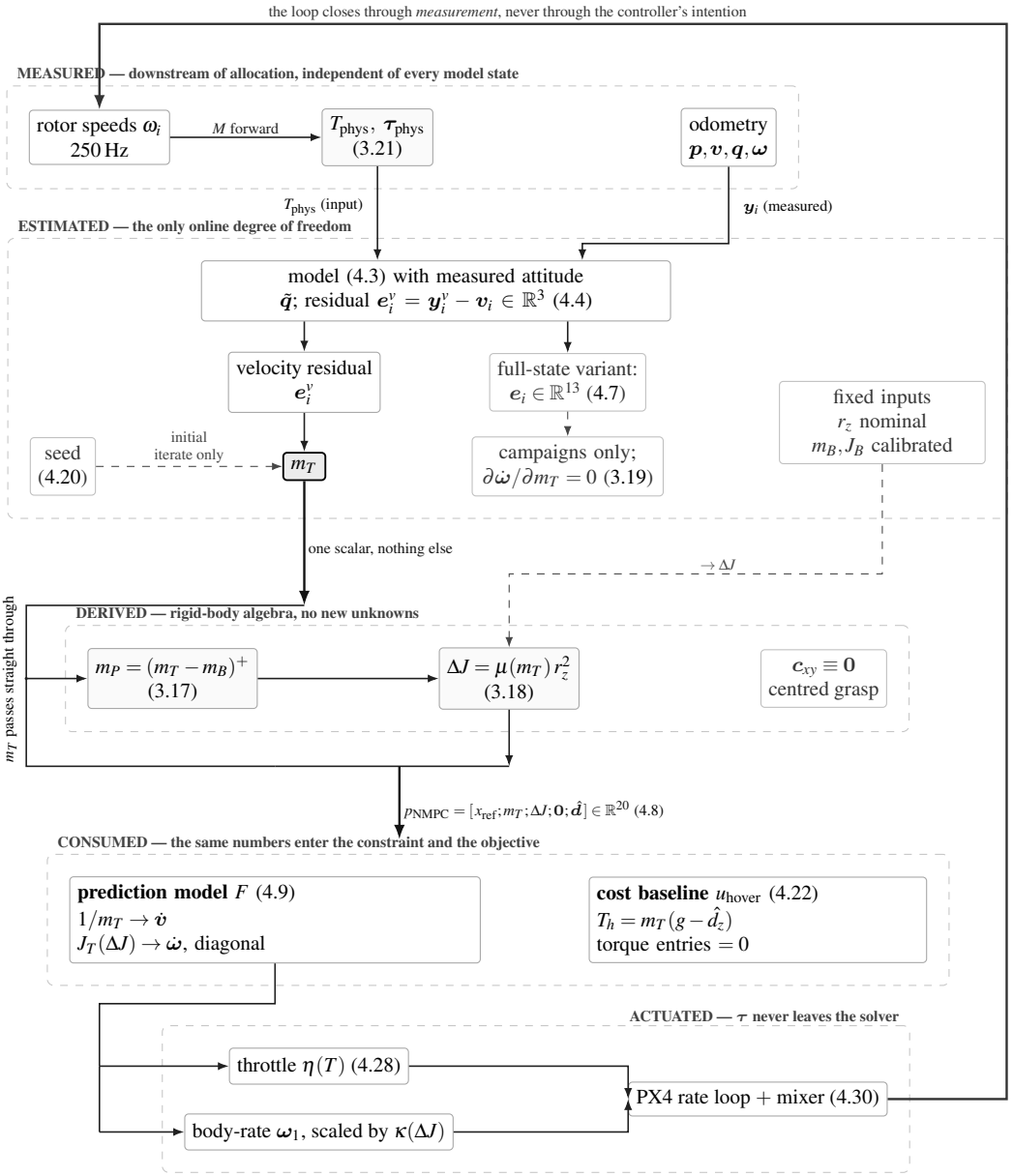


Figure 3.1: How the payload parameter reaches the controller. In the deployed estimator the window's measured velocities and its known inputs — the measured attitude and the reconstructed thrust — meet in one velocity residual (4.4)**, which identifies the single boxed decision variable. The full-state estimator of the evaluation campaigns (grey) used the thirteen-state residual** (4.7)**, whose angular-rate block constrained the vehicle's own attitude and rate but, by** (3.19)**, not the mass directly. Everything in the DERIVED band follows from m_T by the algebra of Section 3.3 and introduces neither a new unknown nor a new sensor; the inertia increment vanishes by itself when the estimate returns to the bare airframe, so no release event is needed to remove it. In the full-state estimator the same increment, lagged by one solve** (3.20)**, was also written into its rotational model as a known parameter; the deployed estimator has no rotational model. The horizontal-offset parameters are held at zero by the operating condition, not estimated. The loop closes through measured rotor speeds, never through the moment the solver intended. The residual specific force $\hat{d}$ in the controller's parameter vector is estimated from the same measurements but is not a payload parameter (Section 4.4.3).**

The arm is nominal, not measured. Both optimisers use $r_z = -0.27\,\mathrm{m}$ for every flight. The realised arm is set by the height at which the vehicle grasps the parcel, which is commanded in the autopilot's local frame whose vertical zero drifts from flight to flight; it varies between about 0.25 m and 0.30 m. Over that range the true increment for 0.30 kg lies between 0.0164 and $0.0236\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$ against the modelled $0.0191\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$ — an error of -14 to $+23$ percent, and a true inertia ratio between 2.15 and 2.66 against the modelled 2.34. Every result in this dissertation carries an arm error of this size, unmeasured on a per-flight basis.

The parcel's own inertia is neglected. The payload is treated as a point mass. A box of side 0.15 m has a central inertia of about $0.004\,m_P$, about 2 % of the roll/pitch increment and the only yaw contribution of a centred load.

The airframe rotational model is approximate. The calibrated airframe inertia $J_{xx} = 0.0142\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$ is about 60 % of the value in the simulator's model description, and a least-squares fit of bare-airframe pitch dynamics recovered an effective inertia 1.07–1.18 times the latter; rotor drag acting through the vertical offset of the rotor plane produces a velocity-dependent body moment that (3.9) does not contain; and a constant torque bias of order 0.01 N m appears in the reconstructed torque of an unloaded vehicle. These errors are the reason the mass is kept off the rotational channel, and the reason the deployed estimator does not integrate that channel at all (Section 3.4.2). They remain in the controller's prediction model, where they appear as an unmodelled moment that the rate loop absorbs.

The full-state estimator's inertia lags its mass by one solve. The deployed estimator carries no inertia; in the full-state estimator the lagged treatment (3.20) evaluates the increment at the previous solution, so during a grasp or release

the estimator's inertia trails the true value by one 0.1 s solve, and under sustained manoeuvre a biased mass estimate is fed back into the next window's rotational model. The treatment reduces the loaded mass bias but does not remove it (Section 5.7.2).

The inertia is treated as constant across a transfer. Equation (3.9) omits the $\dot{J}_T\boldsymbol{\omega}$ term that a time-varying inertia would contribute. The omission is exact on either side of a grasp or release and wrong only for the duration of the transfer itself; within the estimator the affected samples fall inside a single window and are absorbed as process noise.

The rotor model is static. The thrust coefficient k_f is a constant, and is known to lose validity under large induced inflow during fast translation [34]; the mass channel recovers m_T from an absolute thrust and inherits any error in k_f in full. The yaw reaction of (3.21) is the steady-state term only, omitting the rotor angular-acceleration contribution $\sum_i J_r \dot{\omega}_i$, and rotor gyroscopic moments are not modelled. These terms are negligible in hover and mild manoeuvre but not during rapid yaw. Because m_T is recovered from an absolute thrust, a relative error in k_f passes one-for-one into $\hat{m}$; this sensitivity is analytical and has not been measured in the evaluated configuration (Section 5.9). Translational data cannot separate the two: the deployed estimator flags a thrust-map error that drives its estimate outside a physical band (Section 4.3.3) but does not correct it.

3.7 Chapter Summary

This chapter addressed the first research objective and the structural part of the second. For a rigid payload grasped on the thrust axis, the roll and pitch inertia increment is the reduced mass times the square of the vertical arm, so the

composite mass is the only payload quantity that has to be identified online; the inertia follows from it algebraically and vanishes with it. The mass is identified on the translational channel, from a thrust reconstructed from measured rotor speeds. The deployed estimator does not integrate the rotational dynamics at all — the measured attitude enters as a known input — so the optimiser cannot use the mass to absorb rotational model error; the full-state estimator of the evaluation campaigns achieved a weaker form of the same separation by carrying the inertia as a parameter lagged by one solve. The structure rests on stated assumptions — a centred grasp, a nominal arm and a calibrated rotor model — whose limits are collected in Section 3.6. What remains open is the numerical form of the estimator and the controller, and how a release is recognised; Chapter 4 takes these up.

Chapter 4

The MHE–NMPC Framework

Chapter 3 established *what* is estimated and why. This chapter states *how*. Section 4.2 collects the models in one place — the deployed velocity–mass estimator, the full-state estimator with which the evaluation campaigns were flown, and the controller's prediction model. Sections 4.3 and 4.4 give the two optimal control problems built on them, Section 4.5 the interface that carries the estimate from one to the other, Section 4.6 the inner-loop scheduling that consumes the same estimate, and Section 4.7 the logic that decides when the controller may believe that its payload has gone.

The estimator receives no attach or release notification. The controller's model parameters follow the estimate continuously, and a release is *accepted* — declared complete, with auxiliary states reset — only on persistent estimator evidence. Section 4.7.1 separates what that acceptance does from what the continuous adaptation does, and Section 4.7.6 states what a mass-only lifecycle cannot do.

4.1 Closed-Loop Architecture

Figure 4.1 shows the information flow. Three layers are involved: the physics and flight stack (Gazebo, PX4 software-in-the-loop, and a magnetic detachable-

joint gripper that produces genuine mass and inertia changes); the inner rate-control loop on the autopilot; and a ROS outer loop containing the estimator and the predictive controller.

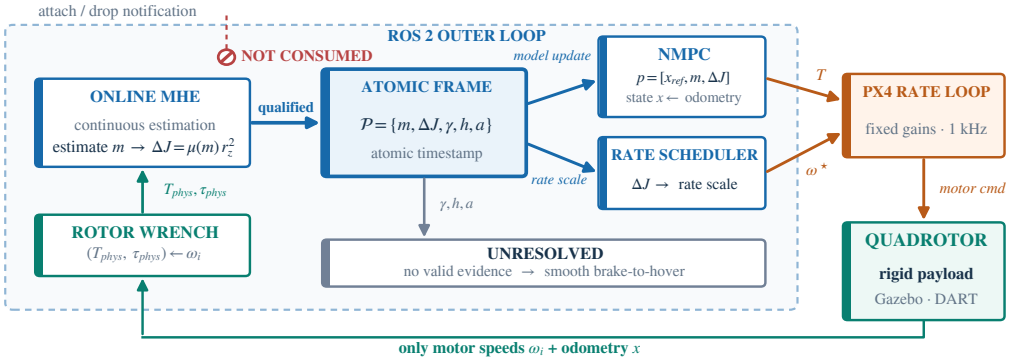


Figure 4.1: System architecture and information flow. The complete pipeline consumes only rotor speeds and odometry. One atomic, health-gated frame carrying the composite mass and the inertia increment derived from it drives both the NMPC model and the continuous body-rate command scheduling. No attach or release notification enters this path.

Two properties of this diagram carry the argument of the dissertation.

First, **the only inputs are odometry and rotor speeds.** The estimator does not read the controller's intended thrust or torque (Section 3.5), does not read the gripper's attach or release record, and does not read the simulator's joint state. The payload truth available in simulation is used exclusively for offline scoring.

Second, **there is exactly one interface.** The estimator publishes a single atomic frame (Section 4.5) containing the mass, the derived inertia, a no-payload evidence score and a health flag. Both consumers — the NMPC model parameters and the inner-loop command scaling — read that one frame. An earlier design in which mass and inertia travelled on separate topics, each with its own latency and validity, made it possible for the controller to hold a mutually inconsistent parameter set; the atomic frame makes that class of fault unrepresentable.

The two optimisers run at different rates and do not share a solve clock. The estimator solves at 10 Hz over a 2 s window; the controller solves at 20 Hz over

a 1 s preview; setpoints are published at 50 Hz by interpolating along the most recent predicted trajectory.

4.2 Estimator and Controller Models

Chapter 3 derived one plant model: the kinematics (3.5)–(3.6), the translational and rotational dynamics (3.7) and (3.9), and the payload algebra that makes the inertia increment a function of the composite mass, (3.18). The estimator and the controller each keep only the part of that model they need, and they keep different parts. This section states the models side by side, so that the optimisation problems of Sections 4.3 and 4.4 can refer to one place. Two estimator models are described: the *reduced* velocity–mass estimator, which is the deployed default, and the *full-state* estimator with which the evaluation campaigns of Chapter 5 were flown. They are selected by one switch and share every interface, so the rest of this chapter applies to both unless stated otherwise. Table 4.1 summarises the three models.

4.2.1 The deployed estimator: velocity and mass

The deployed estimator keeps the composite mass and the world-frame velocity, and nothing else,

$$x_{\mathrm{R}} = \left[\, \boldsymbol{v};\, m_T \,\right] \in \mathbb{R}^4, \qquad \dot{m}_T = 0. \tag{4.1}$$

Its known parameters at stage j of the window are the measured attitude and the reconstructed collective thrust,

$$p_{\mathrm{R},j} = \left[\, \tilde{\boldsymbol{q}}_j;\, T_{\mathrm{phys},j} \,\right] \in \mathbb{R}^5, \qquad \tilde{\boldsymbol{q}}_j = \frac{\boldsymbol{q}_j^{\mathrm{meas}}}{\|\boldsymbol{q}_j^{\mathrm{meas}}\|}, \tag{4.2}$$

where $\boldsymbol{q}_j^{\mathrm{meas}}$ is the odometry attitude at the start of the stage and $T_{\mathrm{phys},j}$ is (3.21) averaged over the stage interval. The model is the translational dynamics

Table 4.1: The three models of one plant. R is the deployed estimator, F the full-state estimator used in the evaluation campaigns, and the right-hand column the controller's prediction model. Equation numbers refer to the definitions.

	Reduced estimator R (deployed)	**Full-state estimator F** (campaigns)	**NMPC prediction model**
State	$[\boldsymbol{v}; m_T] \in \mathbb{R}^4$ (4.1)	$[\boldsymbol{p}; \boldsymbol{v}; \boldsymbol{q}; \boldsymbol{\omega}; m_T] \in \mathbb{R}^{14}$ (4.5)	$[\boldsymbol{p}; \boldsymbol{v}; \boldsymbol{q}; \boldsymbol{\omega}] \in \mathbb{R}^{13}$ (3.1)
Known inputs and parameters	measured attitude $\tilde{\boldsymbol{q}}$, T_{phys}; $\mathbb{R}^5$ (4.2)	T_{phys}, $\boldsymbol{\tau}_{\text{phys}}$, lagged ΔJ, $\boldsymbol{c}_{xy} = \mathbf{0}$; $\mathbb{R}^7$ (4.6)	reference, m_T, ΔJ, $\boldsymbol{c}_{xy} = \mathbf{0}$, $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$; $\mathbb{R}^{20}$ (4.8)
Dynamics	translational only, attitude supplied (4.3)	(3.5), (3.6), (3.7), (3.9) with $J_T(\Delta J^{\text{lag}})$	(4.9)
Where the payload enters	$1/m_T$ in $\dot{\boldsymbol{v}}$; m_T a decision variable	$1/m_T$ in $\dot{\boldsymbol{v}}$ (decision variable); ΔJ a known parameter, (3.20)	$1/m_T$ and $\Delta J(m_T)$, runtime parameters
Rotational dynamics	not integrated	integrated; $\partial\dot{\boldsymbol{\omega}}/\partial m_T = 0$ (3.19)	integrated with $J_T(\Delta J)$
Residual	velocity $\boldsymbol{e}^v \in \mathbb{R}^3$ (4.4)	full state $\boldsymbol{e} \in \mathbb{R}^{13}$ (4.7)	tracking and input deviation (4.23)
Rate, horizon	10 Hz, $N = 20$, $\Delta t = 0.1$ s	same	20 Hz, $N = 20$, $\Delta t = 0.05$ s

Implementation switch: `MHE_MODEL_VARIANT=reduced` or `full`. Since 5 November 2026 the experiment entry points default to `reduced`; the library default of the estimator node remains `full`.

(3.7) with the attitude supplied rather than integrated,

$$\dot{\boldsymbol{v}} = \frac{1}{m_T}\Big(\frac{R(\tilde{\boldsymbol{q}})\,\boldsymbol{e}_3}{\|\tilde{\boldsymbol{q}}\|^2}\,T_{\text{phys}} - k_d\,\boldsymbol{v}\Big) - g\,\boldsymbol{e}_3 + \boldsymbol{w}, \qquad \dot{m}_T = 0, \tag{4.3}$$

with velocity process noise $\boldsymbol{w} \in \mathbb{R}^3$. The stage residual is the velocity block alone,

$$\boldsymbol{e}^v_j = \boldsymbol{y}^v_j - \boldsymbol{v}_j \in \mathbb{R}^3. \tag{4.4}$$

Three properties of the attitude input are deliberate. First, every entry of (3.3) is a quadratic form in $\boldsymbol{q}$, so $R(\boldsymbol{q}) = \|\boldsymbol{q}\|^2 R(\boldsymbol{q}/\|\boldsymbol{q}\|)$; dividing by $\|\tilde{\boldsymbol{q}}\|^2$ in (4.3) normalises the attitude inside the model as well as before it, and a non-unit odometry quaternion cannot rescale the thrust. Second, the same quadratic form makes $R(\boldsymbol{q}) = R(-\boldsymbol{q})$ exactly, so the double cover of the rotation group needs no hemisphere alignment. Third, the attitude is an input and not a state: the cost contains no quaternion residual, neither a component-wise difference nor a norm penalty.

Why is this enough? The composite mass enters the plant at exactly one place, the gain $1/m_T$ of (3.7) (Section 3.2.2). Position kinematics, attitude kinematics and Euler's equation contain no mass, so given the direction and the magnitude of the thrust, the velocity response carries all the information about m_T that the window holds. What a full-state estimator adds is an *estimated* attitude trajectory, and that is precisely the indirect path by which errors in the rotational model reached the mass (Section 3.4.2). Supplying the measured attitude closes that path by construction: no inertia, no torque, no vertical arm and no lagged increment enters the estimator at all. The price is that attitude measurement noise enters the thrust direction unfiltered. At the attitude noise assumed for the full-state estimator ($\sigma_q = 0.01$, about 1.1°) it perturbs the vertical thrust component by less than $0.02\,\%$ and the horizontal components by up to $2\,\%$ per sample, zero-mean, which the window averages. The simulator's odometry is close to ideal, so this argument is not tested by the experiments of Chapter 5.

The model has four states instead of fourteen and three noise channels instead of thirteen, so the quadratic subproblem is an order of magnitude smaller; Section 5.7.3 reports the solve times.

4.2.2 The full-state estimator used in the evaluation campaigns

The cohort and the release campaign of Chapter 5 were flown with an estimator that integrates the complete vehicle model and augments the composite mass into its state,

$$x_{\text{aug}} = \left[x;\, m_T\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{14}, \qquad \dot{m_T} = 0, \tag{4.5}$$

holding it constant across the horizon so that a window of measurements constrains a single value rather than a free trajectory. Process noise is admitted on the thirteen physical states only; noise on the mass channel would let it drift within the window and dissolve the constraint that makes the estimate meaning-

ful. The reduced estimator applies the same rule to its own states.

Its runtime parameter vector carries the reconstructed wrench of Section 3.5 and a three-element slot of known geometry,

$$p_{\mathrm{MHE}} = \left[T_{\mathrm{phys}};\ \boldsymbol{\tau}_{\mathrm{phys}};\ \Delta J^{\mathrm{est}};\ c_x^{\mathrm{est}};\ c_y^{\mathrm{est}} \right] \in \mathbb{R}^7, \tag{4.6}$$

which enters its rotational model as a fixed inertia increment and a fixed thrust-offset moment. In the evaluated configuration the first entry carries the lagged increment (3.20) and the two offsets are zero; the omitted treatment sets all three to zero. In neither case is the slot a function of the decision variable, which is how (3.19) is enforced.

Its stage cost is built on one measurement residual. Writing $\boldsymbol{y}_i$ for the odometry measurement at stage i of the window and x_i for the physical part of the estimator's trajectory at that stage,

$$\boldsymbol{e}_i \;=\; \boldsymbol{y}_i - x_i \;=\; \left[\boldsymbol{e}_i^{p};\ \boldsymbol{e}_i^{v};\ \boldsymbol{e}_i^{q};\ \boldsymbol{e}_i^{\omega} \right] \in \mathbb{R}^{13}. \tag{4.7}$$

The *velocity residual* and the *angular-rate residual* referred to throughout are the blocks $\boldsymbol{e}^{v}$ and $\boldsymbol{e}^{\omega}$ of this vector; the reduced estimator's residual (4.4) is its velocity block alone. Neither residual contains an acceleration: the trajectory is produced by integrating the dynamics forward under the known input, so the comparison is between velocities, never between a measured and a modelled acceleration. Differentiating the odometry velocity would amplify its noise by $1/\Delta t$, to the order of the very effect being estimated.

By (3.19), the full-state estimator also identifies the mass through the velocity residual. Its angular-rate residual constrains the attitude and rate trajectories, and reaches the mass through the estimated attitude, which sets the thrust direction in (3.7); this is the path that the reduced estimator removes. The attitude block $\boldsymbol{e}^{q}$ of (4.7) is a component-wise quaternion difference; the reduced estimator

has no attitude residual of any form.

4.2.3 The controller's prediction model

The predictive controller carries the payload parameters as runtime values,

$$p_{\mathrm{NMPC}} = \left[x_{\mathrm{ref}}(13);\, m_T;\, \Delta J;\, \boldsymbol{c}_{xy}(2);\, \hat{\boldsymbol{d}}(3)\right] \in \mathbb{R}^{20}, \tag{4.8}$$

where m_T is the published mass estimate, ΔJ is (3.18) evaluated at it, the two horizontal-offset entries $\boldsymbol{c}_{xy}$ are held at zero (assumption 2), and $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ is the residual specific force of Section 4.4.3. The offset entries remain because the same generated solver also served the eccentric-grasp configuration of Section 5.7.4. The prediction model is the plant model of Section 3.2 with these parameters substituted,

$$\begin{aligned}
&\dot{\boldsymbol{p}} = \boldsymbol{v}, \qquad \dot{\boldsymbol{q}} = \tfrac{1}{2}\,\Xi(\boldsymbol{q})\,\boldsymbol{\omega},\\
&\dot{\boldsymbol{v}} = \frac{1}{m_T}\Big(R(\boldsymbol{q})\,\boldsymbol{e}_3\,T - k_d\,\boldsymbol{v}\Big) - g\,\boldsymbol{e}_3 + \hat{\boldsymbol{d}},\\
&\dot{\boldsymbol{\omega}} = J_T^{-1}\Big(\boldsymbol{\tau} - \boldsymbol{\omega}\times J_T\,\boldsymbol{\omega}\Big), \quad J_T = \mathrm{diag}\big(J_{xx}+\Delta J, J_{yy}+\Delta J, J_{zz}\big).
\end{aligned} \tag{4.9}$$

Apart from the additive residual $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$, nothing in (4.9) is new: the pair $(m_T, \Delta J)$ are the only payload quantities that change from one solve to the next, each enters at exactly one place, and the second is a function of the first. The controller is the only one of the three models that needs the inertia, and it obtains it from the estimate rather than estimating it.

The published mass is not the raw estimate. The estimator publishes $m_B + m_P^{\mathrm{out}}$, where m_P^{out} is the positive part (3.17) passed through a first-order filter, so the published mass never falls below m_B; the controller filters and rate-limits it again (Section 4.5.2). With the full-state estimator the two optimisers evaluate the inertia increment at different points — the controller at the filtered, pub-

lished estimate, the estimator at its own previous solution; the reduced estimator carries no inertia at all. In no case is the inertia a function of a decision variable. Neither estimator has a counterpart of $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$, so a persistent residual cannot be used there to explain away a mass change.

4.3 Moving Horizon Estimator

4.3.1 The optimisation

Both estimator models of Section 4.2 are solved as the same constrained least-squares problem. At each 10 Hz tick the estimator solves

$$\begin{aligned} \min_{x_{0:N},\, w_{0:N-1}} \quad & \left\|x_0 - \bar{x}_0\right\|_{W_0}^2 + \sum_{j=0}^{N-1} \beta_j \Big(\left\|y_j - C x_j\right\|_{W_y}^2 + \left\|w_j\right\|_{W_w}^2 \Big) \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x_{j+1} = F_{\mathrm{M}}\big(x_j,\, p_j\big) + G w_j, \\ & \underline{m} \le m_T \le \overline{m}, \end{aligned} \tag{4.10}$$

where F_{M} is one explicit fourth-order Runge–Kutta step of the estimator model driven by its known inputs p_j, y_j is the odometry measurement and C selects the measured part of the state. For the reduced estimator, x is (4.1), p_j is (4.2), $C = [I_3 \;\; 0]$ selects the velocity and F_{M} integrates (4.3); for the full-state estimator, x is (4.5), p_j is the reconstructed wrench u^{phys} of (3.21) with the geometry slot of (4.6), and C selects the thirteen vehicle states. In both,

$$G = \begin{bmatrix} I_{n_w} \\ 0_{1\times n_w} \end{bmatrix}, \qquad n_w = 3 \;\text{(reduced)}, \quad n_w = 13 \;\text{(full state)}, \tag{4.11}$$

confines the process noise to the physical states, leaving m_T noise-free within the window.

Measurements and inputs are aligned the same way in both models. Stage j

pairs the measurement y_j taken at the start of the interval with the input averaged over that interval; the newest measurement y_N enters only as the terminal node of the trajectory and carries no cost.

The horizon is $N = 20$ stages at $\Delta t = 0.1\,\mathrm{s}$. The choice is a compromise: a longer window averages more measurement noise, but the constraint that makes the mass identifiable — that it is *constant* over the window — becomes less defensible the longer the arc of trajectory the window spans. In development flights with the full-state estimator in an earlier configuration, on a $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ figure-eight a ten-stage window recovered the mass $3.7\times$ more accurately than a twenty-stage one, while a forty-stage window sat on the lower bound for the entire flight. The horizon was not varied in the evaluated configuration, and it is the same for the two estimators.

4.3.2 Weights

All weight matrices follow Bryson's rule, with each diagonal entry set by a representative residual magnitude. This keeps the residual blocks on comparable numerical scales.

For the full-state estimator the measurement weight uses representative state-estimation standard deviations,

$$W_y = \mathrm{diag}\Big(\sigma_p^{-2} I_3,\ \sigma_v^{-2} I_3,\ \sigma_q^{-2} I_4,\ \sigma_\omega^{-2} I_3\Big), \tag{4.12}$$

with $\sigma_p = 0.02\,\mathrm{m}$, $\sigma_v = 0.05\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, $\sigma_q = 0.01$ (about 1.1°) and $\sigma_\omega = 0.02\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$.

The process-noise weight is deliberately *tighter* than the measurement weight,

$$W_w = \mathrm{diag}\big(10^4 I_6,\ 10^5 I_4,\ 10^3 I_3\big). \tag{4.13}$$

The tight translational block forces persistent disagreement between measured

motion and reconstructed thrust to be explained by the mass rather than by unstructured process noise. The angular block is one decade looser because the rotational equation is numerically more delicate and carries the modelling errors identified in Section 3.4.2.

The arrival cost anchors the start of the window,

$$W_0 = \mathrm{diag}\big(10^3 I_6,\ 10^4 I_4,\ 10^2 I_3,\ \sigma_{m,0}^{-2}\big), \qquad \sigma_{m,0} = 3.16\,\mathrm{kg}, \tag{4.14}$$

with $\bar{x}_0$ taken from the previous window shifted by one stage. The mass anchor is deliberately four to five orders of magnitude softer than the physical-state entries: it carries negligible prior information but remains non-zero so that a poorly excited window retains positive curvature in the mass direction. Setting it to zero produced 472 solver failures in an earlier configuration.

The reduced estimator uses exactly the velocity and mass entries of these matrices,

$$W_y^{\mathrm{R}} = \sigma_v^{-2} I_3, \qquad W_w^{\mathrm{R}} = 10^4 I_3, \qquad W_0^{\mathrm{R}} = \mathrm{diag}\big(10^3 I_3,\ \sigma_{m,0}^{-2}\big), \tag{4.15}$$

so the evidence on which the two estimators base the mass — the velocity residual, the translational process noise and the arrival anchor — is weighted identically, and the comparison of Section 5.7.3 isolates the model structure rather than a retuning.

4.3.3 Mass bounds and the mass-health check

Full-state estimator. The composite mass is constrained to $[0.95\,m_B,\ 5.0\,\mathrm{kg}] = [1.961\,\mathrm{kg}, 5.0\,\mathrm{kg}]$: the vehicle cannot weigh less than its airframe, while the 5 % margin leaves room for calibration error. The estimator imposes this interval as a hard constraint. Under a thrust-map error that hard bound acts as

a prior: a thrust map reading 10 % low requires an empty-airframe estimate of $0.9\,m_B = 1.858\,\mathrm{kg}$, below the bound, and the estimate is held at the bound rather than revealing the error. A replay of the reduced model over the 312 release-campaign flights with the same bound (Section 5.7.3) ended 107 solves at the iteration limit, all of them in the $-10\,\%$ condition and at or near the bound.

Reduced estimator. The reduced estimator separates the numerical bound from the physical judgement. Its box, $[0.70\,m_B,\ 5.0\,\mathrm{kg}] = [1.445\,\mathrm{kg}, 5.0\,\mathrm{kg}]$, only prevents the $1/m_T$ singularity and run-away iterates and is wide enough for a thrust-map error of about 30 % to appear in the estimate. Whether the estimate is *physically credible* is decided after each solve by a separate check against a health band,

$$m_B - 0.10\,\mathrm{kg} \;\le\; \hat{m} \;\le\; m_B + m_P^{\mathrm{env}} + 0.10\,\mathrm{kg}, \qquad \text{i.e.} \quad [1.964\,\mathrm{kg},\ 2.464\,\mathrm{kg}], \tag{4.16}$$

where $m_P^{\mathrm{env}} = 0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$ is the platform's payload envelope (Section 3.4.3). An estimate below the band is flagged as a possible thrust-map *under*-estimate, one above it as out of envelope or a thrust-map *over*-estimate; an estimate within 2 g of the numerical box, or a non-finite one, is flagged as well. The flag takes effect on the first offending solve and is cleared only after ten consecutive solves inside the band (1 s). The margins come from the replay: under the nominal thrust map the reduced estimate ranged over 1.985 kg to 2.368 kg across 264 flights and never left (4.16). No simulator truth is used by the check.

A flagged estimate is not forwarded. The frame is marked unhealthy, so the controller keeps the last accepted model (Section 4.5.1), and the estimator records the reason. The check *detects*; it does not correct. Translational data alone cannot separate the mass from a scale error in the thrust map — (4.3) depends on them only through T_{phys}/m_T — so the estimator does not attempt to estimate both, and a thrust-map error is detected only when it drives the

estimate out of (4.16). A $-10\,\%$ map on the empty airframe ($\hat{m} \approx 1.86\,\mathrm{kg}$) and a $10\,\%$ map with the heavier payload ($\hat{m} \approx 2.60\,\mathrm{kg}$) are detected; a $-10\,\%$ map with the heavier payload ($\hat{m} \approx 2.13\,\mathrm{kg}$) is not.

Prior-free ablation. A switch removes the remaining airframe-mass information from the full-state estimator by lowering the bound to $0.2\,\mathrm{kg}$ and setting $\sigma_{m,0} = 1000\,\mathrm{kg}$. It is an ablation, not the evaluated default; the measurement-derived seed below is prior-free in either configuration.

4.3.4 Input gating and the grasp gap

The reconstructed wrench is admitted as a known input only while the odometry height exceeds $0.5\,\mathrm{m}$ and the collective thrust exceeds $1\,\mathrm{N}$; near the ground the support force decouples T_{phys} from $m_T g$. If any input is older than $0.30\,\mathrm{s}$ the window is discarded, the frame is marked unhealthy, and the window is rebuilt once fresh data return. The grasp hover at $0.35\,\mathrm{m}$ lies below the gate. In each of the ten flights inspected, of both estimators, the window was therefore discarded during the final descent, 1–3 seconds before the gripper registered the attach, and rebuilt about six seconds later, after lift-off had begun. The grasp itself is never inside a window: the loaded estimate starts afresh from the window-balance seed below, and the attach-time convergence reported in Chapter 5 is dominated by this gap and the subsequent window fill, not by the estimator's own dynamics.

4.3.5 Initialisation

The estimator requires an initial iterate for the mass channel. Supplying the calibrated airframe mass would be a prior about the answer; the implementation instead constructs the seed from measurements.

The simplest form is the hover approximation obtained by setting $a_z = 0$ and $\phi = \theta = 0$ in the vertical force balance (3.8),

$$m^{(0)} = \mathrm{clip}\left(\frac{T_{\mathrm{phys}}}{g},\, \underline{m},\, \overline{m}\right), \tag{4.17}$$

which is prior-free because T_{phys} comes from (3.21) and involves no model state. It is valid only near hover: in development flights on a $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ figure-eight the instantaneous ratio T_{phys}/g swung from $-42\,\%$ to $30\,\%$ of the true mass, because the collective thrust also supplies centripetal acceleration and is tilted away from the vertical.

The deployed seed therefore uses the whole window. Summing (3.8) over the N stages,

$$m_T \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} \left(g + a_{z,i}\right) \;=\; \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} T_i \cos\phi_i \cos\theta_i, \tag{4.18}$$

and eliminating the accelerations by the telescoping identity

$$\sum_{i=0}^{N-1} a_{z,i} = \sum_{i=0}^{N-1} \frac{v_{z,i+1} - v_{z,i}}{\Delta t} = \frac{v_{z,N} - v_{z,0}}{\Delta t}, \tag{4.19}$$

gives a seed that requires no numerical differentiation of the velocity signal:

$$m^{(0)} \;=\; \frac{\displaystyle\sum_{i=0}^{N-1} T_i \cos\phi_i \cos\theta_i}{Ng + \dfrac{v_{z,N} - v_{z,0}}{\Delta t}}. \tag{4.20}$$

Only the two velocity endpoints of the window enter, so the seed is immune to the sample-to-sample noise a finite-difference acceleration would amplify; the tilt factor restores the vertical component that (4.17) discards; and every input is either T_{phys} or odometry, so the seed is decoupled from the estimator's own state. The implementation falls back to (4.17), and then to a neutral box value, when the window is not yet full or the denominator of (4.20) degenerates.

The seed enters the solver in two places: the initial iterate of the sequential

quadratic programme, and the mean of the arrival cost. The former affects only the number of iterations, never the optimum. The latter affects the optimum in proportion to its weight, which by (4.14) corresponds to a standard deviation of several kilograms — far wider than the range of masses the vehicle can carry. The seed therefore influences where the optimiser starts, not where it converges. The same expression is used on re-initialisation after repeated solver failure (Section 4.3.7).

4.3.6 Stage weighting: what was tried and what is in effect

The constant-payload model is invalid when a grasp or release lies inside the window, so three alternatives to uniform weighting were implemented. Their role and disposition are summarised in Table 4.2; the experimental negative result on learned weights belongs to Section 5.7.5.

Table 4.2: Stage-weight alternatives considered for the MHE. They apply to both estimators; for the reduced estimator the de-weighting matrices are rebuilt on its own velocity, noise and arrival blocks.

Treatment	Status	Reason
Uniform, $\beta_j \equiv 1$	in effect in almost every flight	no event logic; accepts a transient of roughly one window
Residual-triggered de-weighting (pre-event stages $\times 10^{-4}$ after a collective-thrust step above 4.4 N for two frames)	enabled, rarely effective	collective-thrust steps also occur at trajectory changes; a grasp detection mostly falls inside the gap of Section 4.3.4, so the de-weighted stages have left the window before solving resumes
Exponential forgetting, $\beta_j = \lambda^{N-1-j}$	available, off ($\lambda = 1$)	shortens effective memory smoothly but did not justify another tuning dimension
Mass random walk	available, off	permits within-window change but degraded Hessian conditioning

The de-weighting row needs a number. Across the 312 flights of the release campaign the trigger fired in 81 flights, but the stage weights of a solved window were changed in only 10; in the others the detection fell inside the grasp

gap or was overtaken by the window rebuild. The same default was active in the cohort, where its activations were not counted. The evaluated design therefore effectively tolerates the change transient rather than detecting it, and the lifecycle below is designed around that delay.

4.3.7 Solver failure and re-initialisation

A solve that ends with a non-zero status, or with a non-finite iterate, is discarded. The published estimate is not updated from it and the frame is marked unhealthy. After five consecutive failures the window is discarded and rebuilt: the physical states are reset to the current measurement and the mass is re-seeded from (4.20). Re-seeding from a measurement rather than from the last accepted estimate matters because a run of failures is itself evidence that the last estimate may be corrupt; the window balance is the only mass value available at that instant that does not depend on the estimator's own history.

The two estimators differ in one respect. The full-state estimator also adopts the seed as its current estimate. The reduced estimator uses the seed only as the arrival mean and initial iterate of the rebuilt window: the published estimate stays at the last successful solution and the frame stays unhealthy until a solve succeeds, because a seed is not a solution. The reduced estimator logs the solver status, the number of SQP iterations and the running and cumulative failure counts of every failed solve.

4.4 Adaptive NMPC

4.4.1 The optimal control problem and its input baseline

Over a prediction horizon of N stages the controller solves

$$\begin{aligned}\min_{u_{0:N-1}} \quad & \sum_{k=0}^{N-1} \Big(\big\| e_{\text{track}}(x_k, x_{\text{ref},k}) \big\|_Q^2 + \big\| u_k - u_{\text{hover}}(p) \big\|_R^2 \Big) \\ & \qquad + \big\| e_{\text{track}}(x_N, x_{\text{ref},N}) \big\|_P^2 \\ \text{s.t.} \quad & x_{k+1} = F(x_k, u_k;\, p_{\text{NMPC}}), \\ & \underline{T} \le T_k \le \overline{T}, \quad |\tau_{k,i}| \le \overline{\tau}_i, \end{aligned} \tag{4.21}$$

where F is one explicit fourth-order Runge–Kutta step of the prediction model (4.9) with the parameters (4.8), and the input bounds are those of Section 4.4.4. The problem is re-solved at every step; what is sent to the autopilot is not u_0 itself but the thrust and body-rate setpoints read from the predicted trajectory, as described in Section 3.5.2.

The second term penalises the deviation of the input from a *baseline* u_{hover}, recomputed from the live parameters at every solve rather than fixed when the solver is generated:

$$T_h = m_T \left(g - \hat{d}_z \right), \qquad u_{\text{hover}} = \left[T_h,\, 0,\, 0,\, 0 \right]^\top. \tag{4.22}$$

With the additive residual of (4.9), vertical equilibrium requires $T/m_T - g + \hat{d}_z = 0$, which is (4.22); $\hat{d}_z$ is a specific force, so it is scaled by the mass. Penalising $\|u\|_R^2$ outright would treat the thrust that keeps the vehicle airborne as an expense; the baseline recentres the penalty on the equilibrium input, so that R charges only genuine control effort [1]. What is particular here is that the baseline is a function of the *estimated* mass. A stale baseline — for example one computed from the unloaded mass while a parcel is carried — pulls

the thrust persistently below equilibrium, and the optimum settles at a non-zero steady-state error where the marginal tracking and baseline costs balance. The signature is that increasing R makes the error worse, because R is the strength of the incorrect pull; in development flights with a heavy load and an empty-airframe baseline the tracking error stalled above $0.85\,\mathrm{m}$.

The torque entries of (4.22) are zero because a centred payload requires no trim moment. The small trim left by imperfect alignment is not represented in the controller's model or cost; it is supplied by the integral action of the autopilot's rate loop (Section 5.7.4).

4.4.2 Cost and weights

The controller solves (4.21) with $N = 20$ stages at $\Delta t = 0.05\,\mathrm{s}$, preserving a $1.0\,\mathrm{s}$ preview while running at $20\,\mathrm{Hz}$. The residual vector is

$$\begin{aligned} y_k = \big[\, & \boldsymbol{e}_p;\ \ \boldsymbol{e}_v;\ \ \boldsymbol{e}_{q,\mathrm{vec}};\ \ \boldsymbol{e}_\omega; \\ & u_k - u_{\mathrm{hover}}(p) \,\big] \in \mathbb{R}^{16}, \end{aligned} \tag{4.23}$$

where the attitude entry is the vector part of the relative quaternion $\boldsymbol{q}_{\mathrm{ref}}^{*} \otimes \boldsymbol{q}$, which keeps the residual on the tangent space of the rotation manifold instead of treating four quaternion components as independent Euclidean coordinates.

Weights again follow Bryson's rule, $Q_{ii} = L_i^{-2}$, with tolerances

$$L_p = 0.1\,\mathrm{m}, \quad L_v = 0.3\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}, \quad L_q = 0.05, \quad L_\omega = 0.3\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}, \tag{4.24}$$

and, on the inputs, $L_T = 2\,\mathrm{N}$, $L_{\tau,xy} = 0.5\,\mathrm{N\,m}$, $L_{\tau,z} = 0.2\,\mathrm{N\,m}$; the torque scales are taken to be the constraint bounds themselves, since the input cannot exceed them in any case. The terminal weight rescales the stage blocks by 20 (position), 1 (velocity), 2 (attitude) and 0.2 (rate): the endpoint of the prediction is pulled tightly onto the reference in position and attitude, while relaxing the

terminal rate demonstrably helps the solver.

This non-dimensionalisation is not cosmetic. Before it was applied, position and torque weights differed by a factor of tens at their natural magnitudes, the Gauss–Newton Hessian was correspondingly ill-conditioned across directions, and the stationarity residual was observed to reach 6.26×10^5 — a complete numerical breakdown rather than a slow convergence.

Trajectory-scaled tolerances. Two of the entries in (4.24) are defined by the comment that accompanies them as trajectory-dependent quantities: L_v is a characteristic speed and L_ω a characteristic yaw rate. Written as constants they are correct only for the low-speed reference they were tuned on. An optional rescaling restores the intent,

$$L_v \leftarrow \max\big(L_v,\ r\,w\big), \qquad L_\omega \leftarrow \max\big(L_\omega,\ K_\psi\, w\big), \qquad K_\psi = 3.17, \tag{4.25}$$

taking the maximum so that the weights are only ever relaxed, never tightened. The constant K_ψ is the ratio of peak yaw rate to angular rate on the figure-eight of Section 4.8, obtained numerically; it is worth noting that evaluating the yaw rate at the intuitive location $a = \pi/4$ gives 2.83 and underestimates the peak by 12 %, because the extremum does not occur there. Applying (4.25) at the low-speed condition reproduces L_v exactly but relaxes L_ω by a factor of 3.2, which exposes a pre-existing mismatch rather than introducing one: the original value was documented as matching a *circular* trajectory, whose yaw rate is constant at w, while the vehicle actually flies a figure-eight whose peak is $3.17w$. The rescaling is off by default so that historical batches remain reproducible.

4.4.3 Residual specific force

The translational model at the published mass is still wrong whenever the mass estimate is: under sustained manoeuvre the loaded estimate is biased low (Section 5.5.1), and the thrust feed-forward implied by (4.9) then falls short by the same proportion, leaving a steady-state height error that only the position error can push against. The controller therefore carries an additive specific force $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ [$\mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}$], estimated at the odometry rate by the state predictor and adaptation law of $\mathscr{L}_1$-adaptive control [20]:

$$\dot{\hat{\boldsymbol{v}}} = \boldsymbol{a}_{\mathrm{nom}} + \hat{\boldsymbol{d}}_{\mathrm{raw}} - a(\hat{\boldsymbol{v}} - \boldsymbol{v}), \qquad \dot{\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}}_{\mathrm{raw}} = -\Gamma(\hat{\boldsymbol{v}} - \boldsymbol{v}), \qquad \hat{\boldsymbol{d}} = \frac{\omega_c}{s + \omega_c}\,\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}_{\mathrm{raw}}, \quad (4.26)$$

with $a = 10\,\mathrm{s^{-1}}$, $\Gamma = (a/2)^2$ (critically damped) and low-pass cut-off $\omega_c = 0.5\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$. The nominal acceleration $\boldsymbol{a}_{\mathrm{nom}}$ is (3.7) evaluated with the *measured* collective thrust of (3.21) and the *published* mass $\hat{m}$, so $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ absorbs only the part of the measured acceleration that the model at $\hat{m}$ fails to explain. It enters (4.9) additively and the baseline (4.22) through its vertical component.

Four properties keep it out of the payload accounting. It is a specific force, not a mass, so it needs no assumption about what the mass is. It is used by the controller only: it does not reach the estimator, the evidence score (4.37) or any lifecycle decision. It is reset to zero when the controller accepts a release with a release command outstanding (Section 4.7.4), since a residual learned against the loaded vehicle becomes a phantom force once the payload has gone; an acceptance with *no* command outstanding does not reset it, and the residual is then unlearned by (4.26) itself, at the 2 s time constant of the low-pass filter. And it is held at zero while the measured thrust is below $0.4 m_B g$, because on the ground the support force would otherwise be learned as an upward disturbance. Its cost is equally plain: because it compensates the translational consequence of a mass bias, tracking results obtained with it do not measure

the accuracy of $\hat{m}$, and the mass error is reported directly wherever it matters (Chapter 5). For the same reason the $\mathscr{L}_1$ baseline, which uses the same law with a fixed nominal mass and no payload model, differs from the deployed controller in the payload model, not in the presence of disturbance estimation. Section 5.7.1 isolates its contribution.

4.4.4 Input constraints and the actuator envelope

The rotor model of Section 3.5 also defines what the vehicle can actually produce, and therefore the input constraint set of (4.21). The autopilot accepts a normalised throttle η, which the electronic speed controllers map affinely to rotor speed before the quadratic thrust law applies:

$$\omega(\eta) = \omega_{\min} + \Delta\omega\,\eta, \qquad T(\eta) = K\,\omega(\eta)^2, \qquad K = 4k_f, \tag{4.27}$$

with $\omega_{\min} = 150\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$ and $\Delta\omega = 850\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$. Inverting (4.27) gives the command actually published,

$$\eta(T) = \frac{\sqrt{T/K} - \omega_{\min}}{\Delta\omega}, \tag{4.28}$$

which is exact at every mass, unlike a linear hover-referenced heuristic. Because η is clipped to $[0.05, 0.95]$ — the upper limit reserving 5 % of the command range so that the rate loop retains differential authority when all four rotors are near saturation — the attainable collective thrust is

$$T \in \big[\,T(0.05),\, T(0.95)\,\big] = [\,1.27\,\mathrm{N},\, 31.35\,\mathrm{N}\,], \tag{4.29}$$

and this is the thrust box of (4.21). A box derived from the vehicle's weight rather than its actuators, as used in an earlier implementation ($[0.5\,\mathrm{N}, 2m_Bg = 40.5\,\mathrm{N}]$), over-states the available thrust by 29 %; the surplus is removed silently by the clip in (4.28), so a planned recovery acceleration is never delivered and

the next solve asks for still more.

The torque bounds follow from the allocation. The ROS layer never evaluates the inverse of (3.21) — the autopilot's mixer does — but its form sizes the bounds. The rows of M are mutually orthogonal, so $M^{-1} = M^{\top}\operatorname{diag}\left(\frac{1}{4}, \frac{1}{4l^2}, \frac{1}{4l^2}, \frac{1}{4k_m^2}\right)$ and

$$F_i = \frac{T}{4} + \frac{y_i}{4l^2}\,\tau_x - \frac{x_i}{4l^2}\,\tau_y - \frac{d_i}{4k_m}\,\tau_z. \tag{4.30}$$

A unit roll or pitch moment costs $1/(4l) = 1.44\,\mathrm{m}^{-1}$ of differential rotor thrust, whereas a unit yaw moment costs $1/(4k_m) = 15.6\,\mathrm{m}^{-1}$, a factor of 10.9. At a hover thrust of 20 N each rotor carries 5 N and has 2.84 N of headroom to the 7.84 N per-rotor ceiling implied by (4.29); that headroom buys 1.98 N m of roll authority but only 0.18 N m of yaw. Against the bounds $\overline{\tau}_{x,y} = 0.5\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ and $\overline{\tau}_z = 0.2\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ used in (4.21), the roll and pitch bounds are conservative by a factor of four while the yaw bound is marginally *optimistic*, which is consistent with the executed yaw torque falling well short of the intended one (Section 5.1).

4.4.5 Solver

Both optimal control problems are transcribed by direct multiple shooting with explicit fourth-order Runge–Kutta integration, a Gauss–Newton Hessian approximation, and partial-condensing HPIPM [10] as the quadratic subproblem solver, generated and solved with acados [8]. Both use *full* sequential quadratic programming with merit-function backtracking rather than the real-time-iteration scheme [6]: RTI was observed to diverge silently in this configuration, and a controller that reports success while producing a diverging input is worse than one that takes an extra millisecond. Generated C code is cached and reused until the model or problem dimensions change.

4.5 The Continuous Payload Interface

4.5.1 One atomic frame

After each solve the estimator publishes

$$\mathscr{P} = \Big\{ m_T,\ \Delta J_{xx}, \Delta J_{yy}, \Delta J_{zz},\ J_{xx}, J_{yy}, J_{zz},\ \gamma,\ h,\ a \Big\}, \tag{4.31}$$

in which the inertia entries are computed from m_T by (3.18), with $\Delta J_{zz} = 0$ for a centred point mass; $\gamma \in [0,1]$ is the no-payload evidence score of Section 4.7.3, h is a health bit and a is the age of the most recent successful solution. The message layout additionally retains four horizontal-offset fields for compatibility with the generated solver; they are not consumed by the evidence score, by the lifecycle logic, or by the controller, which holds $\boldsymbol{c}_{xy} = \mathbf{0}$.

Health is a conjunction: the latest solve must have succeeded, the odometry, rotor-speed and known-input streams must all be fresher than 0.30 s, and — for the reduced estimator — the latest estimate must pass the mass-health check (4.16). The consumer applies one further test of its own, on the receive age of the frame itself (0.35 s), because a frame can be healthy at the moment it is produced and stale by the time it is used.

The asymmetry in how an unhealthy frame is treated is deliberate and is the safety property of the interface: *an unhealthy or stale frame freezes the last accepted model and resets the evidence-score persistence timer*. A degraded estimate can therefore delay a release confirmation, but it can never cause one.

4.5.2 Filtering and slew limiting

A valid frame is not consumed directly. Each channel passes a first-order low-pass filter and a separate rate limiter before it reaches the solver:

$$\alpha = 1 - e^{-\Delta t/\tau}, \qquad \hat{\theta} \leftarrow \hat{\theta} + \alpha\big(\theta^{\mathrm{tgt}} - \hat{\theta}\big), \qquad \hat{\theta} \leftarrow \hat{\theta} + \mathrm{clip}\big(\cdot,\ \pm\dot{\theta}_{\max}\Delta t\big), \tag{4.32}$$

with $\tau = 0.20\,\mathrm{s}$ on the controller side ($0.25\,\mathrm{s}$ on the estimator's own output stage) and rate limits $0.60\,\mathrm{kg\,s^{-1}}$ for the mass and $0.080\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2\,s^{-1}}$ for the inertia increment.

The reason for a limiter in addition to a filter is that the two protect against different things. The filter attenuates noise; the limiter bounds how fast the *model* underneath a receding-horizon optimisation may change. A parameter step between consecutive solves invalidates the warm start, and an optimiser that must re-converge from scratch at 20 Hz is an optimiser that occasionally does not converge in time. The limiter converts any step — including a genuine one at grasp — into a ramp the solver can track.

4.6 Inner-Loop Scheduling

Model consistency in the outer loop cannot restore inner-loop bandwidth. The autopilot's rate controller is tuned for the bare airframe; a payload that multiplies the roll and pitch inertia by κ of (3.15) lowers its effective bandwidth by the same factor, and for heavy loads the resulting attitude oscillation grows until the torque saturates. At the nominal arm κ is 2.34 for the heavier payload, by (3.16); because it grows with r_z^2, the arm and the payload mass together define a feasibility boundary, characterised in Section 5.8.3. An earlier implementation applied κ by rewriting the autopilot's rate-loop gains at attachment. The deployed implementation does not touch those parameters; it scales the body-rate

command instead, which keeps the adaptation inside the ROS layer and makes it continuous and reversible.

4.6.1 From inertia ratio to a command scale

The deployed response scales the body-rate *command* around the current measured rate,

$$\boldsymbol{\omega}'_{\text{cmd}} = \boldsymbol{\omega} + \varsigma\left(\boldsymbol{\omega}_{\text{cmd}} - \boldsymbol{\omega}\right), \qquad \varsigma \geq 1, \tag{4.33}$$

applied to the roll and pitch channels only, since ΔJ enters only J_{xx} and J_{yy}. Equation (4.33) exaggerates the rate *error* the inner loop sees, which is equivalent to raising its proportional gain, without modifying any autopilot parameter. Because it is a common scale on the roll/pitch pair it preserves the direction of the rate-error vector.

The requested scale is the inertia ratio (3.15), clipped at a cap of 5.0, evaluated from the live ΔJ of the payload frame. Three filters stand between the request and its application, each addressing a distinct failure:

- a **dead band** of 0.08 on the target, so that estimator noise cannot move it, with explicit snapping to 1.0 and to the cap so that hysteresis cannot strand the empty-airframe steady state permanently above unity;
- a **first-order filter** with $\tau = 0.5\,\text{s}$, chosen far slower than the inner loop (hundreds of hertz) and still fast enough to follow the second-scale progressive load transfer during a grasp;
- **asymmetric rate limits**, $4.0\,\text{s}^{-1}$ rising against $1.5\,\text{s}^{-1}$ recovering, encoding the asymmetry of the consequences: being late to add authority risks saturation, being late to remove it does not.

Because ΔJ is a function of $\hat{m}$, the scale is too: the inner loop receives ex-

actly the authority the mass estimate implies, and a mass estimate that collapses toward the bare airframe during manoeuvre withdraws that authority at the moment it is needed (Section 4.7.6).

4.6.2 Headroom limiting

Scaling a command that is already close to the rate limit accomplishes nothing except saturation, at which point the scaling has silently stopped acting. The implementation therefore solves for the largest scale that keeps the scaled command inside a guard band $\pm L$, with L equal to 95 % of the hard rate limit $\overline{\omega} = 2.0\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$.

For one channel, write the rate error $e = \omega_{\mathrm{cmd}} - \omega$. Requiring $|\omega + \varsigma e| \le L$ gives

$$\varsigma \;\le\; \begin{cases} \dfrac{L-\omega}{e}, & e > 0, \\[2ex] \dfrac{-L-\omega}{e}, & e < 0, \end{cases} \tag{4.34}$$

and the applied scale is the smallest such bound over the roll and pitch channels, floored at unity:

$$\varsigma_{\mathrm{eff}} = \max\Big(1,\; \min_{i\in\{x,y\}} \varsigma_i^{\max}\Big). \tag{4.35}$$

The floor at unity guarantees that the scheduler can never make the raw controller command *less* authoritative than it would have been without scheduling — the scheduler is allowed to help and not allowed to hurt. When (4.35) binds, it is logged, so that saturation avoidance is an observable event rather than a silent degradation.

4.6.3 Attach-time inertia bootstrap

One interval resists estimate-driven adaptation: the second or so between a load beginning to take weight and the estimator accumulating enough evidence to say so. During that interval the vehicle is physically loaded and the model is not, and it is the interval in which the predecessor implementation lost eleven of sixteen flights at the heaviest condition.

The deployed bootstrap addresses it with the narrowest intervention that works. When the grasp is enabled, the *inertia* parameter alone is floored at the value implied by the platform's 0.30 kg payload envelope; the mass is untouched, and no payload is fabricated in it. At the nominal arm the floor is $\Delta J = 0.0191\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$, an inner-loop ratio of 2.34; the controller uses the larger of the floor and the estimate-derived increment, so a heavier estimate still raises the inertia. Two hand-over rules are implemented. In the original rule the overlay is faded out over 0.5 s once the estimator independently reports persistent loaded evidence, namely $\Delta J \geq 0.010\,\mathrm{kg\,m^2}$ together with an evidence score well below the confirmation threshold, sustained for 0.5 s. In the rule used for evaluation (*hold until command*), loaded evidence does not end the floor; it is held until the controller issues the release command and is then faded over the same 0.5 s to the estimate-derived increment. If the estimate becomes stale or unhealthy while the handover is in progress, the fade freezes at the last safe inertia rather than continuing toward zero.

The hold rule is the one place where the release command touches the controller's payload model, and it should be stated exactly. The command ends an *overlay*; it does not assert that the payload has gone. After the fade the inertia is whatever the estimate implies, which for a payload still attached is the loaded value, and the release is still accepted only by (4.38). The command is waited for because, after a real release, the estimator can no longer produce the loaded evidence that would end the floor, and the floor would otherwise re-

main on an empty airframe indefinitely. By the same token, a load lost without any command leaves the floor on the empty airframe; that case is outside the evaluation (Section 5.3.2).

Three properties keep this consistent with the rest of the design. It is *inertia-only*, so it cannot influence the mass channel on which every release decision depends. It can only *raise* the inertia above what the estimate implies, never lower it, so the release path remains estimate-only. And its magnitude is the airframe's payload envelope, which Section 3.4.3 has already disclosed as a platform specification rather than task information.

The bootstrap also has a known failure of its own. It is armed when the grasp is enabled, whether or not the gripper actually catches the parcel, and it is handed over only on loaded evidence. A missed grasp therefore leaves an empty airframe flying with the envelope inertia floor — a 2.34-fold inner-loop scale at the nominal arm — because the evidence that would release the floor never arrives; under the hold rule it is in any case kept until the release command. A variant that arms the floor only once the vehicle has detectably lifted the load is implemented and off by default.

4.7 The Grasp–Release Lifecycle

4.7.1 What release acceptance does, and why it is gated on evidence

Four things happen around a release, and the design keeps them apart.

1. *The dynamic parameters* — the mass, the inertia increment and the inner-loop scale — follow the estimate frame by frame through the continuous interface of Section 4.5, in every lifecycle state. When the payload leaves,

they return to the bare-airframe values because the estimate does, not because any decision switches them.

2. *The release lifecycle state* — carry, release pending, release accepted, or UNRESOLVED — is owned by the controller.

3. *The residual specific force* of Section 4.4.3 is reset when a release is accepted with a release command outstanding.

4. *Task completion* — the delivery is declared done — coincides with acceptance.

Release acceptance is the transition of item 2; it triggers items 3 and 4 and never sets the mass or the inertia. Acceptance is the only lifecycle decision of the controller, and the rest of this section concerns when it may be taken.

The controller issues the gripper-release command itself, and it would be simple to accept the release at that instant. The command and the physical detachment can, however, differ: a gripper can be slow to open, can jam, or can release only part of a load. A controller that accepts at the command declares the delivery complete and discards the residual it learned against the loaded vehicle while the load may still be on the hook. Gating acceptance on estimator evidence — *estimator-confirmed detachment* — separates "the command was issued" from "the payload has left", at the cost of a confirmation delay while the estimator accumulates evidence.

Two arming policies are implemented on the estimator's evidence. The *always-on* policy evaluates the rule throughout carry; the *command-armed* policy starts its persistence count only after the release command. Chapter 5 shows why, on the mass evidence, the latter is preferred, and that neither detects a load lost without a command. A third rule, described in Section 4.7.5, replaces the mass evidence with an independent force-balance test and enables it either by the command or by a watchdog armed on airborne load; it is the only rule in

this dissertation that addresses uncommanded loss.

4.7.2 Two state machines

The lifecycle is split between the two nodes, as shown in Figure 4.2. The estimator owns payload *presence*. The controller owns the *release lifecycle* and accepts a release only on *confirmation*. The separation exists so that no single estimator-side transition can, by itself, declare a delivery complete.

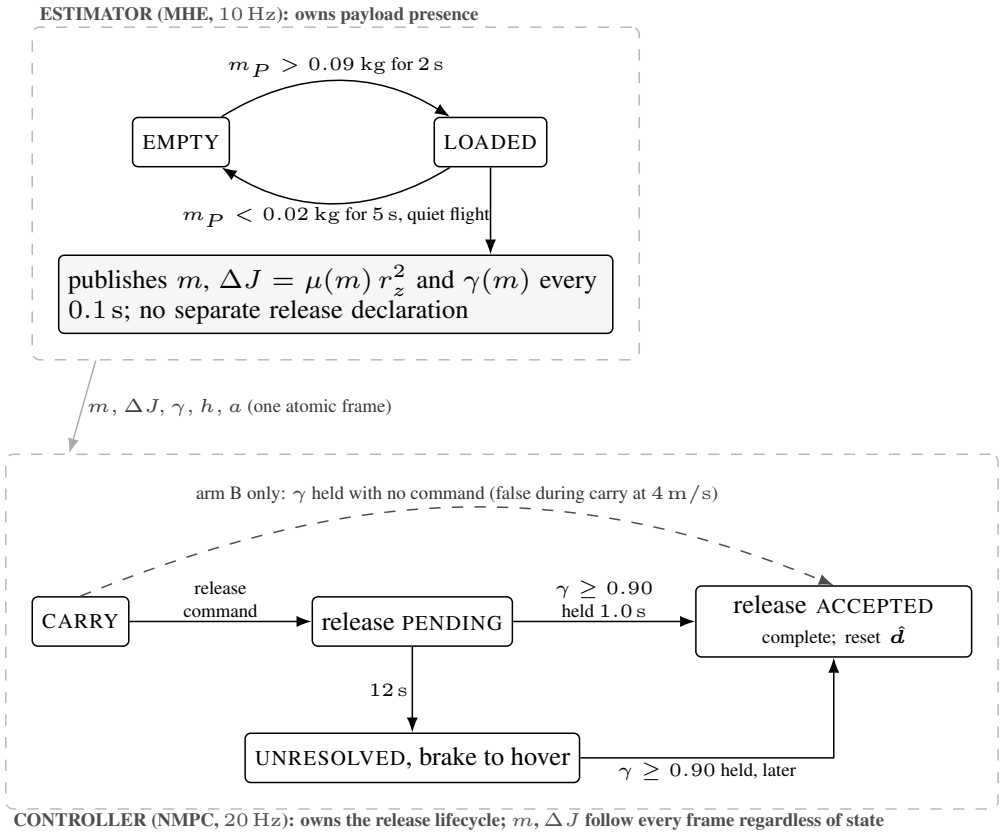


Figure 4.2: The payload lifecycle as two state machines. The estimator owns payload presence, driven by sustained payload-mass evidence with hysteresis. The controller owns the release lifecycle: the release command moves it from carry to release pending and starts the 12 s timeout, and a release is accepted on confirmation, $\gamma \geq 0.90$ held for 1.0 s. UNRESOLVED is a hold, not an acceptance: the vehicle brakes to hover and keeps waiting for evidence. The dashed path exists only under the always-on policy. In every state the mass and inertia increment follow the estimate frame by frame; no transition sets them.

Presence is a hysteretic EMPTY↔LOADED machine. It enters LOADED when the

estimated payload mass exceeds 0.09 kg for 2 s, with a directional thrust residual as a fast path; it returns to EMPTY when the payload mass stays below 0.02 kg for 5 s *while the vehicle is quiet* ($\|\boldsymbol{\omega}\| \leq 0.15\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$, $\|\boldsymbol{v}_{xy}\| \leq 0.20\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$). The quiet-flight condition is there because the mass is least reliable in manoeuvre (Section 4.7.6). The thresholds differ by a factor of four-and-a-half on purpose: the estimate is naturally low while it converges after a grasp, and a single threshold would toggle at the start of every lift. A separate latch records that the present flight reliably entered LOADED at some point.

4.7.3 No-payload evidence score

Apart from whether a release command has been issued, every lifecycle decision of the controller is a function of the published frame (4.31) alone. Let $\sigma(v;a,b)$ be the smooth indicator that is 1 for $|v| \leq a$, 0 for $|v| \geq b$, and in between

$$\sigma(v;a,b) = 1 - \big(3\chi^2 - 2\chi^3\big), \qquad \chi = \frac{|v| - a}{b - a}, \tag{4.36}$$

which is the standard cubic smooth-step: continuous with continuous first derivative at both ends. Let $\bar{m}_{P,k}$ be the estimator's filtered payload mass and let $\gamma_k^\star$ be its instantaneous empty-payload score. The published score is filtered once more at the output stage:

$$\begin{aligned} \gamma_k^\star &= \sigma\big(\bar{m}_{P,k};\, 0.015,\, 0.060\big), \\ \gamma_k &= \gamma_{k-1} + \alpha_\gamma\big(\gamma_k^\star - \gamma_{k-1}\big), \qquad \alpha_\gamma = 1 - e^{-\Delta t / 0.25\,\mathrm{s}}. \end{aligned} \tag{4.37}$$

Thus γ is a deterministic evidence score, not a posterior probability or a statistical confidence level. The score is 1 at or below 0.015 kg, 0 at or above 0.060 kg, and changes smoothly between them. The instantaneous score exceeds 0.90 below approximately 0.024 kg; the additional output filter determines when the published score crosses that threshold. The inertia increment is deliberately absent: in the mass-only model it is a deterministic function of the same mass

estimate and therefore cannot provide independent release evidence.

4.7.4 Confirmation, UNRESOLVED, and braking to hover

The controller accepts a release through exactly one route:

$$\gamma \geq 0.90 \quad \text{held for} \quad 1.0\,\text{s} \quad \text{on healthy, fresh frames.} \tag{4.38}$$

The persistence must be contiguous in valid estimator time: a stale or failed frame breaks the count rather than pausing it. There is no separate estimator declaration in the evaluated configuration, and the release command does not enter the evidence score (4.37); under the command-armed policy it only decides when the count of (4.38) may start.

If no confirmation arrives within 12 s of the release command, the controller enters UNRESOLVED. This state is what makes confirmation on the estimate deployable, and its semantics deserve emphasis: **a timeout is not a release**. Nothing is accepted, the residual is not reset, and the model continues to follow the estimate. What changes is the vehicle's exposure: it stops flying an aggressive trajectory it may no longer have the authority to fly, and it gives the estimator a quiet operating point in which the mass is best observed.

The braking manoeuvre is a finite-time reference rather than an instantaneous switch to hover, because at $4\,\text{m}\,\text{s}^{-1}$ the latter would command a step of several metres per second. Let $\boldsymbol{p}_0, \boldsymbol{v}_0$ be the state at the declaration and $T_b = 3\,\text{s}$. The stopping point is chosen as the displacement of a constant deceleration from $\boldsymbol{v}_0$ to rest,

$$\boldsymbol{p}_1 = \boldsymbol{p}_0 + \tfrac{1}{2} T_b \, \boldsymbol{v}_0, \tag{4.39}$$

and the reference between the two is the unique quintic satisfying $\boldsymbol{p}(0) = \boldsymbol{p}_0$,

$\dot{\boldsymbol{p}}(0)=\boldsymbol{v}_0,\ \ddot{\boldsymbol{p}}(0)=\mathbf{0},\ \boldsymbol{p}(T_b)=\boldsymbol{p}_1,\ \dot{\boldsymbol{p}}(T_b)=\mathbf{0},\ \ddot{\boldsymbol{p}}(T_b)=\mathbf{0}$:

$$\boldsymbol{p}(t)=\boldsymbol{p}_0+\boldsymbol{v}_0 t+a_3t^3+a_4t^4+a_5t^5, \qquad \begin{aligned} a_3&=\big(10\,\Delta\boldsymbol{p}-6T_b\boldsymbol{v}_0\big)/T_b^3,\\ a_4&=\big(-15\,\Delta\boldsymbol{p}+8T_b\boldsymbol{v}_0\big)/T_b^4,\\ a_5&=\big(6\,\Delta\boldsymbol{p}-3T_b\boldsymbol{v}_0\big)/T_b^5, \end{aligned} \tag{4.40}$$

with $\Delta\boldsymbol{p}=\boldsymbol{p}_1-\boldsymbol{p}_0$. Zero acceleration at both ends means the manoeuvre begins and ends without a jump in commanded thrust, which is what keeps the transition from itself perturbing the estimator whose evidence is being awaited. Attitude is blended over the same interval by the smooth-step of (4.36).

4.7.5 Force-balance release evidence and the uncommanded-loss watchdog

The failure of the always-on rule (Section 4.7.6) lies in its evidence, not its arming: the mass estimate of the full-state estimator, with which the rule was developed, is the one quantity that degrades in manoeuvre (Section 5.8.1). The reduced estimator shrinks that bias (Section 5.7.3) but does not turn the mass estimate into an independent second witness. A second test of the same question needs evidence that does not pass through the attitude, the velocity history or the rotational model. The vertical force balance in the body frame provides it. The specific force measured by the inertial unit along the thrust axis, f_z, contains no gravity term, and with the rotor-drag term neglected it satisfies $f_z \approx T/m$. A mass can therefore be formed from two measured signals alone,

$$m_{\mathrm{acc},k}=\frac{\bar{T}_k}{\max\big(\bar{f}_{z,k},\,1\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}\big)}, \qquad T_k=\textstyle\sum_i k_f\,\omega_{i,k}^2, \tag{4.41}$$

where $\bar{(\cdot)}$ denotes a first-order low-pass with a time constant of 0.5 s, applied to the thrust reconstructed from rotor speeds and to f_z alike. The lower limit on $\bar{f}_z$ guards against division in free fall. No estimator state enters (4.41); in particular, it is unaffected by any manoeuvre-induced bias of $\hat{m}$, and it remains

available when the estimator's frames are unhealthy. Its weakness is the one the mass channel also has: a relative error in k_f scales m_{acc} one-for-one.

The evidence score has the form of (4.37) with the same pair of thresholds,

$$\gamma^{\star}_{\mathrm{acc},k} = \sigma\big((m_{\mathrm{acc},k} - m_B)^{+}; 0.015, 0.060\big), \tag{4.42}$$

filtered at the output with a 0.25 s time constant. The score starts at zero, because no evidence is not evidence of an empty vehicle, and it is held rather than advanced while either signal is stale (older than 0.2 s); a stale frame also breaks the persistence count of (4.38), which is otherwise applied to γ_{acc} unchanged: $\gamma_{\mathrm{acc}} \geq 0.90$ held for 1.0 s. Under this rule the controller's lifecycle reads the inertial unit and the rotor speeds directly; the statement of Section 4.7.3 that every lifecycle decision is a function of the published frame does not hold for it, by design.

What may consume the score is decided by *dual enabling*. The score is computed throughout the flight, but a confirmation counts only when one of two conditions holds:

1. a release command is pending — the command opens confirmation at once, as in the command-armed policy; or
2. the *uncommanded-loss watchdog* is armed. It arms after the lift has started, once fresh evidence of load, $\gamma_{\mathrm{acc}} < 0.90 - 0.15 = 0.75$, has persisted for 2.0 s. Once armed it is not disarmed by a rising score — that rise is the event it exists to detect — and it is cleared only at the next pickup.

During grasp and ground support neither condition holds, so a parcel that is attached but still resting on the ground, for which the force balance correctly reads an empty vehicle, cannot produce an acceptance.

An acceptance with a command pending is a normal release, with the actions of Section 4.7.1. An acceptance with no command pending and the watchdog armed is declared an *uncommanded loss*. In addition to resetting the residual specific force, the controller then zeroes the payload geometry, ends the attach-time inertia floor and resets the inner-loop scale to the bare-airframe value, and suppresses any later planned release, since there is nothing left to release. It issues no gripper command, because the gripper's state is unknown and it may be the gripper that failed.

4.7.6 What a mass-only lifecycle cannot do

Because (4.37) is a test on the mass alone, the lifecycle inherits every failure of that estimate. In sustained manoeuvre a low bias can carry $\hat{m}_P$ below the 0.024 kg confirmation threshold while the payload is attached; no rule admitting only that estimate can distinguish the collapse from a real release. The collapse was observed with the full-state estimator; the reduced estimator's loaded bias in manoeuvre is smaller (Section 5.7.3), but the argument does not depend on its size.

The evaluated configuration holds the inertia floor until the release command, protecting inner-loop authority but not the lifecycle. Command-arming separately prevents carry-phase acceptance by not evaluating the release rule before a command. The cohort supports that arming policy (Section 5.5.4), but neither mitigation corrects the mass estimate itself. The force-balance rule of Section 4.7.5 leaves the estimate as it is and stops asking it the release question; its own limitation is calibration rather than manoeuvre (Section 5.6.4).

4.7.7 Threshold provenance

Table 4.3 lists every lifecycle threshold and where its value came from. None was selected against the evaluation data; all are engineering choices whose closed-loop sensitivity has not been swept, and they are reported as such.

Table 4.3: Lifecycle thresholds and their provenance.

Threshold	Value	Provenance
presence entry	$m_P > 0.09\,\mathrm{kg}$, 2 s	below the smallest payload tested; persistence suppresses the post-grasp convergence transient
presence exit	$m_P < 0.02\,\mathrm{kg}$, 5 s, quiet flight	slow backstop; hysteresis against the entry threshold
no-payload evidence score	(4.37); $\gamma \geq 0.90$ held 1.0 s	engineering choice
force-balance score	(4.41)–(4.42); low-pass 0.5 s/0.25 s; fresh within 0.2 s	thresholds shared with (4.37); time constants an engineering choice, checked by offline replay of the earlier cohort and frozen before the campaign of Section 5.6
loss-watchdog arming	$\gamma_{\mathrm{acc}} < 0.75$ for 2.0 s, after lift start	engineering choice; frozen before that campaign
UNRESOLVED timeout / brake	12 s / 3 s	engineering choice

4.8 Reference Trajectory

The evaluation trajectory is a three-dimensional Gerono lemniscate,

$$x_r = r\sin a, \qquad y_r = r\sin a\cos a = \tfrac{r}{2}\sin 2a, \qquad z_r = z_h + d_z\sin a, \qquad a = w t_c, \tag{4.43}$$

with yaw commanded along the velocity vector. The crossing is not a cusp: $\boldsymbol{v} = rw(\cos a, \cos 2a)$ has magnitude $\sqrt{2}rw$ there while the planar acceleration vanishes. The curve therefore excites coupled translation and yaw without a velocity reversal, and the vertical term keeps the workspace compact.

After the initial hover, position amplitude and heading are introduced with the quintic smooth step $\alpha(s) = 10s^3 - 15s^4 + 6s^5$. The ramp duration satisfies $t_{\text{ramp}} \geq 2.65/w$, limiting the extra velocity due to amplitude growth, and heading is blended from the hover direction to the trajectory tangent. This yaw blend was retained because, without it, six development flights at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ spent 19–25 % of their first 5 s at the yaw-moment constraint.

4.9 Online Execution Sequence

At every control instant the implementation performs the following sequence.

1. Receive and frame-convert the latest odometry.
2. Reconstruct the physical wrench from rotor speeds, (3.21), averaging the 250 Hz samples over the estimation interval.
3. Append the measurement and the reconstructed input to the 10 Hz window; re-seed by (4.20) if the window must be rebuilt.
4. Solve (4.10) for m_T (with the full-state estimator, also the vehicle trajectory); with the reduced estimator, apply the mass-health check (4.16).
5. Update the presence machine and the no-payload evidence score (4.37).
6. Assemble and publish the atomic frame (4.31) with its health bit and solution age.
7. In the controller: validate freshness, low-pass filter and slew-limit the frame (4.32), and write m_T and ΔJ into the model parameters and the hover baseline (4.22).
8. Evaluate confirmation (4.38) and the UNRESOLVED timeout; switch the reference to the braking quintic (4.40) if the timeout expires.

9. Shift the previous solution forward as a warm start and solve (4.21). Between solves, publish at 50 Hz the thrust and the body rate interpolated along the predicted trajectory (Section 3.5.2); invert thrust to throttle by (4.28) and apply the body-rate scaling (4.33)–(4.35).

10. Log estimates, residuals, constraint activity, solver statistics and every lifecycle transition.

Estimator and controller failures are handled separately and asymmetrically. An invalid estimator solve, or an estimate outside the health band, retains the last accepted parameter set and marks the frame unhealthy, which — by Section 4.5.1 — freezes the controller's model and resets its confirmation timer. An invalid controller solve falls back to the configured safe action rather than publishing an unconstrained command.

4.10 Chapter Summary

This chapter addressed the third and fourth research objectives: turning the single-parameter model of Chapter 3 into an estimator and a controller that run together, and defining the release lifecycle. The three models involved are collected in one section: the controller predicts with the full vehicle model and the estimate-derived inertia, while the deployed estimator keeps only the translational dynamics, with the measured attitude as a known input, so that no rotational model error can reach the mass. The estimator is a constrained moving-horizon problem whose only payload decision variable is the composite mass, initialised from a window force balance, driven by the measured thrust, and checked against a physical health band before its estimate is released. One atomic, health-gated frame carries the mass and the inertia increment derived from it to the controller, which updates its prediction model, its input baseline and its inner-loop command scaling continuously from that frame. Release ac-

ceptance is kept separate from that adaptation: it changes the lifecycle state, resets the residual force and declares completion, and it is gated on estimator evidence. Two properties of the design are known before any experiment: the lifecycle rests on the mass channel alone, and the attach-time inertia floor protects the inner loop at the price of not being released by evidence. Chapter 5 measures how the complete system behaves, including whether the always-on or the command-armed confirmation policy should be used.

Chapter 5

Implementation and Experimental Evaluation

This chapter addresses the fifth research objective: evaluating the complete interface in software-in-the-loop simulation and characterising where it fails. The evidence comes from five sources of different standing, which are kept apart throughout (Section 5.4.1). The primary results are those of a frozen, block-randomised cohort of 120 flights in the evaluated configuration of Section 5.2; two smaller frozen batches isolate the residual specific force and the estimator's inertia treatment; a second frozen campaign of 312 flights tests an independent force-balance release rule, uncommanded loss, a jammed gripper, thrust-map error and fixed and $\mathscr{L}_1$ baselines (Section 5.6); and development flights in earlier configurations are used only to show mechanisms. The frozen campaign of an earlier revision used a different estimator and eccentric grasps; none of its numbers is reused here.

5.1 Platform and Implementation

The implementation is organised as ROS 2 packages around PX4 software-in-the-loop [35] and Gazebo [36]. The controller node owns the reference generator, the predictive optimal control problem, the mission sequence and the release-confirmation logic; the estimator node owns the sliding measurement

window, the physical-input reconstruction, the mass optimisation, the presence machine and the published payload frame. The two communicate through the single atomic frame of Section 4.5.

Table 5.1: Main implementation components of the deployed pipeline.

Component	Role	Principal signals
Gazebo (Harmonic)	Rigid-body physics; detachable-joint gripper	pose, rotor speed, attach/detach record (logging only)
PX4 SITL	State estimation, rate loop, control allocation	odometry, actuator commands
`mhe_node`	moving-horizon mass estimation (full-state in the campaigns, reduced deployed); presence machine	odometry, rotor speed → payload frame (4.31)
`acados_nmpc_node`	Predictive control, mission sequence, confirmation	payload frame, state → thrust and body-rate setpoint
`payload_estimate`	Frame schema, evidence score (4.37)	shared by the online nodes and the offline replay
`proximity_gripper_node`	Grasp contact and release actuation	proximity, grasp enable, release command
`lifecycle_trace`	Machine-readable event trace for scoring	every state transition, with timestamps
`l1_adaptive`	Residual specific-force estimator (Section 4.4.3); also the comparison adaptive controller	odometry, rotor speed → $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$
`px4_pid_benchmark`	Bare-autopilot cascade baseline	position setpoints only

Every reported payload change is produced by the detachable-joint gripper, which adds or removes a genuine second rigid body and therefore changes mass and inertia together. A retired run-time inertia plugin did not alter the physics engine and contributes no result to this dissertation.

Across twenty recorded batches, reconstructed roll and pitch torques track the intended values (median correlations 0.93 and 0.70; slopes 1.08 and 1.10), whereas executed yaw torque is only 0.32 of the intended value. This three-fold yaw discrepancy is a concrete reason to drive the estimator with the measured wrench (3.21), not the command.

5.1.1 Platform parameters and task

The reusable-vehicle constants are

$$m_B = 2.0643\,\mathrm{kg}, \qquad J_B = \mathrm{diag}(0.0142, 0.0142, 0.0210)\ \ \mathrm{kg\,m^2}, \qquad k_d = 0.05, \tag{5.1}$$

with rotor arm $0.174\,\mathrm{m}$, $k_f = 8.55 \times 10^{-6}\,\mathrm{N\,s^2}$ and $k_m = 0.016\,\mathrm{m}$. The collective-thrust box is the actuator envelope (4.29), $[1.27\,\mathrm{N}, 31.35\,\mathrm{N}]$, and the torque bounds are $0.5\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ in roll and pitch and $0.2\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ in yaw. None of these grows with the estimate.

The value m_B appears in the model, in the derived quantity $m_P = (m_T - m_B)^+$ and in offline scoring. The payload is a $0.15\,\mathrm{m}$ cube of $0.15\,\mathrm{kg}$ or $0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$, placed directly below the grasp point so that the grasp is centred. The gripper attaches when the parcel is within $0.03\,\mathrm{m}$ horizontally of the attachment point and its vertical distance lies in $[0.15\,\mathrm{m}, 0.45\,\mathrm{m}]$. The vehicle descends to $0.35\,\mathrm{m}$ above ground to grasp, which realises a vertical arm of about $0.27\,\mathrm{m}$; both optimisers use the nominal prior $r_z = -0.27\,\mathrm{m}$, and the realised arm varies between about $0.25\,\mathrm{m}$ and $0.30\,\mathrm{m}$ from flight to flight (Section 3.4.3). None of the payload values is supplied to the estimator or the controller.

The task sequence is: approach under position control; hand-off to the predictive controller and warm-up hover; alignment over the parcel; controlled descent; grasp enable; lift from $0.35\,\mathrm{m}$ to $6.0\,\mathrm{m}$ in $8.4\,\mathrm{s}$; figure-eight carry (4.43) with $r = 10\,\mathrm{m}$, $z_h = 6.0\,\mathrm{m}$ and $d_z = 0.8\,\mathrm{m}$; release; recovery. The release command is issued after $45\,\mathrm{s}$ of loaded figure-eight, at the next tip of the figure-eight ($a = 3\pi/2$), so that every release occurs at the same geometric phase. The two speeds are set by the phase rate: $w = 0.283\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$ for a peak of about $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and $w = 0.1415\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$ with a $9.36\,\mathrm{s}$ speed ramp for about $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. The scope of the controller is stated explicitly — it governs the grasp hover and the post-event adaptation phase, and the approach controller is not part of any claim. Batches run headless.

5.1.2 Real-time performance

On one desktop core shared with the simulator and the autopilot, the 13-state controller ($N = 20$, 20 Hz) solves in 1.3 ms at the median and 2.2 ms at the 99th percentile over $n = 1009$ solves: 2.6 % and 4.4 % of its 50 ms period. The controller's problem dimensions are unchanged by the estimator configuration.

The full-state estimator ($N = 20$, 10 Hz) logs its solve time as a mean and a maximum over consecutive 2 s windows, not per solve. Over the 120 cohort flights, with the first two windows of each flight discarded ($n = 5800$ windows), the window mean had a median of 2.8 ms, a 90th percentile of 5.4 ms and a 99th percentile of 14.3 ms; the largest single solve recorded in any window was 77.3 ms. Against the 100 ms period the estimator never overran in the cohort, but the worst case used about three quarters of it, and because only window aggregates were recorded, the per-solve percentiles are not available. The reduced estimator logs every solve; its timing is reported with the comparison of Section 5.7.3.

The deadline is met in simulation. We nevertheless make *no* claim about headroom on an onboard computer; that requires measurement on the target hardware.

5.2 Evaluated Configuration

Throughout this dissertation, *evaluated configuration* means the full-state (14-state) mass-only MHE of Section 4.2.2 at 10 Hz ($N = 20$), driven by odometry and the rotor-speed wrench, with stage weights that were uniform in effect (Section 4.3.6), the $0.95\,m_B$ lower bound, lagged inertia (3.20), $r_z = -0.27$ m, window-balance seeding and the mass-only evidence score (4.37). It feeds the 13-state NMPC at 20 Hz. The cohort additionally sets five non-default choices

explicitly:

1. the residual specific force $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ of Section 4.4.3 ($a = 10$, $\omega_c = 0.5\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$);
2. the attach-time inertia floor held until the release command (Section 4.6.3);
3. alignment relative to the parcel before grasp, to 0.012 m with at most 4 s of waiting (Section 5.8.2);
4. a smoothed initial yaw reference at the start of the figure-eight;
5. the shortened arm described above.

Offset compensation is off and every grasp is centred. Inner-loop scaling and lifecycle thresholds remain at their documented defaults; switches belonging to the unused moment/offset formulation are inactive. Appendix A gives the complete resolved configuration. All 120 flight records were checked and contain the 14-state selection, lagged inertia, residual, inertia-floor hold, relative alignment, yaw smoothing and stated r_z prior.

Deployed estimator. After the cohort and the release campaign, the experiment entry points were switched to the reduced velocity–mass estimator of Section 4.2.1. Every flight of Sections 5.5–5.6, of the ablations other than Section 5.7.3, and of the failure-mode analysis was flown with the full-state estimator; those results describe the system as evaluated, not the deployed estimator. The evidence for the replacement is Section 5.7.3. Results that depend on the estimator's model — the mass bias and its manoeuvre-induced collapse in particular — should not be transferred to the reduced estimator without that evidence.

Result-version warning. The numerical cohort tables in this working revision were collected with the earlier product score, which multiplied the mass score

by an inertia score derived from the same mass estimate. They remain useful as historical system data but do not constitute final closed-loop validation of (4.37). The cohort driver now selects the mass-only score explicitly; the tables and effect summaries in this chapter must be regenerated from that rerun before the dissertation is submitted. Offline replay found no timing change in 68 of 71 score-confirmed flights and a 0.1 s advance in the other three, but replay is not a substitute for the planned closed-loop rerun.

5.3 Experimental Questions and Hypotheses

The evaluation is organised around five questions. For each, the design of Chapters 3 and 4 implies an expected outcome, stated here so that the results can be read against it.

Q1 Mass identifiability. Is the composite mass identified through grasp, carry and release from the measured wrench and odometry alone? *Expected:* accurate in loaded hover; biased low in sustained manoeuvre, because rotational model error reaches the mass through the attitude (Section 3.4.2).

Q2 Release completion. Is every physical release accepted, and how long after the payload has left? *Expected:* completion, at a delay of at least the 1 s persistence hold plus the time the estimate needs to fall.

Q3 Delayed detachment. When the command precedes the physical detachment, does an evidence-gated arm avoid accepting a release while the payload is still attached? *Expected:* the command-triggered arm accepts early by the length of the hold; the evidence-gated arms do not.

Q4 Arming policy. What does running the confirmation before the command cost in false acceptances during carry, and what does command-arming cost in delay? *Expected:* the always-on rule inherits the manoeuvre-induced collapse of the estimate (Section 4.7.6).

Q5 Tracking. Does the release arm change tracking, and what does the residual specific force contribute? *Expected:* no difference between arms, since the controller's mass follows the estimate in all of them; an improvement from the residual, which compensates the mass bias.

Failure modes and operating limits are examined separately in Section 5.8.

5.3.1 Release-acceptance arms

The release-acceptance logic is parameterised, so that the arms differ in exactly one factor wherever possible. Table 5.2 lists them. Arm B is the rule originally proposed for this interface and the default of the implementation; arm C differs from it only in when the persistence count may start.

Table 5.2: Release-acceptance arms implemented as switchable settings. In every arm the controller's mass and inertia follow the estimate continuously; the arms differ only in when a release is accepted.

Arm	Name	Release-acceptance rule
B	Always-on confirmed	evidence score (4.38) counted throughout loaded flight; the command does not accept the release
A	Command-immediate	accepts the release at the command itself, with no confirmation
C	Command-armed confirmed	the same confirmation, but persistence counted only after the command arrives
—	Oracle	accepts at the true separation instant; an upper bound, not deployable, not run in the cohort

What *accepting* the release does should be stated precisely, because in the continuous interface it is less than the name of arm A suggests. Accepting marks the release complete in the lifecycle and resets the residual specific force $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ of Section 4.4.3, which was compensating the loaded vehicle. It does *not* replace the controller's mass or inertia: in every arm those follow the published estimate throughout, so a vehicle whose payload is still attached keeps a loaded mass in its model whatever the arm has declared. The attach-time inertia floor

is ended by the release command in all three arms (Section 4.6.3), after which the inertia, too, is whatever the estimate implies. The arms therefore differ only in *when* the release is declared complete and *when* $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ is reset.

5.3.2 Conditions and scenarios

Three nominal conditions are used: 0.15 kg at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, 0.15 kg at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and 0.30 kg at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, labelled c1, c2 and c3. The last is deliberately a stress condition, with hover at 74 % of maximum thrust, for reasons quantified in Section 5.8.3.

Two scenarios are crossed with those conditions in the frozen cohort:

1. **Nominal grasp–carry–release** (d0), arms A and B.
2. **Delayed detachment** (d4), arms A, B and C. A fault injector accepts the normal release command but holds the physical joint for 4 s. This separates "the command was issued" from "the payload left".

One further scenario was implemented but is outside the cohort. **Unsignaled loss**, in which the payload is detached at the release phase with no command and no notification, emulates a gripper that opens by itself or a load torn off. It was *not* run in the cohort, because in the evaluated configuration the attach-time inertia floor is released only by the release command (Section 4.6.3): after a loss without a command the empty airframe keeps flying with the envelope inner-loop scale, and smoke flights of this scenario showed pitch-moment saturation in 8–31 % of samples. A partial-loss scenario and a thrust-map mismatch scenario were also designed but were not run in the cohort; Section 5.9.2 states what is and is not known about them. Uncommanded loss and a thrust-map error in the release detector were later flown under the force-balance rule, which ends the inertia floor on detected loss (Section 5.6).

5.4 Cohort Design, Eligibility and Metrics

The cohort has five arm–scenario cells per condition, 15 cells in all. Each block runs every cell once, in an order drawn from a fixed random seed, and eight blocks give 120 flights. Every flight launched enters the statistics, and none is re-run: a flight that crashes or fails to grasp is reported as such, under the eligibility rule below. The arms are implemented by the release-baseline switch of the controller (A: accept at the command; B: always-on confirmation; C: command-armed confirmation). The cohort was launched on 30 October 2026 with block seed 1793358067; all 120 scheduled flights ran, and the attempts and exclusions are listed in Table 5.4.

Eligibility is declared before scoring: a flight enters the release statistics if the payload physically attached, according to the gripper's own attach record, and the vehicle survived to the release command. Physical attachment is used rather than the estimator's own mass evidence, because the latter would silently exclude flights whose estimator failed to recognise an attached payload — exactly the cases most worth reporting.

5.4.1 Sources of evidence

Table 5.3 lists every source of evidence used in this chapter. Only the first row supports the primary results of Section 5.5; the second, a frozen campaign of the same standing, is analysed on its own in Section 5.6 and never pooled with the first. The two smaller frozen batches each answer one question in one configuration; the horizontal-offset ablation was run in an earlier, eccentric configuration; and development flights are cited only for mechanisms, never pooled with frozen results or used to estimate an effect size.

Table 5.3: Sources of evidence in this chapter, in decreasing order of standing.

Source	Flights	Configuration and use	Section
Frozen cohort	120 attempted, 118 eligible	evaluated configuration; arms A/B/C; d0 and d4; three conditions; primary results	5.5
Release campaign	312 attempted, 312 eligible	evaluated configuration with the force-balance rule (arm D); four experiments, four conditions; analysed separately from the cohort	5.6
Residual ablation	48	arm B, nominal release, residual on/off, three conditions	5.7.1
Inertia-treatment comparison	16 (8 + 8)	0.30 kg at 4 $\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$; release at 45 s rather than at the tip	5.7.2
Horizontal-offset ablation	8 (4 + 4)	earlier eccentric configuration, 0.15 kg	5.7.4
Development flights	single flights to batches of 8	earlier configurations, changes confounded; mechanisms only	5.8.1, 5.7.2

5.4.2 Attempts and exclusions

Table 5.4: Attempts and exclusions in the frozen cohort. Eligible: physically attached according to the gripper's record, and survived to the release command. Crashed: before the release command. Conditions as in Section 5.3.2.

Cond.	Attempted	Attached	Eligible	Crashed	Excluded
c1	40	40	40	0	—
c2	40	39	39	0	1 missed grasp (A, d0)
c3	40	39	39	0	1 simulator stall (C, d4)
Total	120	118	118	0	2

Table 5.4 accounts for every flight launched. Two were ineligible. In one, the parcel was 0.47 m below the gripper at the grasp, just outside the attachment window — most plausibly the vertical drift of the grasp height described in Section 5.8.2 — and the grasp was never made. In the other, the simulator stopped advancing before take-off and the flight produced no estimator or controller data; this is an infrastructure failure, and it is reported rather than re-run, in accordance with the no-re-run rule of Section 5.4. No flight that produced data crashed or diverged in any phase.

5.4.3 Metrics

Position tracking is summarised by

$$\mathrm{RMSE}_p = \sqrt{\frac{1}{K}\sum_{k=1}^{K}\left\|\boldsymbol{p}_k - \boldsymbol{p}_k^{\mathrm{ref}}\right\|_2^2}. \tag{5.2}$$

Estimator metrics are the composite-mass error in loaded hover, in loaded manoeuvre and after release; the fraction of loaded figure-eight samples in which $\hat{m}_P$ falls below half the true payload, called the *collapse fraction*; the fraction of samples resting on a bound; and the number of window re-anchorings. The collapse threshold is relative because an absolute one does not transfer between payloads: a fixed 0.15 kg threshold, used in earlier development work at 0.30 kg where it coincides with the relative definition, would classify every sample of a 0.15 kg flight with any negative bias as collapsed. Hover is the interval from 2 s after the end of the lift ramp to the start of the figure-eight; loaded figure-eight runs from 5 s after its start to the release command; post-release runs from 10 s to 40 s after physical detachment. Position RMSE in loaded figure-eight uses the same interval, and post-release RMSE the interval from 5 s to 35 s after detachment. Lifecycle metrics are the completion rate, the confirmation delay measured from the release command to the end of the 1.0 s evidence-score hold, and the count of confirmations occurring during loaded carry before any command or injected loss. Computational metrics are the median and upper percentiles of the solve time for both optimisers.

Ground truth is used only in offline scoring. The composite-mass truth is the airframe mass plus the payload mass while the simulator's joint record shows the payload attached; it never reaches the estimator.

5.5 Primary Results

5.5.1 Mass estimation

The behaviour the design intends is that $\hat{m}$ rises with no attach notification, holds near truth in loaded hover, and returns to the bare-airframe value after release without any event resetting it. The behaviour it does *not* guarantee is accuracy in sustained manoeuvre, where the estimator's approximate rotational model (Section 3.4.2) leaks into the mass. Figure 5.1 shows both on the nominal flights of the cohort, and Table 5.5 summarises every physically attached flight.

Table 5.5: Composite-mass error by flight phase, all physically attached cohort flights (all arms and scenarios; the estimator is identical across arms). Errors are medians over flights of the per-flight mean, with the range of per-flight values in brackets; post-release error is relative to m_B. Collapse fraction: share of loaded figure-eight samples with $\hat{m}_P < \frac{1}{2}m_P$. Bound: share resting on $m_T = 0.95\,m_B$.

Cond.	n	Hover [%]	Figure-eight [%]	Post [%]	Collapse	Bound
c1	40	−0.21	−0.97 [−2.50, −0.47]	−0.94	0.00 [0, 0.12]	0.000
c2	39	−0.22	−4.09 [−6.27, −2.37]	−1.70	0.38 [0.21, 0.73]	0.010
c3	39	−0.29	−3.30 [−8.09, −1.62]	−1.68	0.03 [0, 0.40]	0.014

Three findings follow. First, in loaded hover the estimate is accurate in every flight: the per-flight mean error lies between $-0.44\,\%$ and $-0.10\,\%$ of the composite mass, which for the lighter payload is within about 10 g. No physically attached flight failed to recognise its payload. Second, in the figure-eight the bias is small at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ (median $-1.0\,\%$) and roughly four times larger at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and it is not constant: the error dips about once every 11 s, half the figure-eight period, to $-6\,\%$ to $-9\,\%$ in the median trace. The first dip, at the entry to the figure-eight while the speed ramps up, takes the median of both $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ conditions to the lower mass bound. Because the dip is a fixed fraction of the composite mass, it is a larger fraction of the *payload* for the lighter one, which is why the collapse fraction is highest at c2 (median 0.38)

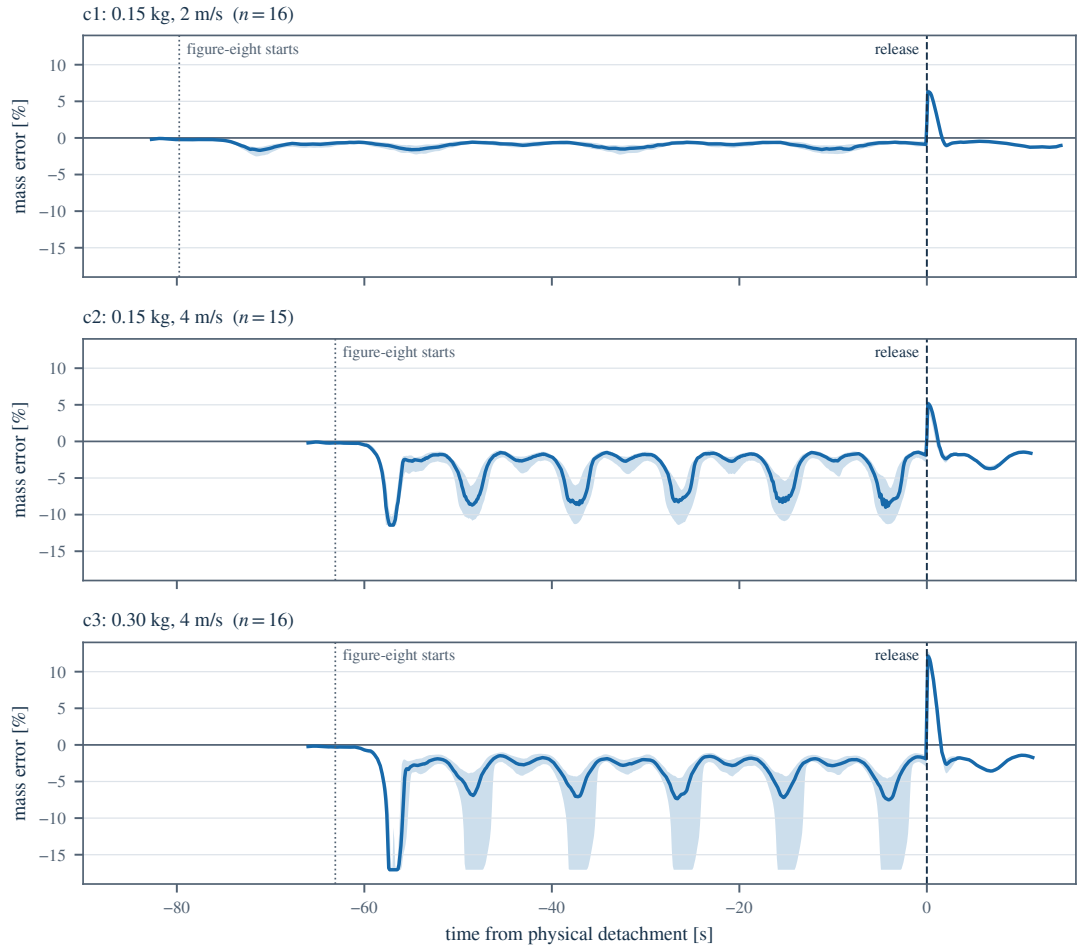


Figure 5.1: Composite-mass error $(\hat{m}-m)/m$ of the nominal (d0) cohort flights, each aligned on its own physical detachment and scored against its own truth. Line: median over flights; band: 10th–90th percentile. Traces start at the end of the lift ramp, because before lift-off the parcel rests on the ground and the joint record is not a usable truth. The positive transient at release is the estimator's lag behind an instantaneous truth step. The floor of the c3 band at $-17\,\%$ is the mass lower bound $0.95\,m_B$.

although c3's dips reach the bound more often. Third, after release the estimate settles slightly below the bare airframe, $-0.9\,\%$ to $-1.7\,\%$ of m_B; since $\hat{m}_P = (\hat{m}-m_B)^+$ is then zero, the release confirmation is unaffected.

The manoeuvre-induced dips of the second finding are the collapse that Section 5.8 discusses as the dominant failure of the interface. In the evaluated configuration the collapse fraction had medians of 0, 0.38 and 0.03 at c1, c2 and c3, with the per-flight maximum reaching 0.73 at c2 (Table 5.5); at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ the estimate touched the mass lower bound at the entry to the figure-eight in at

least half the flights, and in some c3 flights at every dip thereafter (Figure 5.1). Its lifecycle consequence is reported in Section 5.5.4. The collapse no longer cost a flight: the inertia floor held the inner-loop scale at 2.34 through every loaded figure-eight (Section 5.8.3), the residual kept the vertical tracking error below 1 mm on average (Section 5.7.1), and no eligible flight diverged. But it was not prevented, and its effect on the lifecycle is undiminished. Development flights that show the mechanism of the collapse, in earlier configurations, are reported separately in Section 5.8.1.

5.5.2 Release completion and delay

Two delay modes are possible by construction and would have to be reported separately rather than pooled: confirmation while the vehicle is still flying the figure-eight, and confirmation after the 12 s timeout has declared UNRESOLVED and the vehicle has braked to hover. In the cohort only the first occurred. Table 5.6 lists completion and delay for every eligible flight.

Every one of the 118 eligible flights completed its release (CP interval $[0.969, 1]$); none reached UNRESOLVED, and no flight diverged. Pooled over conditions and scenarios, arm B completed 48 of 48 ($[0.926, 1]$). Arm B's confirmation arrived 2.3 s to 3.2 s after the payload physically left, in manoeuvre, with medians of 3.0 s at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and 2.5 s to 3.1 s at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. About 1 s of this is the persistence hold of (4.38); the rest is the time the estimate takes to fall through the evidence-score transition band (Figure 5.1). That delay is the price of confirmation under nominal conditions, where the command is true.

The completion rate does not by itself show that the confirmations were correct. Arm B also confirmed releases that had not happened: 114 times during loaded carry, all at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, before any command. These are reported with arm C in Section 5.5.4; arm C confirmed real detachments in the same 2.4 s to 3.2 s range (Table 5.6).

Table 5.6: Release completion and confirmation delay, all eligible cohort flights. Delay is from the release command to acceptance; under delayed detachment (d4) it is also given from the physical detachment. CP: two-sided 95 % Clopper–Pearson interval on the completion rate. Ranges are over flights.

Cond.	Arm	Scen.	Done	CP	From command [s]	From detachment [s]
c1	A	d0	8/8	[0.63, 1]	0	0
	A	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	0	−4.08
	B	d0	8/8	[0.63, 1]	2.96 (2.76–3.00)	2.96
	B	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	7.16 (7.10–7.26)	3.07
	C	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	7.13 (7.10–7.16)	3.07
c2	A	d0	7/7	[0.59, 1]	0	0
	A	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	0	−4.07
	B	d0	8/8	[0.63, 1]	2.60 (2.30–2.70)	2.60
	B	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	6.56 (6.30–6.76)	2.51
	C	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	6.65 (6.40–6.76)	2.62
c3	A	d0	8/8	[0.63, 1]	0	0
	A	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	0	−4.03
	B	d0	8/8	[0.63, 1]	3.03 (2.90–3.16)	3.03
	B	d4	8/8	[0.63, 1]	7.10 (6.96–7.26)	3.06
	C	d4	7/7	[0.59, 1]	7.00 (6.96–7.20)	2.97

5.5.3 Delayed detachment

A command-triggered arm accepts the release at the command and therefore declares, for the whole of the hold, that a payload has gone which is still attached. As Section 5.3.1 explains, in the continuous interface this does not put an empty model on the loaded vehicle: the controller's mass and inertia keep following the estimate, which still sees the payload. What the early acceptance does change is the lifecycle's report, which is wrong for the duration of the hold, and the residual $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$, which is reset while the mass bias it was compensating is still present. An evidence-gated arm should accept in none of these flights.

That is what the cohort shows. Arm A accepted before the joint was removed in all 24 of its delayed-detachment flights, about 4.0 s early in each; arms B and C accepted early in none of their 47 (Table 5.6). Measured from the physical detachment, arm B's confirmation came 2.3 s to 3.2 s later (medians 2.5 s

to 3.1 s), the same as under nominal release: holding the joint for 4 s neither produced a confirmation during the hold nor slowed the one after it. What this experiment shows is a difference in *lifecycle correctness*. It does not show a difference in tracking or survival, and none was expected with the hold this short and the mass model unaffected; a permanently jammed gripper is a separate test.

5.5.4 Command-armed versus always-on confirmation

A delayed-detachment result reflects *persistent confirmation*: arm C, which starts counting only after the command, also never accepts early. The difference between arms B and C lies elsewhere. Arm B's confirmation rule runs throughout loaded flight and can fire during carry if the mass estimate collapses (Section 4.7.6); arm C's cannot, because it is not armed until the command. The comparison therefore measures what running the rule before the command costs in false confirmations.

Table 5.7: Release confirmations during loaded carry (after physical attachment, before the release command), all physically attached cohort flights. Arm A does not run the confirmation rule.

Cond.	B: flights	B: confirmations	C: flights	C: confirmations
c1	0 of 16	0	0 of 8	0
c2	14 of 16	78	0 of 8	0
c3	6 of 16	36	0 of 7	0

Table 5.7 gives the result. Arm C confirmed no release during loaded carry in any of its 23 flights, a per-flight rate whose 95 % upper bound is 0.15. Arm B confirmed 114 releases that had not happened, in 20 of its 32 flights at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and in none of its 16 at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. They are not isolated events: an affected flight typically confirmed about six times, spaced about 11 s apart, each time at an evidence score above 0.99. The spacing is the half-period of the figure-eight and coincides with the dips of Figure 5.1: each dip carries $\hat{m}_P$ below the confirmation threshold for longer than the 1 s hold. At c2 the light payload

makes this nearly certain; at c3 the same relative dip leaves more payload mass above the threshold, and it happened in fewer flights.

In the evaluated configuration these false confirmations had no effect on control. With no release command pending, an acceptance neither resets $\hat{d}$ nor ends the inertia floor, and the controller's mass follows the estimate in either case; the release command re-arms the rule, so the genuine release was still confirmed in every flight. The error is in the lifecycle's report: a delivery system that acted on *release confirmed* would, at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, have been told repeatedly that a parcel still on the hook had been delivered. Arm C avoids this by construction, at no cost in delay (Table 5.6); its price is that it cannot detect a release that was never commanded.

The comparison settles the arming policy. The always-on rule of arm B is a negative result: it shows that, in this configuration, mass evidence alone does not separate a loaded vehicle in manoeuvre from an empty one, and a rule that admits only that evidence will accept releases that have not happened. The command-armed rule of arm C keeps the property the delayed-detachment experiment established — it does not accept a release while the payload is still attached — without the false acceptances, and without a longer delay after detachment. It is the mechanism the present evidence supports. Its scope is correspondingly narrower: it distinguishes a commanded release from a physical detachment, and it cannot by itself detect a load lost without a command.

5.5.5 Tracking performance

Under nominal conditions the command is true, so waiting for confirmation can gain nothing and costs a delay; arm A has zero confirmation delay by construction. The purpose of the nominal pairs is to establish that the always-on confirmed arm completes and tracks as well as the command-triggered one, not that it is better: in the continuous interface the controller's mass and inertia

follow the estimate in both arms, so no tracking difference is expected.

Pairs are formed within a block at the same condition. Both arms completed every pair. Post-release position RMSE (median over pairs, arm A against arm B) was 0.028 m against 0.026 m at c1 ($n = 8$, Wilcoxon $p = 0.38$), 0.108 m against 0.088 m at c2 ($n = 7$, $p = 0.078$) and 0.104 m against 0.102 m at c3 ($n = 8$, $p = 0.74$). Loaded figure-eight RMSE, before any difference between the arms can act, was 0.029 m to 0.033 m at c1 and 0.118 m to 0.126 m at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ in both arms. No difference in post-release stability was detected; the c2 pair count is seven because one arm A flight missed its grasp (Table 5.4).

Tracking is therefore governed by the condition rather than by the release arm: loaded figure-eight RMSE is about 0.03 m at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and about 0.12 m at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. What does change tracking is the residual specific force, whose contribution is isolated in Section 5.7.1.

5.6 Release Campaign with Force-Balance Evidence

The cohort leaves three questions open: whether release evidence that does not pass through the mass estimate removes the carry-phase false acceptances of the always-on rule; whether such a rule can detect a load lost without a command and remain safe when a commanded release fails; and how the interface compares with fixed-parameter and lumped-adaptive control. A second frozen campaign of 312 flights, run on 3–4 November 2026, addresses them with the force-balance rule of Section 4.7.5, here called arm D. Its results are reported separately from the cohort and are not pooled with it; the earlier cohort's logs were used only for offline replay before the campaign was frozen.

5.6.1 Design

Arm D is the dual-enabled force-balance rule: the score (4.42), consumed only when a release command is pending or the uncommanded-loss watchdog is armed. Arm A is the command-immediate arm of Table 5.2. The two arms share every other setting of the evaluated configuration of Section 5.2, and they differ only in the release lifecycle. A fourth condition, c4 (0.30 kg at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$), completes a two-by-two mass–speed design with c1–c3 as defined in Section 5.3.2. Table 5.8 lists the four experiments.

Table 5.8: Experiments of the force-balance release campaign. All four conditions c1–c4 appear in every experiment. d0: nominal release; d4: detachment held 4 s **after the command.**

Experiment	Flights	Factors	Arm
E1 Release semantics	144	arm A/D × d0/d4 × 4 conditions; 9 paired blocks	A and D
E2 Controller comparison	72	Fixed / $\mathscr{L}_1$ / MHE × 4 conditions; 6 rounds; d0	D
E3 Thrust-map error	48	detector thrust scaled by 0.90 / 1.10 × 4 conditions; 6 rounds; d0	D
E4 Faults	48	uncommanded loss / jammed gripper × 4 conditions; 6 rounds	D

In E1 each block contains one round of eight flights with nominal release and one with delayed detachment, both rounds covering the four conditions under both arms, with the order of the rounds and of the flights within them drawn from a recorded seed. In E2 the three controllers share the arm-D lifecycle, the inertia floor and the inner-loop scheduling, and differ only in their translational compensation. *Fixed* keeps the bare-airframe mass in the prediction model with no translational adaptation. $\mathscr{L}_1$ keeps the same mass and compensates with the residual $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ alone. *MHE* is the evaluated configuration, with the estimated mass and $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$. In E3 the thrust (4.41) seen by the force-balance detector is scaled by a fixed factor; the plant, the controller's thrust map and the residual are unchanged, the payload mass and thresholds are not altered, and the factor actually applied is recorded in each flight's log (0.900 and 1.100 in 24 flights

each). In E4 an *uncommanded loss* detaches the payload at the release phase with no command, no pending release and no notification to the estimator. A *jammed gripper* receives the normal command and never releases.

Thresholds, filters, arming and confirmation times, controller and trajectory parameters were frozen before the first flight. A fingerprint of the flight code was recorded at the start and checked before every flight; it did not change. A flight was eligible if the payload physically attached, the vehicle survived to the release command or the injected fault, the estimator, controller, gripper, inertial, rotor-speed and residual logs were complete, and the recorded configuration matched the schedule. False or missed confirmations, divergence, solver failures, large tracking errors, an UNRESOLVED jam and a failed recovery after loss count as results, never as exclusions; in E2 a divergence before the command counts as a controller failure. Ineligible flights would have been replaced, and only those; none occurred. All 312 scheduled flights attached and were eligible, so every cell has its planned size (nine per E1 cell, six per cell elsewhere). No flight in the campaign diverged. Post-release metrics here use a window from physical detachment (or the injected loss) to 25 s after it, which differs from the cohort's window; post-release numbers are not comparable across the two.

5.6.2 Release semantics and carry-phase acceptance

Table 5.9: Release acceptance under the force-balance rule (E1). Median (range) over nine flights per cell. det.: time of acceptance relative to physical detachment (negative = before the payload left); cmd: relative to the release command. Every flight in every cell completed its release.

	A, d4	D, d0	D, d4	
Cond.	**det. [s]**	**det. [s]**	**cmd [s]**	**det. [s]**
c1	−4.05 (−4.09 to −4.04)	2.06 (2.00–2.15)	6.20 (6.10–6.26)	2.12 (2.05–2.21)
c2	−4.09 (−4.10 to −4.04)	1.94 (1.90–2.05)	6.10 (6.00–6.16)	2.01 (1.91–2.12)
c3	−4.09 (−4.09 to −4.00)	2.30 (2.20–2.44)	6.40 (6.25–6.45)	2.31 (2.20–2.44)
c4	−4.05 (−4.09 to −4.04)	2.40 (2.30–2.46)	6.46 (6.34–6.60)	2.41 (2.34–2.51)

Table 5.9 reproduces the delayed-detachment result of the cohort with the new evidence. Arm A accepted before the payload left in all 36 of its delayed-detachment flights, by 4.05 s at the median. Arm D accepted early in none of its 36 (95 % CP upper bound 0.10) and completed all 72 of its releases ($[0.950, 1]$). Its confirmation came 1.90 s to 2.51 s after physical detachment (median 2.20 s, 95th percentile 2.44 s). Holding the joint for 4 s did not change the delay measured from detachment. About 1 s of it is the persistence hold; the rest is the two low-pass stages of (4.41)–(4.42).

The delay depends on the mass and hardly at all on the speed. In an effect-coded two-by-two regression on the nominal flights, the heavier payload lengthened the delay from detachment by 0.35 s (± 0.02, $p < 10^{-15}$), the higher speed shortened it by 0.08 s ($p = 0.0006$), and the interaction was not detectable ($+0.02$, $p = 0.64$); under delayed detachment the effects were $+0.30$, -0.14 and $+0.01$ s ($p = 0.76$ for the interaction). A larger payload leaves a larger step for the filtered score to traverse before it crosses 0.90.

The comparison that matters for the arming policy is carry. In every arm-D flight the watchdog armed after the lift and before the release command, a median of 3.2 s after the start of the lift (range 1.9 s to 3.9 s). From that point, the rule was able to accept a release at any time during carry, which is the always-on property that produced the cohort's 114 false acceptances. Across all 240 flights of the campaign flown with the arm-D lifecycle, the watchdog was armed in 228, and no release was accepted during loaded carry in any flight (95 % upper bound 0.016 per armed flight), including every armed flight at c2, the condition at which the mass evidence had failed in 14 of 16 cohort flights. The force balance therefore separates a loaded vehicle in manoeuvre from an empty one where the mass estimate did not. The twelve flights in which the watchdog did not arm are the thrust-map cases of Section 5.6.4.

Arm D's delay after detachment, 1.9 s to 2.5 s, is also shorter than the 2.3 s to 3.2 s of the cohort's mass-evidence arms. The two come from different batches

and are not a paired comparison.

Tracking did not differ consistently between the arms. Of the eight within-block pairings of post-release RMSE (four conditions, two scenarios), seven showed no difference ($p \geq 0.07$, Wilcoxon, nine pairs each); at c3 with delayed detachment arm D's was higher by 0.014 m at the median ($p = 0.004$). As in the cohort, the result concerns the lifecycle, not tracking.

5.6.3 Uncommanded loss and a jammed gripper

Table 5.10: Faults under the force-balance rule (E4), six flights per cell. Loss: payload detached with no command. Armed: watchdog armed before the loss. Delay: from detachment to the declared loss, median (range). Reset: geometry zeroed and inner-loop scale returned to the bare airframe. Jam: command issued, payload never released. False acc.: release accepted. Hover: UNRESOLVED, braked, then hovering below $0.5\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$.

	Uncommanded loss				Jammed gripper	
Cond.	**Armed**	**Detected**	**Delay [s]**	**Reset**	**False acc.**	**Hover**
c1	6/6	6/6	2.03 (1.76–2.10)	6/6	0/6	6/6
c2	6/6	6/6	1.94 (1.90–2.00)	6/6	0/6	6/6
c3	6/6	6/6	2.34 (2.20–2.50)	6/6	0/6	6/6
c4	6/6	6/6	2.38 (2.30–2.46)	6/6	0/6	6/6

Table 5.10 gives the fault results. The watchdog was armed before the loss in all 24 uncommanded-loss flights, and every loss was detected ($24/24$, $[0.86, 1]$), 1.8 s to 2.5 s after the payload left; none was declared before it. In every case the payload geometry was zeroed, the inner-loop scale returned from the floor value to that of the bare airframe, no planned release was issued afterwards, and no flight diverged; the largest post-loss position error had a median between 0.08 m and 0.20 m by condition. This is the scenario the cohort could not fly, because under the mass-evidence rules nothing other than the command ended the inertia floor (Section 5.3.2).

The jammed gripper is the converse test: the command is true and the detach-

ment never comes. No release was accepted in any of the 24 flights ($0/24$, $[0, 0.14]$), and the payload model was never cleared. Every flight reached UNRESOLVED at the 12 s timeout, armed the braking reference and came to hover, with a largest speed in hover of $0.18\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ over all flights.

5.6.4 Thrust-map error

Table 5.11: Thrust-map error in the force-balance detector (E3), six flights per cell. m_{acc} bias: median error relative to the true composite mass, in loaded carry and after release. γ_{acc} max: median over flights of the largest score in loaded carry. Delay from the command.

Gain	Cond.	Bias, carry	Bias, post	γ_{acc} max	Armed	Done	Delay [s]
0.90	c1	−10.4 %	−10.3 %	1.00	0/6	6/6	0.96
	c2	−10.7 %	−10.5 %	1.00	0/6	6/6	0.95
	c3	−10.7 %	−10.6 %	0.62	6/6	6/6	1.48
	c4	−10.4 %	−10.4 %	0.18	6/6	6/6	1.56
1.10	c1	+9.3 %	+9.8 %	0.00	6/6	0/6	—
	c2	+9.1 %	+9.8 %	0.00	6/6	0/6	—
	c3	+9.0 %	+9.8 %	0.00	6/6	0/6	—
	c4	+9.3 %	+9.8 %	0.00	6/6	0/6	—

The force-balance mass moved one-for-one with the injected error (Table 5.11), and the two directions failed differently, as the analysis of Section 5.9.1 predicts for the mass channel. A 10 % error in the composite mass is 0.22 kg to 0.24 kg, larger than the lighter payload and close to the heavier one.

*Overestimated thrust (*1.10*).* After release the empty vehicle read about 10 % heavier than it was, the score never rose, and none of the 24 releases was confirmed. Every flight reached UNRESOLVED, braked and hovered, without divergence. The failure is a miss, and it ends in the safe state the timeout was designed for. By the same arithmetic, an uncommanded loss would also go undetected; that was not flown.

*Underestimated thrust (*0.90*).* No release was accepted during carry and every release completed, faster than nominally. That outcome hides two failures. With

the lighter payload the loaded vehicle already read as empty — the score was 1.00 throughout carry — so the watchdog never armed in any of the 12 flights: protection against uncommanded loss was silently lost. Confirmation followed the command by the length of the hold alone, because the score was already high; with delayed detachment, which E3 did not include, the same rule would be expected to accept before the payload left. With the heavier payload the watchdog armed, but the largest carry score reached 0.85 in one flight, close to the 0.90 threshold. The dual enabling prevented every false acceptance in E3; it cannot restore evidence the thrust map has removed.

5.6.5 Fixed, $\mathscr{L}_1$ and MHE controllers

Table 5.12: Controller comparison under the force-balance rule (E2), nominal release. Medians over six flights per cell. Loaded RMSE: from 5 s **into the figure-eight to the command. Post: detachment to** 25 s **after it. Delay from detachment.**

Cond.	Controller	Loaded RMSE [m]	Post RMSE [m]	Post peak [m]	Delay [s]
c1	Fixed	0.087	0.031	0.090	2.00
	$\mathscr{L}_1$	0.032	0.030	0.077	2.03
	MHE	0.033	0.026	0.072	2.08
c2	Fixed	0.151	0.118	0.203	1.94
	$\mathscr{L}_1$	0.099	0.085	0.136	2.02
	MHE	0.123	0.102	0.163	1.97
c3	Fixed	0.218	0.130	0.211	2.25
	$\mathscr{L}_1$	0.114	0.107	0.198	2.29
	MHE	0.117	0.096	0.206	2.32
c4	Fixed	0.168	0.036	0.170	2.40
	$\mathscr{L}_1$	0.030	0.045	0.149	2.40
	MHE	0.028	0.033	0.134	2.40

All 72 flights completed their release without divergence or saturation of the collective thrust, with one solver failure in one flight, and the confirmation delay did not depend on the controller (Table 5.12). Flights were paired within rounds; with six pairs the smallest attainable two-sided Wilcoxon p is 0.031.

Against the fixed-parameter controller the benefit of adaptation is clear in loaded

carry: the MHE controller had the smaller loaded RMSE in all 24 pairs ($p = 0.031$ in each condition), by 0.04 m to 0.14 m at the median, largest with the heavier payload. After release, when the fixed model is again correct, the difference in RMSE shrank to 0.002 m to 0.033 m and was consistent only at c1 ($p = 0.031$).

Against the $\mathscr{L}_1$ controller, which compensates the same payload with the residual alone, no consistent difference in loaded tracking was found ($p \geq 0.16$ in every condition); at c2 the $\mathscr{L}_1$ controller was nominally the better in five of six pairs. After release the MHE controller had the smaller peak error at both $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ conditions in all six pairs ($p = 0.031$), by 0.006 m to 0.017 m, and the smaller RMSE at c4 ($p = 0.031$); at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ there was no consistent difference. With the residual present in both, estimating the mass is therefore not shown to improve tracking in carry, and its measurable effect in this experiment is a small one in the transient after release at low speed. The three controllers also share the inertia floor and the inner-loop scheduling, so E2 does not test the rotational benefit of the payload model.

5.6.6 Scope of the campaign

The campaign has the limitations of the cohort — simulation only, one airframe and gripper geometry, centred grasps, no wind — and some of its own. The thrust-map error was applied to the detector's input alone; neither the estimator's mass channel nor the plant was perturbed, and E3 used only nominal release. Every zero-count result is bounded by the cell sizes: an upper bound of 0.10 for early acceptance and 0.14 for false acceptance under a jam. The interface code of the campaign was not committed; the record holds the base revision, a patch of the uncommitted changes and an archive of untracked files, as for the cohort (Section 5.9.4). The campaign's data and scoring scripts are in `release_paper_20261103_210022/`.

5.7 Ablations

5.7.1 The residual specific force

The residual $\hat{\boldsymbol{d}}$ of Section 4.4.3 is part of the evaluated configuration, and its contribution was isolated in a separate frozen batch of 48 flights run on 1 November 2026 (block seed 1793469773). Arm B of the cohort was flown with the residual on and off, everything else in the evaluated configuration unchanged; the flight records confirm that the residual switch is the only setting that differs between the two arms. Nominal release (d0) was crossed with the three conditions, eight blocks each, in an order drawn from the seed. The endpoints were fixed before the batch: primary, loaded figure-eight position RMSE and mean vertical error; secondary, post-release RMSE, completion, divergence, mass bias and confirmations during carry. All 48 flights attached, completed their release and did not diverge.

Table 5.13: Residual specific force on against off (arm B, nominal release). Medians over eight within-block pairs per condition; "better" counts the pairs in which the residual-on flight had the smaller value (for the vertical error, the smaller magnitude); p: Wilcoxon signed-rank. Vertical error is $z - z^{\mathrm{ref}}$ averaged over loaded figure-eight.

Metric	Cond.	On	Off	Better	p
Loaded figure-eight RMSE [m]	c1	0.033	0.047	8/8	0.008
	c2	0.116	0.148	7/8	0.016
	c3	0.106	0.145	8/8	0.008
Mean vertical error [mm]	c1	$+0.4$	-4.5	7/8	0.008
	c2	-0.8	-28.4	8/8	0.008
	c3	$+0.2$	-44.3	8/8	0.008
Post-release RMSE [m]	c1	0.023	0.044	8/8	0.008
	c2	0.089	0.132	7/8	0.016
	c3	0.073	0.115	8/8	0.008

Table 5.13 gives the result. Without the residual the vehicle flies the loaded figure-eight below its reference, by 4.5 mm at c1 and by 28 mm and 44 mm at the two $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ conditions; with it the mean vertical error is under 1 mm at

every condition. Loaded figure-eight RMSE falls by 22 % to 31 % and post-release RMSE by 33 % to 48 %, in 23 of the 24 pairs on each metric. The sag grows with the manoeuvre-induced mass bias of Section 5.5.1, which is the error the residual is there to absorb: an estimate that is low by a few percent asks for a thrust that is low by the same fraction.

Equally informative is what the residual did not change. The loaded figure-eight mass bias was the same in both arms (medians $-0.9\,\%$ against $-0.8\,\%$, $-3.6\,\%$ against $-3.1\,\%$, $-3.1\,\%$ against $-3.5\,\%$; all $p > 0.19$), and so were the confirmation delays (all $p > 0.45$) and the confirmations during carry, which occurred in both arms at c2. The residual compensates the *consequence* of the mass bias for tracking; it does not reduce the bias, and it does not touch the lifecycle. This also qualifies the inertia-treatment result of Section 5.7.2, whose tracking endpoint was measured with the residual on in both arms.

5.7.2 The inertia treatment inside the estimator

Table 3.1 lists three treatments of the inertia increment inside the estimator. The lagged treatment is the deployed default; the evidence for that choice is a closed-loop comparison against the omitted treatment, reported below together with the configuration it was run in. The evidence against the live treatment is from single development flights.

Live. With the mass-dependent inertia in the estimator's rotational model, one $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ flight overestimated the loaded mass by 28 % to 64 % relative to the force balance and diverged; with the airframe inertia additionally corrected to the simulator's value, one $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ flight overestimated it by 29 % in the figure-eight and by 39 % after release, so that confirmation never arrived. These two flights motivated the rejection of the live treatment and the argument of Section 3.4.2.

Lagged against omitted. Sixteen flights were run in alternating order, eight per treatment, at 0.30 kg on the $r = 10\,\mathrm{m}$, $w = 0.283\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$ figure-eight at a hover height of 6 m (about $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ peak speed). The primary endpoint, fixed before the batch, was loaded figure-eight position error; the mass bias was secondary.

- All sixteen flights completed the release; there were no failures in either arm.
- Mean loaded figure-eight position error was 0.113 m with the increment omitted and 0.121 m with it lagged (Mann–Whitney $p = 0.23$): no detectable difference on the primary endpoint, and not in the lagged treatment's favour.
- The online loaded figure-eight mass bias was $-8.9\,\%$ omitted and $-4.0\,\%$ lagged (Mann–Whitney $p = 0.001$). The share of those samples resting on the lower mass bound was $9.8\,\%$ and $4.6\,\%$ ($p = 0.46$, not significant).
- Cross-replay removes the flight-to-flight variation: every one of the sixteen recorded flights was re-estimated offline under both treatments from the identical recorded inputs, and the lagged treatment had the smaller loaded figure-eight bias in all sixteen (Wilcoxon signed-rank $p = 3 \times 10^{-5}$). Replay fidelity of the recorded estimator against its own logged output was of order 10^{-7}.

The lagged treatment therefore halves the loaded mass bias in manoeuvre without changing tracking, and it was adopted as the default on that basis. It does not remove the bias.

Configuration of this comparison. Both arms ran in the evaluated configuration of Section 5.2 — residual specific force, inertia floor held until the command, shortened arm, alignment relative to the parcel and smoothed yaw reference — at 0.30 kg and $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. It differs from the cohort only in the release timing:

the command was issued 45 s into the loaded figure-eight rather than at the next tip. Two consequences should be kept in view. The result is a property of that configuration; with the earlier 0.47 m arm the increment is three times larger and the comparison has not been run. And because both arms carried the residual $\hat{d}$, which compensates the translational effect of a mass bias (Section 4.4.3), the tracking endpoint is partly insensitive to the bias by construction; the null tracking result does not show that the bias is harmless.

5.7.3 Full-state versus reduced estimator

Every flight reported so far in this chapter was flown with the full-state estimator F of Section 4.2.2. The deployed default is now the reduced velocity–mass estimator R of Section 4.2.1. This subsection gives the evidence for that change in three parts: an offline replay over the recorded release campaign, a four-flight thrust-map smoke test of R in closed loop, and a paired closed-loop comparison of F and R. The two estimators share horizon, sampling, alignment of inputs and measurements, the velocity, noise and arrival weights (4.15), initialisation and event logic; they differ only in model structure and in the mass bound and health check of Section 4.3.3.

Offline replay. R was solved offline on the odometry, the interval-averaged reconstructed thrust and the 10 Hz solve instants of all 312 flights of Section 5.6, and compared with the estimate F produced online in the same flights. The replay used F's lower bound $0.95\,m_B$, so that only the model differs. Loaded windows run from 5 s after lift-off to the command or detachment, post-release windows from 5 s after detachment; convergence is entry into a ± 0.03 kg band held for 1 s. Table 5.14 gives the flight-level medians for the 264 flights with a nominal thrust map.

The reduced estimate was more accurate in every loaded and every post-release

Table 5.14: Replay of the reduced estimator on the 264 nominal-thrust flights of the release campaign, against the full-state estimate recorded online in the same flights. Flight-level medians; paired Wilcoxon signed-rank tests.

Metric	F (online)	R (replay)	R better	p
Loaded mass MAE [kg]	0.0359	0.0127	264/264	5×10^{-45}
Post-release mass MAE [kg]	0.0291	0.0093	240/240	4×10^{-41}
Convergence after lift-off [s]	4.21	4.22	—	—
Return to the empty value within the flight	183/240	240/240	—	—
Solve time, median [ms]	2.8	0.16	264/264	—

window. Convergence after lift-off was unchanged. After release, 57 of the 240 full-state estimates never re-entered the band within the flight. All 57 were at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and they had not stalled: they settled 2.15 % below the empty value (median; interquartile range -2.21 % to -2.09 %) in the continuing figure-eight, which is outside the band. The reduced estimate re-entered it in every flight. The solve times are indicative only: the replay ran on an otherwise idle core and the online figure is a window mean.

Under the thrust-map error of Section 5.6.4 the replay behaved as the analysis of Section 4.3.3 predicts. With a map 10 % high the reduced estimate was biased high by the same proportion (loaded MAE 0.207 kg, against 0.198 kg for F). With a map 10 % low it was driven onto the $0.95\,m_B$ bound: 107 of its solves, in 22 of the 24 flights, ended at the iteration limit, all at or near the bound. These 107 solves are 0.03 % of all replay solves, but they are the reason the deployed reduced estimator replaces the hard physical bound by a wide numerical box and an explicit health check.

The replay has three limitations. It cannot measure tracking, because the trajectories were generated with F in the loop. It uses the simulator's near-ideal odometry. And it does not reproduce the grasp gap of Section 4.3.4: it treats the logged solve instants as consecutive, so the windows that span the gap join samples taken about 6 s apart, and its lift-off convergence times are not a model of the online ones. It supports the reduced model as a mass estimator; it does not by itself justify putting it in the loop.

Thrust-map smoke test. Before the closed-loop comparison, R was flown once in each of four conditions — thrust map $-10\,\%$ and $10\,\%$, payload $0.15\,\mathrm{kg}$ and $0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$, at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ with immediate detachment — with the pre-registered rule that any divergence, any model update during an unhealthy interval or any failed safety fallback would stop the comparison. None occurred. No flight recorded a non-zero solver status or a re-initialisation, so the iteration-limit failures of the replay did not recur with the wider box. In both $-10\,\%$ flights the estimate was $10.2\,\%$ to $10.6\,\%$ low and was flagged below the health band whenever the airframe was empty; the controller then held its model, and its model mass did not change at all during any unhealthy interval. Both releases were confirmed, and the controller's model returned to within $0.01\,\mathrm{kg}$ of the empty value. With $10\,\%$ both releases ended in UNRESOLVED, the expected outcome because the over-reading thrust map makes the empty airframe look loaded, and both flights braked to a safe hover. With the heavier payload the estimate left the band upward during lift-off and the controller held, for the whole carry, the last accepted value of $2.272\,\mathrm{kg}$ against a true $2.364\,\mathrm{kg}$. That value is closer to the truth than the $2.60\,\mathrm{kg}$ the estimator itself reported, but it is whatever the estimate happened to be when it crossed the band edge during a transient: the check prevents an implausible model, it does not supply a correct one. With the lighter payload the $10\,\%$ estimate stayed inside the band and was used.

Paired closed-loop comparison. The deciding experiment flies F and R in the same conditions with everything else frozen: release arm D, the deployed controller, trajectory, gripper geometry, lifecycle and safety settings of Section 5.6, nominal thrust map, no injected fault. The design crosses payload ($0.15\,\mathrm{kg}$, $0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$), speed ($2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$) and detachment (immediate, $4\,\mathrm{s}$ after the command) with six paired replicates, $2\times2\times2\times6$ pairs and 96 flights. Within each of six blocks the eight cells are flown in random order with the two estimators of a pair adjacent, in random order. Only infrastructure failures are excluded;

divergence, solver failure, early or missed confirmation and UNRESOLVED are outcomes. Metrics, statistics and the acceptance criteria were fixed before the first flight: paired differences R−F with bootstrap confidence intervals of the median and Wilcoxon signed-rank tests, by payload, speed and detachment as well as overall.

5.7.4 The horizontal-offset decision

The decision to hold the controller's horizontal centre-of-mass offset at zero (Section 3.3) rests on a control-side ablation performed with eccentric grasps, before the offset was removed from the model. The cohort used 0.15 kg, a nominal 0.10 m grasp offset and the $r = 10\,\mathrm{m}$, $\omega = 0.283\,\mathrm{rad/s}$ figure-eight, with four time-paired trials per arm in alternating order. The ablated arm set the controller's offset parameters to zero, removing both the predicted thrust-offset moment and its trim-cost reference; the estimator and every other part of the controller were identical in both arms. All eight attempts physically attached and completed, with no solver failures.

Mean loaded figure-eight position RMS was 0.1230 m with compensation and 0.1213 m without it (-1.4%); the mean per-flight peak was 0.2760 m versus 0.2705 m, and lift RMS 0.4032 m versus 0.4039 m. Even at a grasp offset three times the attachment tolerance of the present configuration, modelling the offset in the controller bought nothing measurable. This is consistent with an analysis of flight logs from an earlier eccentric-load configuration, which found that the autopilot's rate integrator, not the predictive controller's torque, carried about 99 % of the trim moment even when the controller modelled the offset explicitly. This small, single-condition cohort is not an equivalence demonstration, and it does not address offsets large enough to consume most of the torque authority; the present configuration avoids that regime by aligning before grasp. The frozen logs, configurations and scoring scripts are in

`../data/ecc_ablation_20260924_202511/`.

5.7.5 A negative result on learned stage weights

The parameterised generalisation of the retired event-triggered schedule (Section 4.3.6) was optimised by cross-entropy search in the loop, on the earlier mass-only estimator, and the resulting schedule showed no measurable benefit over the hand-designed rule in a paired ablation. The objective was flat over a broad neighbourhood of that rule.

This negative result is substantively useful, and is reported rather than omitted. What produced the benefit in the predecessor system was *noticing that the model had changed and removing stale data*; the precise magnitude of the post-trigger weights is weakly determined by the data. A learned schedule should therefore not be presented as a superior learned controller. It is also part of the reason the mainline retired event logic altogether.

5.8 Failure Modes and Operating Limits

5.8.1 Manoeuvre-induced mass collapse: development evidence

The dominant failure of the mass-only interface is that the loaded mass estimate collapses toward the bare airframe during the figure-eight. Its size in the evaluated configuration is measured on the frozen cohort in Section 5.5.1. The evidence below is of a lower standard and serves a different purpose: it shows the mechanism and the consequences of the collapse. It comes from development flights at $0.30\,\mathrm{kg}$ on a figure-eight of radius $5\,\mathrm{m}$ at $w = 0.283\,\mathrm{rad\,s^{-1}}$, predates both the final cohort and the lagged default — every flight below ran with the payload inertia omitted from the estimator — and mixes configuration

changes noted where they occur. It is not pooled with the cohort.

Table 5.15 condenses the three development batches.

Table 5.15: Development evidence for the mass-collapse mechanism. Configuration changes are cumulative and the first two changes in the second row are confounded.

Configuration	Attempts	Completed	Main observation
Early baseline	8	2	two missed-grasp failures; four loaded flights lost roll control after $\hat{m}$ and the inner-loop scale collapsed
Relative alignment + yaw smoothing	8	7	survival improved ($p = 0.041$), but collapse persisted and one flight failed during carry
Shortened arm, with both changes above	8	8	collapse fraction fell from 0.05–0.90 to 0.03–0.24 ($p = 0.028$), but was not eliminated

Across the sixteen flights used for the arm comparison, collapse fraction rose with measured arm length (Spearman $\rho = 0.66,\ p = 0.005$), implicating the omitted inertia without making it the sole cause. Separate high-speed development flights recorded seven and nine carry-phase acceptances; holding the inertia floor preserved control authority but did not restore the mass estimate or the rule's discriminating power. The frozen cohort measures the current frequency of these failures in Sections 5.5.1 and 5.5.4.

These observations bound what the mass-only interface can claim. Its release confirmation is sound only while the mass estimate is: where the estimate collapses under manoeuvre, a confirmation rule that admits no other evidence will confirm a release that has not happened. The remedies available within the present architecture are the lagged inertia treatment of Section 5.7.2, now the default, which halves the bias but does not remove it; the inertia-floor hold and the residual specific force, both in the evaluated configuration, which address two of its consequences (loss of inner-loop authority and loss of thrust feedforward) without touching its cause; and the command-armed arm C, which removes the false confirmation by not running the rule before the command.

5.8.2 Grasp alignment

The centred-grasp assumption of Section 3.3 depends on the vehicle actually being over the parcel when the grasp is enabled. In development flights the autopilot's local position estimate drifted 2 cm to 4 cm per flight relative to the simulator's world frame, while the controller believed its horizontal error to be under 2 cm; with the 0.03 m attachment tolerance, roughly one flight in four or five missed the grasp. Tuning the controller cannot fix an error in the position it is given. An alignment step relative to the parcel, emulating a downward-looking camera, aligns the vehicle on the parcel's relative position to within 0.012 m, waiting at most 4 s, before the grasp is enabled; it is part of the evaluated configuration. The same drift acts vertically on the grasp height, which is why the realised arm varies from flight to flight (Section 3.6).

5.8.3 The operating limit

0.30 kg at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ is the stress condition. Hover requires 74 % of maximum thrust. At the shortened arm the inertia ratio (3.15) is 2.34 nominally and at most about 2.7 over the realised arm range, well inside the body-rate scaling cap of 5.0; with the earlier 0.47 m arm it was 5.07, above the cap, and the inner loop could not be given the authority the load implied. The arm was shortened for that reason, so what remains at this condition is a thrust and torque margin, not an inner-loop one. This is the quantitative form of the feasibility boundary predicted in Chapter 3.

The cohort confirms that the remaining margin was not exhausted. The controller logs the inner-loop scale and the share of torque commands at their bounds over consecutive 5 s windows. In loaded figure-eight the inner-loop scale had a median of 2.34 and its window minimum never fell below 2.34 in any physically attached flight: the inertia floor, held until the command, kept the

inner loop at the envelope scale however far the estimate dipped. Roll torque was never at its bound; pitch was at its bound in at most 0.3 % of samples on average; yaw was at its bound in about 2.5 % of samples at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and never at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$. The controller's solver reported at most one failure in any flight. These are window-level diagnostics, not per-sample statistics, and they say nothing about margin under disturbances the cohort did not include.

5.8.4 Estimator health

In every physically attached cohort flight the published mass left the empty value and settled within 0.44 % of truth in loaded hover (Table 5.5). The one flight whose estimate stayed at the empty value is the missed grasp of Table 5.4, where that was the correct answer: the parcel was 0.47 m below the gripper, outside the 0.45 m attachment window, and the 90th percentile of the estimated payload was 4 g. That flight is also the cohort's only instance of the bootstrap's known failure (Section 4.6.3): the empty airframe flew the $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ figure-eight with the envelope inertia floor, at a 2.34-fold inner-loop scale, and did not diverge. Estimator health at the moment of the release command was not scored separately.

One structural gap is known independently of the cohort: the phase-timed release command is *not* gated on estimator health. A release issued while the estimate is frozen leaves a model that no longer matches the vehicle after detachment. Gating release on estimator health is an obvious remedy and is not implemented.

5.8.5 Configuration and default-safety

The mass-only configuration is selected by an environment switch whose default in both experiment entry points is the 14-state form, and the estimator reports

at startup which lifecycle path is active. A second switch selects the estimator model; since 5 November 2026 both entry points default to the reduced estimator, which requires the mass-only form, and the estimator reports the selected model at startup. The cohort and the campaign predate that change and ran the full-state model. The estimator node's own library default is still the 16-state form with an augmented first moment, which this dissertation does not use: a node started directly, without an entry point, runs that form. Entry-point defaults and library defaults are therefore not interchangeable, and statements about defaults in this dissertation refer to the entry points. A configuration that does not match the one described here must be detectable from the run record alone, which is why every run records the resolved value of every behaviour-affecting switch (Appendix B).

The cohort driver sets the five non-default settings of Section 5.2 explicitly for every flight, so the cohort does not depend on the entry-point defaults, which for those settings remain off; the lagged inertia treatment is an entry-point default. A flight launched from an entry point without the cohort driver therefore does *not* run the evaluated configuration. The 14-state selection is both an entry-point default and set explicitly by the cohort driver, and each flight's record marks it as explicitly set.

5.9 Threats to Validity, Missing Baselines and Reproducibility

All system-level evidence is software-in-the-loop. The leading threats are:

- **Thrust-map fidelity.** The plant generates thrust with the same square law the estimator inverts, and rotor speeds are exact. Neither a mis-calibrated thrust coefficient (Section 5.9.1) nor speed noise, transport delay or in-

duced inflow [34] was tested in the evaluated configuration.

- **Clean state estimates.** The odometry available in simulation is better than a real vehicle's, and the measurement weights (4.12) are set from representative rather than measured noise levels. The horizontal drift of the local position estimate (Section 5.8.2) is the one deviation from clean odometry that has already been seen to matter.

- **Rigid attachment and centred grasp.** Gripper compliance and pendulum modes are not modelled, and every reported grasp is within the attachment tolerance of the thrust axis. Larger offsets are outside the claim. The realised vertical arm differs from the nominal prior by up to about 10 % per flight and is not measured per flight.

- **Single gripper geometry.** Every cohort flight uses the shortened arm. The inertia ratio grows with the square of the arm, and the earlier 0.47 m geometry, at which the heavier payload exceeds the inner-loop scaling cap, is outside the claim.

- **Confounded disturbances.** A sustained vertical updraft or downdraft is intrinsically indistinguishable from a payload change on a collective-thrust-only residual, and the mass-only interface has no second channel to separate them. Wind is not evaluated.

5.9.1 Thrust-map calibration: an analytical sensitivity

The mass channel recovers m_T from an *absolute* thrust, so it inherits the calibration error of k_f directly — nothing in the formulation cancels it. The relation is analytical: a relative error ε in the estimator's thrust coefficient scales the reconstructed thrust by $1+\varepsilon$, and through (3.7) the identified mass by the same factor. At $\varepsilon = \pm 5\%$ and the 2.2 kg composite mass of the lighter condition this is ± 0.11 kg — three-quarters of the 0.15 kg payload, and between four

and five times the 0.024 kg confirmation threshold. The arithmetic predicts two failures: a coefficient reading low may leave the payload unrecognised, and one reading high may leave a phantom payload after release, so that confirmation never arrives. The direction matters: the second degrades toward UNRESOLVED, which is safe, the first toward an unrecognised payload, which is not. For the estimator's mass these remain predictions; no mismatch was applied to the estimator. The force-balance detector of Section 4.7.5 has the same one-for-one sensitivity, and a $\pm 10\,\%$ error in its thrust was flown: both predicted failures occurred, a miss ending in UNRESOLVED on one side and, on the other, a lighter payload read as absent, which silently disabled the uncommanded-loss watchdog (Section 5.6.4).

5.9.2 Experiments designed but not run

Three experiments were designed for this dissertation but not run in the evaluated configuration. They are listed so that their absence is explicit; no result is claimed for any of them.

- **Thrust-map mismatch in the estimator** (k_f scaled by 0.95 and 1.05 in the estimator only). Its expected effect is the analytical sensitivity of Section 5.9.1; only the release detector's thrust was perturbed in the campaign (Section 5.6.4).
- **Partial payload loss** (four 0.05 kg boxes, three removed one at a time without a signal, against a no-loss control arm). This is the case a binary attached/detached abstraction cannot represent at all, and the one where a continuous interface would be expected to differ in kind.
- **Window-seed comparison** (the window force balance (4.20) against the instantaneous seed (4.17) at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$). The only evidence for the window seed is the development observation of Section 4.3.5.

Unsignaled loss, the fourth scenario outside the cohort, was flown in the release campaign under the force-balance rule (Section 5.6.3); it has not been flown under the mass-evidence rules, for the reason given in Section 5.3.2. The open experiments are taken up in Chapter 6.

5.9.3 Missing baselines

The release arms of Table 5.2 and arm D isolate release semantics. A fixed-parameter predictive controller and an $\mathscr{L}_1$-type controller were compared with the MHE controller in the release campaign (Section 5.6.5), under one lifecycle and with the inertia-floor and inner-loop scheduling shared by all three. Because the $\mathscr{L}_1$ arm uses the same residual law as the evaluated configuration, that comparison isolates the payload model rather than the presence of adaptation; it found no consistent tracking benefit in carry. The evaluation still does *not* include incremental nonlinear dynamic inversion [21], the full $\mathscr{L}_1$-adaptive NMPC of [20] with its rotational channel, or a change-detection procedure such as CUSUM [32] applied to the same signals under a matched false-alarm constraint. The last is the largest remaining gap for the release question: the force-balance rule is compared with the mass-evidence rules and with command-triggered acceptance, not with an optimised detector.

5.9.4 Reproducibility

Reproducibility is handled by construction rather than by discipline. Every run records its code identity, the resolved value of every environment switch that affects behaviour, the problem dimensions, horizons, weights, bounds, event timestamps, random seed and solver statistics. Runs terminated by numerical failure remain in the denominator. The evidence-score function used online and the one used in offline replay are the same function, so a recorded flight can be

re-scored without re-implementing the logic.

The code identity is recorded as a repository revision *plus* a frozen patch of uncommitted changes and an archive of untracked files, not as a single commit. The cohort was not run from a clean revision: the working tree contained uncommitted edits to this dissertation's sources, which do not affect flight code, and the autopilot source tree contained modifications belonging to an unrelated project. Each flight's record accordingly marks an exact-commit claim as prohibited. Every flight can nevertheless be rebuilt exactly from the recorded revision, patch and archive, and that is the claim made here; no cohort result should be cited as having been produced by a particular commit.

The flight code of every reported batch also carried three further controller parameters, the slot of a rotational lumped-disturbance channel that had been tried in development and rejected; they were held at zero in every flight. They were removed from the code after the campaign. On twelve fixed test problems, including two that end at the iteration limit, the controller's solution with and without them was bitwise identical, iteration counts included, so the removal changes the description of the controller in Section 4.2.3 and not its behaviour.

5.10 Chapter Summary

This chapter addressed the fifth research objective with a frozen, randomised cohort of 120 software-in-the-loop flights, two smaller frozen ablations and a second frozen campaign of 312 flights. The answers to the five questions are, in brief: the mass is accurate in loaded hover and collapses periodically in sustained manoeuvre at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ (Q1); every one of the 118 eligible releases was accepted, 2.3 s to 3.2 s after physical detachment (Q2); under delayed detachment, the evidence-gated arms never accepted a release while the payload was attached, whereas the command-triggered arm always did (Q3); the always-

on confirmation accepted 114 releases that had not happened during high-speed carry, and the command-armed confirmation none, at no cost in delay (Q4); and the release arm did not change tracking, while the residual specific force improved it without changing the mass bias (Q5). In the campaign, a force-balance release rule enabled by the command or by an airborne-load watchdog accepted no release during carry in 240 flights, never accepted before a delayed detachment, detected 24 of 24 uncommanded losses and accepted none of 24 jammed releases; it is, however, sensitive to the thrust map in both directions, and a 10 % underestimate disabled the watchdog for the lighter payload. Adaptation clearly beat the fixed-parameter controller in carry, while estimating the mass gave no consistent tracking benefit over the residual alone. All of these results were obtained with the full-state estimator. Its replacement by the reduced velocity–mass estimator is supported by a replay of the 312 campaign flights, in which the reduced estimate had the smaller loaded mass error in every nominal flight, and by a thrust-map smoke test in which its health check flagged the under-reading map and held the controller's model; the paired closed-loop comparison is reported in Section 5.7.3. Beyond that replay and four smoke flights, no estimator-side thrust-map, partial-loss or hardware result exists. Chapter 6 draws the conclusions these results support, and only those.

Chapter 6

Conclusion and Future Work

6.1 Summary

This dissertation treated payload grasp and release on a quadrotor as one estimation-and-control problem. Chapter 3 reduced a centred rigid payload to a single online parameter, the composite mass, from which the roll and pitch inertia increment follows, and assigned the identification of that mass to the translational channel. Chapter 4 built a moving-horizon estimator driven by a wrench reconstructed from rotor speeds, a predictive controller updated continuously from one health-gated estimate, and a release lifecycle in which acceptance of a release is gated on evidence — from the estimator, or from an independent force balance. Chapter 5 evaluated the system in PX4/Gazebo software-in-the-loop simulation with a frozen cohort of 120 flight attempts, two smaller frozen ablations and a second frozen campaign of 312 flights. The findings below answer the five research objectives against that evidence.

6.2 Principal Findings

Objective 1 — a single-parameter payload structure.

- **Answer.** For a rigid payload on the thrust axis, the roll and pitch inertia increment is μr_z^2, a function of the composite mass and a nominal arm, so the composite mass is the only payload quantity that needs online identification; the inertia follows from it and vanishes with it.
- **Evidence.** The derivation of Section 3.3; the structure is implemented in both optimisers and used in every reported flight.
- **Boundary.** A centred grasp within the alignment tolerance, a point-mass payload, and a nominal arm whose realised value varies by up to -14 to $+23$ percent in inertia (Section 3.6).
- **Not established.** Eccentric grasps; and whether estimating the inertia directly would perform better or worse, which was not compared.

Objective 2 — identifying the mass.

- **Answer.** The estimator identifies the composite mass accurately in loaded hover, but under sustained manoeuvre the estimate is biased low and periodically collapses toward the bare airframe. Both statements describe the full-state estimator with which the campaigns were flown. Carrying the payload inertia in it as a lagged parameter reduces that bias without removing it; the deployed reduced estimator, which does not integrate the rotational dynamics, removes most of it in replay.
- **Evidence.** In the frozen cohort the per-flight loaded-hover error lay between $-0.44\,\%$ and $-0.10\,\%$; the loaded figure-eight bias had medians of $-1.0\,\%$ at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and $-4.1\,\%$ and $-3.3\,\%$ at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, with dips to the mass lower bound and a median collapse fraction of 0.38 for the lighter payload (Section 5.5.1). In a sixteen-flight comparison the lagged inertia reduced the loaded bias from $-8.9\,\%$ to $-4.0\,\%$ (Section 5.7.2). Replayed on the 312 campaign flights, the reduced estimator lowered the median loaded mass error from $0.036\,\mathrm{kg}$ to $0.013\,\mathrm{kg}$, smaller in every one of the

264 nominal flights, and returned to the empty value after every release, where the full-state estimate stayed about 2 % low in 57 flights at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ (Section 5.7.3).

- **Boundary.** Simulated rotor speeds are exact and the plant uses the thrust law the estimator inverts; the shortened arm; payloads of 0.15 kg to 0.30 kg.
- **Not established.** The full cause of the collapse; the reduced estimator under realistic attitude noise, which the simulator's odometry does not exercise; the effect of a thrust-coefficient error, which is known only analytically (Section 5.9.1); and the advantage of the window seed, whose comparison was not run.

Objective 3 — a continuously updated controller.

- **Answer.** The controller completed every eligible flight without divergence while consuming the estimate continuously. The residual specific force improves tracking but does not improve the mass estimate or change the lifecycle. The held inertia floor protects the inner loop through the collapse, but for that reason the cohort cannot show the effect of estimate-driven inner-loop scheduling on its own.
- **Evidence.** No eligible cohort flight diverged (Table 5.4). In the 48-flight ablation the residual reduced loaded figure-eight RMSE by 22 % to 31 % and removed a mean vertical sag of up to 44 mm, with no difference in mass bias, confirmation delay or carry-phase confirmations (Section 5.7.1). The inner-loop scale stayed at the floor value of 2.34 through every loaded figure-eight (Section 5.8.3). In the release campaign, with the lifecycle and inner loop shared, the MHE controller had a smaller loaded RMSE than a fixed-parameter controller in all 24 pairs, by 0.04 m to 0.14 m at the median, and no consistent difference in carry from an

$\mathscr{L}_1$ controller that uses the residual alone (Section 5.6.5).

- **Boundary.** The inertia ratio at the shortened arm stays below the scaling cap; with the earlier, longer arm it would not.
- **Not established.** A tracking benefit of estimating the mass over the lumped residual alone — the only consistent difference was a smaller post-release peak at $2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, of 6 mm to 17 mm; any benefit over incremental dynamic inversion or full $\mathscr{L}_1$-adaptive NMPC, which were not run; and the contribution of the continuous inner-loop scaling, which the held floor masked during carry and which all three controllers of the comparison shared.

Objective 4 — separating a release command from a physical detachment.

- **Answer.** Gating release acceptance on evidence separates "the command was issued" from "the payload has left". On the mass evidence, only consulting it after the command — *command-armed, estimator-confirmed detachment* — is sound; consulting it throughout carry is not, because the mass evidence fails in manoeuvre. With independent force-balance evidence, which does not pass through the mass estimate, the rule can in addition be enabled by a watchdog armed on airborne load: it then also detects a load lost without a command, without false acceptances in carry. That rule's weakness is the thrust map, not the manoeuvre.
- **Evidence.** Every eligible release was accepted, 2.3 s to 3.2 s after physical detachment. Under delayed detachment the command-triggered arm accepted early in 24 of 24 flights, about 4 s early, and the evidence-gated arms in none of 47. The always-on rule accepted 114 releases that had not happened, in 20 of 32 flights at $4\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$; the command-armed rule accepted none in its 23 flights and confirmed real detachments no later (Sections 5.5.2–5.5.4). In the release campaign the force-balance rule ac-

cepted no release during carry in any of 240 flights (228 with the watchdog armed), none early in 36 delayed-detachment flights, against 36 of 36 for command-triggered acceptance, and confirmed real detachments 1.9 s to 2.5 s after they occurred. It detected 24 of 24 uncommanded losses 1.8 s to 2.5 s after detachment, resetting the payload geometry and inner-loop scale each time, and accepted none of 24 releases with a jammed gripper, all of which ended in a braked hover (Section 5.6).

- **Boundary.** For the command-armed rule, a release command must exist. For both rules, the detachment delay tested was 4 s. The force-balance rule assumes a thrust map accurate to better than 10 %: overestimated by that much it missed every release, safely; underestimated by as much it read the lighter payload as absent, so that the loss watchdog never armed (Section 5.6.4).

- **Not established.** A tracking or survival advantage of evidence-gated acceptance — none was detected, and none was expected, since the model's mass follows the estimate in every arm; what the delayed-detachment experiment shows is lifecycle correctness. Also not established: uncommanded loss under the mass-evidence rules, which was not run; the force-balance rule under delayed detachment with a thrust-map error, where it is expected to accept early; detection of partial loss; and its performance relative to an optimised change detector.

Objective 5 — evaluation and its scope.

- **Answer.** The interface was evaluated with randomised blocks, complete reporting of every attempt, two targeted ablations and an explicit account of its failure modes.

- **Evidence.** 120 attempts, 118 eligible, two exclusions both explained (Table 5.4); a second campaign of 312 attempts, all eligible, with no replace-

ment flight needed (Section 5.6.1); the evidence sources and their standing are listed in Table 5.3.

- **Boundary.** All system-level evidence is software-in-the-loop.
- **Not established.** Hardware validity; a comparison with incremental dynamic inversion or with a change detector under a matched false-alarm constraint; and the designed estimator-side thrust-map, partial-loss and window-seed experiments, which were not run (Section 5.9.2).

6.3 Limitations

The limitations that bound the findings are collected here once. All system-level evidence is software-in-the-loop, with exact rotor speeds and a plant that generates thrust by the same law the estimator inverts. The attachment is rigid and the grasp centred; eccentric grasps, gripper compliance, pendulum modes and flexible loads are not modelled, and a sustained vertical gust is intrinsically confounded with a payload change on a collective-thrust residual. Every flight uses one gripper geometry, whose nominal arm differs from the realised one by an unmeasured amount. The attach-time inertia floor is armed whether or not the grasp succeeds. Under the mass-evidence rules it is ended only by the release command, so a load lost without a command leaves it in place; under the force-balance rule a detected loss ends it, but detection depends on the thrust map. The release command is not gated on estimator health. The evaluated configuration includes settings that are not the defaults of the experiment entry points, and the results are claims about that configuration.

6.4 Future Work

The following directions are ranked by how much they would change what can be claimed.

1. **Manoeuvre-robust mass estimation.** Every weakness of the lifecycle follows from the collapse of the loaded estimate in manoeuvre. Calibrating the airframe's rotational model — inertia, rotor-drag moment and torque bias — would reduce the error that reaches the mass through the attitude, and might eventually let the rotational channel contribute information instead of error. The designed but unrun partial-loss and window-seed experiments belong here: both test the estimator rather than the lifecycle.

2. **Calibration-robust release evidence and health-gated release.** The force-balance rule showed that evidence independent of the mass estimate removes the carry-phase false acceptances and allows uncommanded loss to be detected and flown through. Its remaining weakness is the absolute thrust map. Evidence that is insensitive to a constant thrust-coefficient error — for example the relative step in m_{acc} against the value recorded after lift, or an online calibration of k_f in empty hover — should be tested with thrust-map error and delayed detachment crossed, the combination the campaign did not fly. The release command should also not be issued while the estimator is unhealthy.

3. **Change-detection and rotational baselines.** A comparison against CUSUM or a related procedure on the same signals, under a matched false-alarm constraint, would show whether persistence on a filtered score is near the achievable detection performance. Since the mass estimate gave no consistent tracking benefit over the lumped residual in carry, its value should next be tested where the residual cannot substitute for it — in the rotational channel, with the inner-loop scaling no longer shared between the arms.

4. **Thrust-map robustness and hardware transfer.** The one-for-one sensitivity to the thrust coefficient, measured for the release detector at $\pm 10\,\%$, should be measured for the estimator's mass with the designed $\pm 5\,\%$ mismatch and then against motor-stand calibration of k_f and k_m. Transfer should proceed through tethered hover with the estimator running open loop, centred pickup, and only then dynamic flight, with electronic-speed-controller telemetry replacing simulated rotor speeds and a supervisor gating every stage.

6.5 Closing Remark

The result that generalises beyond this vehicle concerns the relation between an estimate and a decision. A continuously estimated mass can drive the model of a predictive controller without any event, and doing so kept every flight of the frozen cohort stable. Deciding that a payload has gone is a different matter: the same estimate that is accurate enough to adapt a model in hover is not reliable enough to declare a release in manoeuvre. In this work that decision was safe either when the estimate was asked a narrower question — whether a release that has already been commanded has physically happened — or when it was not asked at all, and the release question was put to a measurement that does not depend on it. The second form also detects a load lost without a command; it moves the weak point from the manoeuvre to the calibration of the thrust map.

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Appendix A

Implemented Optimal Control Problem Configuration

Table A.1: NMPC configuration (evaluated configuration).

State dimension	13
Input dimension	4
Runtime parameter dimension	23
Prediction stages	$N = 20$
Sampling interval	$\Delta t = 0.05\,\mathrm{s}$
Prediction horizon	1.0 s
Solve rate	20 Hz; setpoints published at 50 Hz
Integrator	Explicit RK4
NLP method	Full SQP with merit backtracking
QP solver	Partial-condensing HPIPM
Hessian	Gauss–Newton
Thrust box	$[1.27\,\mathrm{N},\ 31.35\,\mathrm{N}]$ (actuator envelope)
Torque box	$\pm 0.5\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ roll/pitch, $\pm 0.2\,\mathrm{N\,m}$ yaw
Bryson tolerances (state)	0.1 m, 0.3 m/s, 0.05, 0.3 rad/s
Bryson tolerances (input)	2.0 N, 0.5 N m, 0.2 N m
Terminal scaling	$20\times$ pos., $1\times$ vel., $2\times$ att., $0.2\times$ rate

Table A.2: MHE configuration. The full-state estimator is the evaluated configuration of the cohort and the release campaign; the reduced estimator is the deployed default since 5 November 2026; the prior-free column lists the values taken by the full-state ablation of Section 4.3.3.

	Full-state (evaluated)	**Reduced (deployed)**	**Prior-free ablation**
Model selection[a]	`full` (library default)	`reduced` (entry-point default)	`full`
State dimension	14 (x, m_T)	4 ($\boldsymbol{v}$, m_T)	14
Process-noise dimension	13 (physical states only)	3 (velocity)	13
Runtime parameter dimension	7 (wrench; lagged ΔJ; $c_x = c_y = 0$)	5 (measured unit quaternion; T_{phys})	7
Measurement residual	13 ((4.7))	3, velocity ((4.4))	13
Weights	(4.12)–(4.14)	(4.15) (velocity and mass blocks of the former)	as full-state
Estimation stages / interval	$N = 20$ / 0.1 s	same	same
Mass box[b]	$[0.95\,m_B,\ 5.0\,\text{kg}]$	$[0.70\,m_B,\ 5.0\,\text{kg}]$	$[0.2\,\text{kg},\ 5.0\,\text{kg}]$
Mass-health band	none	(4.16), $[1.964\,\text{kg}, 2.464\,\text{kg}]$; recover after 10 solves	none
Mass arrival σ	3.16 kg	3.16 kg	1000 kg
Initial iterate	window force balance (4.20)	same	same
Estimator inertia increment[c]	lagged, (3.20) (entry-point default; library default omitted)	none	lagged
Mass-only selection[d]	on (entry-point default; library default off)	required	same
Stage weighting β_j	residual-triggered de-weighting enabled, uniform in effect (Section 4.3.6)	same, rebuilt on the reduced blocks	same
Solver failure	re-anchor after 5 consecutive failures; seed adopted as estimate	re-initialise after 5; last valid estimate held, frame unhealthy	as full-state
Output filter	first order, $\tau = 0.25\,\text{s}$	same	same
NLP / QP method	Full SQP / partial-condensing HPIPM	same	same

Switches: [a] `MHE_MODEL_VARIANT`; [b] reduced: `MHE_REDUCED_M_MIN`, `MHE_REDUCED_M_MAX`; [c] `MHE_DJ_EXT=1`; [d] `MHE_ESTIMATE_MOMENT=0`.

Table A.3: Payload interface, lifecycle and task settings (evaluated configuration).

Frame fields	m_T, ΔJ_{diag}, J_{diag}, γ, health, solution age (offset fields unused)
Vertical-arm prior r_z	-0.27 m nominal, both optimisers (realised 0.25 m to 0.30 m)
Input freshness / solution freshness	0.30 s / 0.30 s
Consumer receive-age limit	0.35 s
Controller-side filter τ	0.20 s
Slew limits (m_T / ΔJ)	0.60 kg/s / 0.080 kg m^2/s
Evidence-score mode	mass only (no inertia factor)
Payload-mass score thresholds	$(0.015, 0.060)$ kg
Confirmation	$\gamma \geq 0.90$ held 1.0 s
Presence entry / exit	$m_P > 0.09$ kg for 2 s / $m_P < 0.02$ kg for 5 s in quiet flight
Quiet-flight test	$\|\boldsymbol{\omega}\| \leq 0.15\,\text{rad s}^{-1}$, $\|\boldsymbol{v}_{xy}\| \leq 0.20\,\text{m s}^{-1}$
UNRESOLVED timeout / brake duration	12 s / 3 s
Body-rate scale cap / dead band	5.0 / 0.08
Body-rate scale τ / rise / recover	0.5 s / 4.0 s^{-1} / 1.5 s^{-1}
Body-rate headroom fraction / hard limit	0.95 / 2.0 rad s^{-1}
Attach inertia bootstrap	envelope 0.30 kg ($\Delta J = 0.0191$ kg m^2, $\kappa = 2.34$); fade 0.5 s; hold until command†
Residual specific force†	$a = 10$, $\omega_c = 0.5$ rad s^{-1}, nominal mass $\hat{m}$
Relative alignment†	tolerance 0.012 m, wait ≤ 4 s
Figure-eight yaw smoothing†	on
Controller offset compensation	off ($\boldsymbol{c}_{xy} \equiv \mathbf{0}$)
Release	at the figure-eight tip after 45 s loaded carry

† Set explicitly by the cohort driver; off at the experiment entry points. The geometry-release mode, moment-based offset and release options and moment over-range re-anchoring appear in launch records but are inert in the mass-only form; the residual event trigger is active but rarely changes the stage weights (Section 4.3.6).

Appendix B

Experiment Record Template

Each run stores the following metadata with its log, so that any reported figure can be regenerated from retained data:

1. code identity — repository revision, a frozen patch of uncommitted changes and an archive of untracked files, with an explicit verdict on whether an exact-commit claim is permitted — together with the build timestamp and generated-solver identity;
2. the *resolved value* of every environment switch that affects behaviour — not only those explicitly set, since a default that is never written to disk is the commonest way for a batch to become unattributable;
3. airframe mass and inertia calibration, rotor coefficients and the fixed actuator limits;
4. payload mass and attachment geometry for offline scoring, together with evidence that neither reached the adaptive path;
5. trajectory parameters, grasp and release phase, and random seed;
6. both horizons, weights, bounds and solver options;
7. topic rates and measured end-to-end latency;
8. the complete lifecycle event trace, with timestamps for every state transition and every confirmation;

9. termination reason, solver status sequence and constraint activity.

Results tables carry one row per run in the retained data, not only an aggregate, so that failed runs cannot disappear during manual selection. Runs terminated by numerical failure remain in the denominator; any manual exclusion must name a pre-declared logging or infrastructure fault.